Media as Political Currency*

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Abstract

Executives who allocate broadcast licenses hold a resource fiscal transfers cannot match: it keeps working after it is granted. In Brazil's 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly the president licensed radio and television at will while Congress wrote a new Constitution. We link the administrative record of radio and television grants to every 1986 federal-deputy candidate. In a close-election regression discontinuity design, winning a seat raised concession receipt by 14.0 percentage points, and 18.8 points among the governing coalition, and none at twelve placebo cutoffs. Recipients align with the government 36 percentage points more on institutional votes than on ideological ones, a gap measured within deputy. The incumbency premium is 26.2 percentage points larger for media-owning legislators than for non-owners. A probabilistic-voting model of executive-legislative bargaining predicts all three patterns: broadcast concessions are productive political capital, paying their electoral return in combination with office.

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1 Introduction

Leaked archives from Peru show that Montesinos valued control of a single television network at roughly 100 times the price of a congressional vote (McMillan and Zoido, 2004). The strategic exchange of resources for legislative support is a central feature of democratic politics. Executives frequently rely on fiscal transfers and other forms of distributive spending to build and maintain congressional coalitions (Golden and Min, 2013; Stokes et al., 2013; Cruz and Keefer, 2015; Bonilla-Mejía and Morales, 2024; Brollo and Nannicini, 2012). Together, this literature shows that targeted benefits can shape legislative behavior, discipline coalition partners, and strengthen governing majorities. A parallel body of research highlights the political importance of the media, documenting how news exposure and media bias affect electoral behavior, political accountability, and long-run institutional development (Strömberg, 2015; Snyder and Strömberg, 2010; DellaVigna and Kaplan, 2007; Enikolopov et al., 2011; Grossman et al., 2022; Chong et al., 2017; Prat, 2018; DellaVigna and La Ferrara, 2015; Ferraz and Finan, 2008), and showing that executives who can capture media reporting gain substantial political leverage (Besley and Prat, 2006; Durante et al., 2019).

Yet despite extensive evidence that media shapes electoral and policy outcomes, we know almost nothing about how politicians come to control media in the first place and whether executives strategically allocate this control to influence the political process. Clean quantitative evidence on legal, public-discretion allocation in a transitional democracy remains scarce. Building on theoretical work that models media capture as favor exchange between politicians and outlet owners (Szeidl and Szucs, 2021), this paper provides direct empirical evidence on the allocation side of that exchange.[1]

Informational assets such as broadcast licenses constitute a distinct class of political

[1]Boas and Hidalgo (2011) document, using an RD design, that incumbents are more likely to obtain community-radio licenses and that ownership raises vote shares—evidence on electoral behavior that complements our focus on the executive-legislative allocation mechanism.

resource from the fiscal transfers studied in the existing literature. Fiscal transfers are *consumptive*: the benefit is delivered, appropriated by the district, and then exhausted. Broadcast licenses are *productive* capital: they generate an informational stream that sustains the recipient's electoral position as long as the holder remains politically active, at no recurring fiscal cost to the Executive. When a transitional executive faces a legislature with the power to write new constitutional rules, broadcast concessions therefore combine the targeting precision of individual-level patronage with the durability of a standing electoral asset. We show that a candidate who barely won a seat in 1986 was 14.0 percentage points more likely to receive a broadcast concession over the following two years, and that the return to holding office is 26.2 percentage points larger for candidates who already owned a station—the empirical signatures the productive-political-capital framework predicts.[2]

We study this mechanism in Brazil's 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly, where executive discretion over media licensing was wide and the informational value of local radio was substantial. The mid-1980s in Brazil represented a period of profound institutional uncertainty, with an unpopular executive, a fragmented Congress, and the politically consequential task of drafting a new Constitution (Mainwaring, 1999). At that time, Brazilian regulation granted the president substantial discretion over the allocation and renewal of radio and television licenses (Lopes, 2018; Motter et al., 2019). Moreover, in many regions radio stations were the dominant source of local political information, giving their owners considerable influence over voter perceptions. This combination of discretion and informational power created a setting in which broadcast concessions functioned as targeted political transfers, exchanged for legislative support during a foundational moment of constitutional redesign.

To study this executive–legislative exchange, we assemble new data linking all radio and television concessions granted between 1982 and the 2000s to individual politicians.

[2]The closest empirical antecedent is Bonilla-Mejía and Morales (2024), who use the same close-election RDD design to show that Colombian legislators trade votes for infrastructure projects. Section 3 develops the structural features that separate broadcast concessions from that pork-patronage framework.

We combine these administrative records with detailed electoral data from the 1986 Federal Deputy election, digitized roll-call votes from the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (NCA), longitudinal election results through 1998, and extensive biographical information on candidates, their families, and their prior media involvement. This dataset allows us to follow every candidate for the NCA—winners and losers—and track whether, when, and what type of broadcast outlets they acquired.

To guide our empirical analysis, we develop a simple theoretical framework in which the Executive allocates media concessions to maximize legislative support. In the model, owning a media outlet increases a legislator's electoral valence, reducing the electoral cost of siding with the government. In equilibrium, the Executive targets legislators who are ideologically proximate, as they require lower compensating transfers.

Our empirical strategy combines three designs. For *allocation* we use a narrow-margin Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD) within party–state coalitions in the 1986 election: candidates who barely won became members of the NCA, while those who barely lost did not. For *legislative response* we estimate within-deputy partial correlations on the 455-deputy roll-call sample: the contrast between institutional and ideological topics differences out deputy-level selection on overall pro-government disposition. For *office–media complementarity* we estimate the close-election incumbency effect separately by predetermined media ownership—holdings observed up to and including the origin election—and compare the two, under the framework of Becker et al. (2013).

Our first result is allocation: barely elected deputies were 14.0 percentage points more likely to receive a radio or TV concession during 1987–88, and the effect is 18.8 points among candidates of the governing PMDB–PFL coalition, roughly a third larger than in the full sample, against an estimate indistinguishable from zero on the left opposition. Twelve placebo cutoffs displaced from the seat threshold yield null effects.

The second is legislative response. Recipients align with the Executive 32.8 percentage

points more on institutional than on ideological constitutional items, and 36.0 points more once deputy fixed effects are absorbed, so that each deputy's alignment on the two blocks of votes is compared with his or her own. Because the contrast is taken within deputy, any characteristic that makes a legislator uniformly more pro-government shifts both index values equally and cancels.

The third is office–media complementarity. A broadcast license is worth something to a legislator through the platform it amplifies: a defeated candidate who owns a station has no legislative record for it to cover and no public position to attach a name to. Winning a seat should therefore be worth more to a media owner than to a non-owner. Estimating the incumbency effect separately by predetermined media ownership, we find that narrowly winning raises the probability of winning the next federal election by 42.7 percentage points among candidates who already held a broadcast concession and by 16.4 points among those who did not—a difference of 26.2 points (s.e. 5.6), significant at the one percent level in every specification. A fiscal transfer is appropriated at delivery and retains its value to the recipient whether or not office is retained, so a patronage account predicts no ownership gradient in the incumbency premium. An informational asset yields its return only in combination with office, so the productive-capital account predicts the gradient we estimate.

This paper contributes to three strands of the literature. First, we advance research on how media structure shapes political competition (e.g., Strömberg, 2004; Gentzkow et al., 2011; Gavazza et al., 2018) and how politician-owned media produces durable electoral advantages (Durante et al., 2019; Barone et al., 2015; Cavgias et al., 2024). Boas and Hidalgo (2011) is the closest predecessor, on community-radio licenses obtained by incumbents. A related demand-side literature shows that media disciplines politicians: press coverage raises voter information (Snyder and Strömberg, 2010) and audit publicity deters corruption (Ferraz and Finan, 2008). We study the supply side of the same relationship: politicians captured broadcast licenses before that discipline could operate, shaping

the information environment to their advantage.[3] We extend this to a setting where licenses are allocated directly by the national Executive as a legislative-bargaining tool, and provide causal evidence on the allocation margin.

Second, the paper speaks to the literature on patronage and distributive politics (e.g., Golden and Min, 2013; Stokes et al., 2013; Cruz and Keefer, 2015; Bonilla-Mejía and Morales, 2024). We show that informational assets constitute a structurally distinct class of political currency, with testable implications for how the recipient's political career evolves—implications we bring to the data in section 6. The theoretical structure follows the favor-exchange environment of Szeidl and Szucs (2021) with the government as allocator and legislators as recipients.

Third, the office–media complementarity result separates the productive-capital interpretation from pure patronage. This ownership conditionality connects our allocation margin to the literature on politician-owned media (Durante et al., 2019; Barone et al., 2015; Cavgias et al., 2024), and identifies the office–ownership interaction, rather than the level of the premium, as the object that distinguishes informational assets from cash.

The remainder of this study is organized as follows. Section 2 explains why Brazil's transition to democracy—and the 1987–88 Constituent Assembly in particular—created a rare opportunity to observe how executives deploy control over broadcasting licenses. Section 3 formalizes the mechanism motivating our analysis, presenting a simple framework in which media concessions raise legislators' electoral valence and lower the ideological cost of supporting the Executive. Section 4 describes the data sources and variable construction, detailing how we link electoral records, media concession data, and legislative voting behavior. Section 5 sets out the three designs, and Section 6 tests the model's predictions with them—allocation (the close-election RDD on concession receipt), legislative response (the within-deputy contrast between institutional and ideological roll-call

[3] We do not study whether recipients adjusted editorial content after receiving a concession; evidence on the content channel in related settings is provided by Gentzkow and Shapiro (2010).

votes), and office–media complementarity (the ownership gradient in the incumbency premium). Finally, Section 8 concludes by discussing the broader implications of our findings for democratic accountability, institutional design, and the political economy of media control.

2 Background

2.1 Broadcasting concessions and the regulatory framework

Broadcasting concessions. A broadcasting concession (*outorga*) in Brazil is a government grant of the exclusive right to operate a radio or television station on a specified frequency in a specified municipality, typically for ten years (radio) or fifteen years (television), renewable. Because the electromagnetic spectrum is a finite public resource, a concession is an economically valuable asset: it carries a barrier to entry (competitors are prohibited from broadcasting on the same frequency in the same market), an advertising revenue stream, and, in the local media markets that dominate Brazilian radio in particular, a near-monopolistic position on political information. For politicians, the concession offers a second, distinct dividend—the ability to shape the informational environment in which their own electoral performance is judged—which is a margin that standard commercial valuation of the asset does not capture. The empirical strategy in this paper exploits precisely this combination of economic and political value.

The allocation mechanism distinguishes the Brazilian setting from the OECD norm. In most large democracies, broadcasting licenses are allocated by independent regulatory bodies insulated from executive discretion (Hallin and Mancini, 2004). Brazil is unusual in that the president had direct discretionary authority over AM and television concessions, with only a thin technical filter from the Ministry of Communications and congressional ratification serving largely as a rubber stamp. This concentration of allocation authority

in the presidency is what makes concessions a natural instrument of executive-legislative bargaining.[4]

Brazil's system of media regulation historically granted the federal executive extensive discretion over the allocation and renewal of radio and television licenses. The main legal framework from the 1960s[5] allowed the president to designate the holder of AM radio and national TV concessions from among technically qualified applicants, while the Ministry of Communications exercised similar discretion over FM broadcasters (Motter et al., 2019). During the military regime, Decree-Law 236/1967 expanded these powers by allowing the state to fine, suspend, or revoke licenses without judicial oversight, a threat frequently used to discipline media outlets even though few revocations became formal actions (Lopes, 2018). These institutions created a regulatory environment in which broadcast concessions were highly valuable and heavily dependent on presidential favor.

2.2 The 1986 Election and the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly

By the early 1980s, Brazil was undergoing a process of redemocratization, with the military gradually transferring political authority back to civilian leaders after two decades in power. President José Sarney, who unexpectedly assumed office after Tancredo Neves's death, inherited a fragile economic environment marked by high inflation and the eventual failure of successive stabilization plans. Politically, Sarney lacked a cohesive partisan base and governed a Congress characterized by extreme fragmentation and weak party discipline. The largest governing party, the PMDB (Brazilian Democratic Movement Party), was a broad and internally heterogeneous centrist coalition that had served as the main

[4]Qualitative evidence from Peru under Fujimori suggests that political capture of broadcast media can be economically substantial even under formally competitive arrangements: McMillan and Zoido (2004) document that Montesinos valued the editorial line of a single television network at roughly 100 times the price of a congressional vote—the authoritarian-exchange analogue of the legal-democratic mechanism studied here.

[5]Specifically the 1962 Código Brasileiro de Telecomunicações and the 1963 Regulamento dos Serviços de Radiodifusão. A contemporary example of political discretion in the allocation of radio concessions is reproduced in Figure C1.

legal opposition under the military regime. The PFL (Liberal Front Party), formally a center-right party and an important coalition partner, was composed largely of politicians who had supported the military regime and then repositioned themselves during the transition. Both parties exhibited substantial rates of legislative defection and weak internal cohesion (Mainwaring, 1999), complicating the Executive's efforts to build stable majorities.

The nationwide elections held in November 1986 selected the members of the National Constituent Assembly (NCA), composed of 487 deputies and 72 senators, and were strongly influenced by the temporary popularity generated by the *Plano Cruzado*, an ambitious price-freeze stabilization program. Shortly after the election, however, inflation resurged and the plan quickly collapsed, leading to a sharp and well-documented decline in the government's popularity.[6] Although the PMDB–PFL coalition secured a large number of seats, it remained internally divided (Motter et al., 2019). As a result, the Executive needed to assemble majorities vote by vote on several contentious constitutional issues: some were high-stakes institutional questions on which the government held a unified position—most notably the length of the presidential term and the choice of a presidential over a parliamentary system of government—while others split the governing coalition along pre-existing ideological lines, including property rights and agrarian reform.

In this environment, media concessions functioned as a particularly effective political currency. Broadcast outlets were economically attractive and electorally powerful given the central role of radio and television as sources of political information in Brazil, especially in areas with limited newspaper circulation (Boas, 2005; Porto, 2003; Lopes, 2018). Local radio stations, in particular, were often the primary venue for political news in smaller municipalities (Lopes, 2018). Historical accounts describe an uptick in the distribution of concessions during periods of intense political bargaining. For example, Motter

[6] Appendix C, and particularly Figure C2, reproduces newspaper headlines from late 1986 to 1988 documenting the collapse of the *Cruzado* plan and the rapid decline in presidential approval.

et al. (2019) documents that during Sarney's presidency, approximately ninety legislators received radio and TV concessions over the course of the NCA. Although these accounts are descriptive and not intended to establish causal patterns, they underscore how valuable media outlets were perceived to be as bargaining instruments in the very period analyzed in this paper.

The phenomenon is not confined to a small number of outliers. Table C1 (Appendix C) lists twelve representative politician-broadcasters whose links to radio or television are documented in archival and secondary sources, including the congressional investigations reconstructed by Motter et al. (2019) and the broadcasting ownership records compiled by Lopes (2018). The cases span ten states and both large governing parties; ownership is frequently registered through spouses, children, or close business associates, a feature that our matching procedure (Section 4) is designed to capture.

The structure of Brazil's media market further magnified the political returns to owning broadcast outlets. Television expanded rapidly during the military regime as part of a broader modernization strategy but evolved into a highly concentrated private market dominated by a small number of conglomerates (Lima, 1988; Motter et al., 2019). A sizable literature documents how media owners have historically used their outlets to promote political allies and reduce the visibility of rivals (Costa and Brener, 1997; Santos and Capparelli, 2005; Stevanim and Santos, 2011). Complementing this qualitative evidence, recent quantitative work shows that owning a radio station increases a politician's vote share (Boas and Hidalgo, 2011; Lopes, 2018) and that voters respond to corruption audits only when local media are not controlled by political elites (Gehrke, 2019). The executive could allocate concessions at will and legislators wanted them; that is the exchange we study.

3 Conceptual Framework

This section develops a one-shot allocation game in which the Executive uses broadcast concessions as discrete, ownership-dependent political capital to secure legislative support during a constitutional bargaining episode. Three features distinguish the framework from canonical pork-patronage models (Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996; Bonilla-Mejía and Morales, 2024): concessions are binary and identity-embodied rather than divisible; legislators face issue-differentiated deviation costs so that the same license can flip an institutional vote but not a distributive one; and the asset yields its electoral return only in combination with office. The framework derives three empirical predictions taken to the data in section 6, drawing on the media-capture environment of Besley and Prat (2006), the government-control-of-media framework of Gehlbach and Sonin (2014), and the political-exchange structure of Groseclose and Snyder Jr. (1996).

Environment. There are N legislators $\ell \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$, each representing a single-member district with median voter ideal point $p_\ell^* \in [0, 1]$ drawn from a continuous distribution F. The Executive E has $K < N$ broadcast licenses available for allocation during the legislative term and announces a (possibly stochastic) allocation rule before votes are cast. We denote the allocation by $b_\ell \in \{0, 1\}$, with $b_\ell = 1$ if legislator ℓ receives a license and 0 otherwise, subject to $\sum_\ell b_\ell \leq K$. The constraint $K < N$ reflects spectrum scarcity: radio frequencies are physically finite, and the Ministério das Comunicações processed concessions through a regulated pipeline (the *Fistel* registry) whose throughput per period was institutionally bounded (Lopes, 2018)—placing the 1987–88 NCA setting clearly in the under-supply regime ($|\mathcal{A}^*| > K$), where the Executive rations within the targetable set.[7]

[7] In the 1987–88 NCA period, roughly 110 of the 487 elected candidates in our RDD sample received a concession, against a governing coalition of approximately 366 PMDB and PFL deputies (historical accounts document approximately 90 across the full NCA membership including senators). An alternative microfoundation treats K as endogenous: the Executive stops granting concessions when the marginal political cost of an additional license equals the marginal legislative benefit. We view spectrum scarcity as the more binding constraint in this setting, but a political-cost model delivers the same qualitative predictions.

The legislature votes on two classes of issues. *Institutional* issues—indexed I—concern the structure of executive power (e.g., system of government, length of presidential term). The Executive has a unified preferred position $g^I \in \{0,1\}$, and voters' preferences on these issues exhibit low ideological salience: knowledge of the issue is thin and partisan priors are weak. *Ideological* issues—indexed D—concern redistribution and the regulation of economic life (e.g., agrarian reform, labor rights, property). The government may or may not have a unified position; voters hold strong, ideologically anchored priors. Each legislator chooses a vote $v_\ell^I, v_\ell^D \in \{0,1\}$.

Electoral game. Reelection is contested between the incumbent ℓ and a challenger who positions at the district median on both issues. Each voter j in district ℓ draws an idiosyncratic preference shock $\varepsilon_j \sim U[-\sigma,\sigma]$, capturing unobserved heterogeneity in political tastes. Voter j supports the incumbent if and only if

$$-\omega^I(v_\ell^I - \hat{v}_j^I)^2 \;-\; \omega^D(v_\ell^D - \hat{v}_j^D)^2 \;+\; \Gamma\, b_\ell \;+\; \varepsilon_j \;\geq\; -\omega^I(\hat{v}_j^I - p_\ell^*)^2 \;-\; \omega^D(\hat{v}_j^D - p_\ell^*)^2, \quad (1)$$

where $(\hat{v}_j^I, \hat{v}_j^D)$ are the voter's ideal positions, $\omega^I < \omega^D$ are issue-specific salience weights—voters discount the institutional dimension—and $\Gamma > 0$ is the valence delivered by the broadcast license through programming, name recognition, and editorial reach. Aggregating over voters in district ℓ, the incumbent's *expected* vote share—the fraction of voters for whom the support condition holds—takes the form

$$s_\ell(v_\ell^I, v_\ell^D, b_\ell) \;=\; \tfrac{1}{2} \;-\; \omega^I\,\Delta_\ell^I(v_\ell^I) \;-\; \omega^D\,\Delta_\ell^D(v_\ell^D) \;+\; \Gamma\, b_\ell, \quad (2)$$

where $\Delta_\ell^j(v_\ell^j) \geq 0$ is the loss in median-voter utility from a vote against district preference on issue j, normalized so that $\Delta_\ell^j(g^j) = 0$ when the Executive's position coincides with the district's.

Legislator's problem. Legislators are office-motivated and choose (v_ℓ^I, v_ℓ^D) to maximize their expected vote share s_ℓ, which is equivalent to maximizing their reelection probability since $\Pr(s_\ell \geq \frac{1}{2})$ is increasing in s_ℓ. The cost of voting with the Executive on issue j when this conflicts with the district median is the lost expected vote share

$$c_\ell^j \;=\; \omega^j \cdot \Delta_\ell^j, \qquad j \in \{I, D\}, \tag{3}$$

which inherits the salience asymmetry $\omega^I < \omega^D$. We make the distributional assumption that Δ_ℓ^I and Δ_ℓ^D are drawn from continuous distributions with bounded supports $\Delta_\ell^I \in [0, \bar{\Delta}^I]$ and $\Delta_\ell^D \in [\underline{\Delta}^D, \bar{\Delta}^D]$ with $\underline{\Delta}^D > 0$, and we restrict the parameter space so that

$$\omega^I \, \bar{\Delta}^I \;\leq\; \Gamma \;<\; \omega^D \, \underline{\Delta}^D. \tag{4}$$

Under (4), $c_\ell^I \leq \Gamma < c_\ell^D$ holds with probability one: a license is valuable enough to flip an institutional vote but not a distributive one. The restriction $\omega^I < \omega^D$ reflects a documented feature of Brazilian electoral politics: distributive issues (agrarian reform, labor rights, property) crystallized sharp ideological cleavages with strongly positioned constituent bases, while institutional questions (system of government, presidential term length) carried low mass salience and were contested primarily among political elites (Pilatti, 2008; Mainwaring, 1999).[8]

Given an allocation b_ℓ, the change in expected vote share from aligning with the Executive on issue j is $\Gamma \, b_\ell - c_\ell^j$, which is positive iff $\Gamma \, b_\ell \geq c_\ell^j$. The legislator's best response is therefore

$$v_\ell^j = g^j \;\iff\; \Gamma \, b_\ell \;\geq\; c_\ell^j. \tag{5}$$

[8]The asymmetry is about *voter* salience in retrospective evaluation, not the Executive's priority ordering—institutional votes were cheap to flip precisely because constituents discounted them, even as the Executive prized them most. Cavgias et al. (2024) show the first post-Assembly presidential election was dominated by economic concerns rather than the institutional choices the Assembly had just made. Formally, the restriction survives the limit $\omega^I \to \omega^D$ provided the supports are separated ($\bar{\Delta}^I < \underline{\Delta}^D$), so it requires only that distributive issues carry *some* additional electoral cost at every point in their support.

By (4), $b_\ell = 1$ flips the institutional vote but not the ideological vote, while $b_\ell = 0$ leaves the legislator at the district median on both. The asymmetry in (4) is the structural counterpart of the empirical issue-heterogeneity result documented in section 6.

Executive's allocation problem. The Executive seeks to maximize the number of institutional votes aligned with g^I.[9] She solves

$$\max_{b \in \{0,1\}^N} \quad \sum_{\ell=1}^{N} \mathbb{1}\left[\Gamma\, b_\ell \geq c_\ell^I\right] \quad \text{s.t.} \quad \sum_{\ell=1}^{N} b_\ell \leq K. \tag{6}$$

The solution to (6) is straightforward: define the *targetable set*

$$\mathcal{A}^* \;=\; \{\ell : c_\ell^I \leq \Gamma\}, \tag{7}$$

which contains every legislator whose institutional vote can be flipped at cost Γ. If $|\mathcal{A}^*| \leq K$ the Executive allocates a license to every $\ell \in \mathcal{A}^*$. If $|\mathcal{A}^*| > K$, any subset of K legislators drawn from $\mathcal{A}^*$ is an equilibrium allocation; the equilibrium vote count is unique.[10]

Equilibrium. In the Subgame-Perfect Nash Equilibrium, the Executive draws from $\mathcal{A}^*$ and recipients vote $v_\ell^I = g^I$; non-recipients vote at the district median p_ℓ^*.

Commitment is a maintained assumption: the Executive announces the allocation schedule before votes are cast, grounded in the public registration of concessions in the *Diário Oficial da União* prior to the relevant constitutional votes.[11]

[9] The ideological dimension is excluded from the objective because the governing coalition held internally divided positions on redistributive issues; the Executive's net gain from securing any one faction's ideological vote was cancelled by the cost of alienating the opposing faction. All qualitative results hold under a weak Executive preference on ideological issues provided $c^D > c^I$.

[10] The within-coalition gradient documented in Table 4 is consistent with any priority rule that rewards ideological proximity; we explore this heterogeneity in section 6.

[11] A retrospective reading—rewarding deputies who already voted loyally—is observationally equivalent given roll-call data alone. We do not model the reputational equilibrium explicitly; the *Diário Oficial* record serves as the institutional microfoundation.

Three testable implications. The equilibrium yields three predictions taken to the data in section 6. All three follow directly from the static allocation game and the electoral game of (1).

Proposition 1 (Targeting)**.** *The set of recipients $\mathcal{A}^*$ contains legislators whose institutional deviation cost c_ℓ^I is below Γ. Equivalently, recipients are concentrated among legislators ideologically proximate to the Executive's institutional position g^I. Legislators distant from g^I on the institutional dimension—typically deep opposition—fall outside $\mathcal{A}^*$ and receive no licenses.*

Proposition 2 (Issue-differentiated voting)**.** *Recipients vote with the Executive on institutional issues but not on ideological issues; non-recipients vote at the district median on both. The recipient–non-recipient gap therefore satisfies*

$$\underbrace{\mathbb{E}[v_\ell^I \mid b_\ell = 1] - \mathbb{E}[v_\ell^I \mid b_\ell = 0]}_{>0 \text{ (large)}} \; - \; \underbrace{\mathbb{E}[v_\ell^D \mid b_\ell = 1] - \mathbb{E}[v_\ell^D \mid b_\ell = 0]}_{\approx 0} \; > \; 0.$$

Proposition 2 follows from (4) and is the model's signature prediction: the within-deputy, institutional-versus-ideological Loyalty Index gap. In the empirical sections, v_ℓ^I is operationalized as alignment on the two *non-ideological* issues and v_ℓ^D as alignment on the five *ideological* issues, the labels the tables use.

Proposition 3 (Office–media complementarity)**.** *A license delivers valence $\Gamma > 0$ only to a legislator who holds office: by (1), Γb_ℓ enters the incumbent's support condition and is unavailable to a defeated candidate, whose broadcasting assets carry no legislative platform to amplify. Winning a seat is therefore worth more to a media owner than to a non-owner, and the incumbency effect satisfies*

$$\tau^1 - \tau^0 \; = \; f(\tfrac{1}{2})\,\Gamma \; > \; 0,$$

where τ^G is the effect of narrowly winning on winning the next election within ownership group $G \in \{0, 1\}$ and $f(\frac{1}{2})$ is the density of counterfactual vote share at the winning threshold. The scaling matters for interpretation: Γ is an increment to expected vote share in (2) while τ^G is

a difference in the probability of holding a seat, so the estimated difference is proportional to the valence parameter rather than equal to it, and the constant of proportionality need not be common across ownership groups.

Proposition 3 rests on a substantive restriction worth stating plainly: a defeated candidate who owns a station captures none of Γ. Writing $\lambda \in [0, 1]$ for the share a defeated owner does capture, the difference becomes $(1 - \lambda)\, f(\frac{1}{2})\, \Gamma$: it is positive for any $\lambda < 1$, vanishes only if losing candidates convert their holdings into votes exactly as officeholders do, and is a lower bound on the complementarity whenever $\lambda > 0$. The restriction is the paper's central claim rather than a technical convenience—broadcast licenses are *productive* political capital precisely because their electoral return is realized in combination with office, through programming that covers the holder's own legislative work and name recognition tied to visible public position.

4 Data

The empirical analysis combines administrative records on broadcast concessions, corporate-ownership records, electoral returns, and roll-call votes from Brazil's 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (NCA). The preceding Background section explains the D'Hondt/Jefferson allocation rule and the general difficulty of defining close elections under proportional representation. This section implements the paper's solution: it defines the effective electoral list, constructs the candidate-level running variable, and then describes the three estimating samples used in the empirical analysis—media allocation, legislative response, and electoral advantage.

4.1 Sources

Broadcast grants and corporate ownership. The Ministry of Communications data are an administrative extract of radio and television broadcasting grants obtained through a *Lei de Acesso à Informação* request. The file contains 5,753 grant records dated 1979–2003, including 3,819 classified as radio and 1,934 as television. It identifies the grantee by its corporate tax identifier (CNPJ), municipality and state of service, service type, and grant date. We therefore describe these data as the radio and television grants covered by the LAI extract, not as the universe of Brazilian telecommunications concessions.

We link grantees to extracts from the *Cadastro Nacional de Empresas* (CNE). The processed ownership file contains 65,728 firm–partner events for 8,141 CNPJs and 28,995 individual tax identifiers. It records partner names and, when available, partner entry and exit dates as well as corporate start and incorporation dates. The CNE therefore observes dated partnership relationships, not only the owners present when a firm opened; nor do the records by themselves constitute an uninterrupted ownership history.

Electoral records. We obtain candidate-level electoral records directly from the official files of the *Tribunal Superior Eleitoral* (TSE).[12] The files report candidate names, states, parties and electoral lists, nominal votes, offices contested, and official electoral status. We harmonize these records across election years and construct person-level and kinship links to identify candidates who reappear in subsequent elections, as well as relatives of earlier candidates who later enter the electoral record. These links provide the candidacy and election outcomes used to follow politicians and political families over time.

Table 1 reports the election-specific list rule and the resulting running-variable coverage. Party coalitions were prohibited in 1978 and 1982, so the effective list is party-by-state in those elections. Coalitions were permitted from 1986 onward. For 1986, 1990, and 1994,

[12]The TSE electoral files are available at https://dadosabertos.tse.jus.br/.

we therefore compare candidates within coalition-composition-by-state when a party ran in a coalition and within party-by-state when it ran alone. The positive side of the resulting running variable reproduces every official TSE winner in every state through 1990. In 1994 it recovers 503 of 513 winners and the exact winner count in 21 of 27 states.

Table 1: Election Rules and Running-Variable Coverage

Election	Effective list	Candidates with $RunVar$ /TSE candidates	$RunVar \geq 0$ /TSE winners	UFs exact
1978	Party × state	1,096/1,104	420/420	25/25
1982	Party × state	1,355/1,586	479/479	25/25
1986	Coalition × state if allied; party × state otherwise	2,606/4,194	487/487	26/26
1990	Coalition × state if allied; party × state otherwise	2,885/3,846	503/503	27/27
1994	Coalition × state if allied; party × state otherwise	2,326/3,037	503/513	21/27

Notes: Candidate coverage is the share for which an opposite-side within-list margin can be defined; it is not a person-linkage rate. "UFs exact" counts states in which the number of nonnegative running-variable values equals the official number of winners. The 1994 shortfall is ten winners in CE, DF, MG, MT, RJ, and RO.

Three identifiers that serve different empirical purposes are kept separate throughout the pipeline. First, the *effective electoral list* identifies the candidates who competed for the same pool of seats and therefore defines $RunVar$. Second, the candidate's observed *party* defines the political groups used in the heterogeneity analysis and the party components of fixed effects. Third, a person identifier is used to link the same politician across elections and to stack the longitudinal electoral-advantage panel. Neither party nor the person identifier substitutes for the election-specific list identifier.

The official candidate archives do not preserve coalition composition uniformly across years. The 1994 list variable therefore uses a documented coalition reconstruction and falls back to party when coalition composition is unavailable. The ten missing 1994 winners are concentrated in eight reconstructed state–party cells without a valid losing-side candidate. Seven are absent from the current coalition rescue map; the remaining CE–PP cell contains

a losing record with null status and missing votes. These are unresolved list-reconstruction or source-data limitations, not evidence by themselves of ten person-level crosswalk errors. We retain the limitation explicitly and do not impute a running variable for those cases.

NCA roll calls. The roll-call source is the Chamber of Deputies' official historical collection of scanned NCA proceedings. The inherited extraction scripts use Optical Character Recognition (OCR) to convert the page images to text, standardize deputy names and vote options, and combine the extracted lists into a deputy-level file. Project documentation records manual inspection of names, choices, and abstention codes against the original pages. The seven topics are agrarian reform, the right to strike, employment stability, working hours, property rights, the presidential system, and the five-year presidential term. The Executive's preferred position on each component vote is coded from statements in the plenary record, including Mário Covas's floor speeches as government leader. Appendix D describes the extraction pipeline, the validation procedure, and the topic-level sub-vote assignments in detail.[13]

Matching concessions and candidates. The automated linkage has two distinct channels. The *self* channel compares a politician's normalized name with a registered partner's normalized name within the same state. The broader *all-links* channel also searches for family links. A surname link requires at least one uncommon shared surname or at least two common shared surnames. First-name similarity separates candidate self-links from candidate-relative links. The broad automated measure therefore includes family-name links and should not be described as direct formal ownership only. Appendix A documents the normalization, linkage rules, and current validation limits.

We complement the automated links with the concession histories reconstructed by

[13]The Chamber collection is available at https://www2.camara.leg.br/atividade-legislativa/plenario/discursos/escrevendohistoria/25-anos-da-constituicao-de-1988/momentos-marcantes-da-constituinte.

Motter et al. (2019), which document spouses, relatives, associates, and proxy shareholders that a registry-only link may miss. Motter's archival search was conducted on the treated side: it sought NCA deputies who received or politically controlled concessions, rather than applying the same search to every losing candidate. It can therefore reveal false negatives in the automated treatment measure among archival recipients, but it cannot estimate full-sample precision or false-negative rates among losing RDD candidates.

Qualitative evidence makes this limitation substantively plausible. Reporting on the Sarney period documents a television concession formally held by the son and son-in-law of a leading politician and describes a concession assigned to Osvaldo Coelho after Fernando Bezerra Coelho publicly attributed the loss of the license he expected to his vote against the five-year presidential term (Lobato, 1995). A later multi-state investigation identifies political control exercised through foundations, spouses, former aides, and electoral associates in Espírito Santo, Santa Catarina, Alagoas, Pará, and Amazonas (Lobato, 2006). An official Senate account likewise records a committee hearing on fictitious partners and irregular ownership transfers in broadcasting (Agência Senado, 2011). These sources establish mechanisms and geographic reach; they do not measure their prevalence in our 1986 population.

The data retain two orthogonal coding choices: linkage scope (self versus all links) and information source (automated only versus automated plus Motter). In the 1986 RDD population, the broad automated-plus-Motter measure identifies 204 recipients (7.83%): 112 of 487 winners and 92 of 2,119 non-winners. Losing candidates could legally receive grants, so these cases are not errors by definition. Among the 92 positive losing candidates, 82 are identified only by the relative channel. The archived linkage records recover the underlying 1987–88 automated match for 11 of 91 automated positives. We therefore report automated-only and Motter-augmented results separately and do not claim that the current files validate the precision of all relative links. Appendix A separates missing CNE coverage, missing person-panel coverage, and indirect ownership and presents sanitized

input snapshots for recognizable recovered and unrecovered cases.

4.2 Samples

4.2.1 Media Allocation Estimating Sample

Population and running variable. The Media Allocation estimating sample begins with 4,194 federal-deputy candidacies in 1986. Six have zero or missing nominal votes, leaving 4,188 candidates with a classifiable status, positive votes, a person identifier, a state, and an electoral list. Because federal deputies were elected in statewide open-list contests, a candidate's relevant comparison is the marginal candidate in the same state and party-or-coalition list. A margin can therefore be constructed only in a state–list cell containing at least one elected and one non-elected candidate. This rule leaves 2,608 candidates: all 487 elected candidates, all 2,121 candidates recorded as substitutes (*suplentes*), and none of the 1,580 candidates recorded as non-elected. Two common-name cases with defined margins are not present in the consolidated data, producing the final RDD population of 2,606 candidates: 487 winners (18.7%) and 2,119 non-winners (81.3%) in 74 eligible state–list cells across 26 states.[14] We denote official electoral victory by $Elected_i$.

Following the candidate-margin logic used by Boas, Hidalgo, and Richardson (2014), Firpo, Ponczek, and Sanfelice (2015), and Novaes (2024), $RunVar_i$ is the candidate's within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold, measured against the marginal candidate on the opposite side.[15] Winners have positive margins, non-winners have negative margins, and zero is the cutoff. The unit is percentage points of the statewide nominal vote. The baseline is not divided by the marginal

[14] Tocantins is absent because it did not exist as a state in 1986.

[15] Let i index candidates, c electoral lists, and s states; let v_{ics} be candidate votes and $V_s = \sum_{c'} \sum_{j \in \mathcal{I}_{c's}} v_{jc's}$ the total nominal federal-deputy vote in state s. Define $q_{ics} = 100 v_{ics}/V_s$ and let E_{ics} equal one for an officially elected candidate. Within each eligible cell, $q^W_{cs} = \min_{j:E_{jcs}=1} q_{jcs}$ is the last winner's share and $q^L_{cs} = \max_{j:E_{jcs}=0} q_{jcs}$ is the first non-winner's share. Then $RunVar_{ics} = q_{ics} - q^L_{cs}$ for a winner and $RunVar_{ics} = q_{ics} - q^W_{cs}$ otherwise.

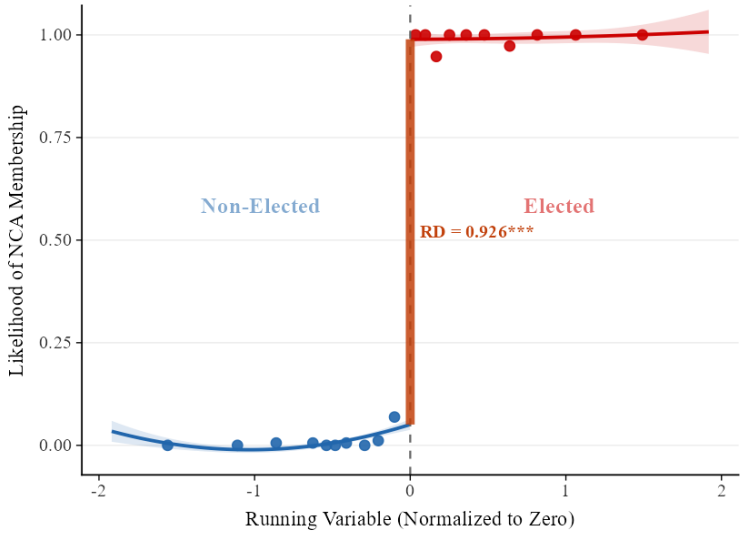
candidate's votes, the list vote, or an estimated threshold. An alternative robustness measure divides the baseline margin by the candidate's own statewide vote share; this changes scale and bandwidth but not cutoff or treatment status.

A named state–list comparison makes the scale concrete. On the PFL list in Rio de Janeiro, Arolde de Oliveira was the last elected candidate with 26,417 votes (0.57% of the statewide nominal vote), while Nelson Sabrá was the first non-winner with 19,826 votes (0.43%). Their opposite-side margins are therefore $+0.14$ and -0.14 percentage points. The construction uses full precision and rounds only for presentation. Each of the 74 eligible cells similarly contributes one marginal candidate on either side, yielding a 148-candidate marginal-pair robustness sample; the main local RDD uses all candidates inside each outcome-specific bandwidth to retain precision for a rare binary outcome.

The corrected NCA crosswalk provides a direct validation of how the electoral cutoff maps into actual constituent service. In the current data, all 487 candidates with $RunVar_i \geq 0$ are NCA members, while 25 candidates below the cutoff also served in the NCA. The latter pattern is consistent with elected deputies leaving office and list substitutes taking their places, although the analysis file does not contain an explicit substitution flag. Figure 1 therefore documents a strong but not perfectly sharp relationship between electoral victory and NCA membership.

Outcomes and heterogeneity groups. The primary outcome, $Concession_i$, equals one if a candidate is linked through the broad automated-plus-Motter measure to any radio or television grant in 1987–88. $Radio_i$ and TV_i denote the corresponding technology-specific outcomes. The full population contains 204 any-media recipients (7.83%), 165 radio recipients (6.33%), and 60 television recipients (2.30%); radio and television are separate outcomes and may overlap. Automated-only versions retain the same definitions without the Motter augmentation, while pre-1987 holdings are predetermined covariates rather than part of the 1987–88 outcome.

Figure 1: Electoral Victory Almost Perfectly Predicts National Constitutional Assembly Membership



Notes: This figure displays an RDD estimate of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on membership in the National Constitutional Assembly (NCA, 1987–88), using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The outcome is $MemberNCA_i$, an indicator equal to one if candidate i sat as a member of the NCA. The running variable $RunVar_i$ is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold in the 1986 election. The binned scatter plot uses 10 equal-frequency bins on each side of the cutoff, a local-quadratic ($p = 2$) with triangular kernel and MSE-optimal bandwidth ($h = 1.918$), and a vertical segment at the cutoff marking the estimated jump. The estimating equation is $MemberNCA_i = \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors, clustered at the state level. The discontinuity is close to, but not exactly, sharp: 17 candidates with $RunVar_i < 0$ nonetheless became NCA members (13 of 17 affiliated with PMDB), and 3 candidates with $RunVar_i \geq 0$ did not (out of 2606 candidates in the estimating sample). The below-cutoff NCA members are concentrated in PMDB, consistent with the historical record that many PMDB deputies-elect resigned their federal mandate after winning state governorships in the concurrent 1986 gubernatorial elections (PMDB won 22 of 23 states), elevating their coalition-list alternates (suplentes) to the NCA in their place; this is a substantive account consistent with the party composition of these cases, not a conclusion drawn from an explicit substitution flag in the data. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The political-group cuts are defined directly from the candidate's 1986 party. $Government_i$ identifies PMDB or PFL candidates (1,140; 43.7%); $LeftOpposition_i$ identifies PDT, PT, PSB, PCB, and PCdoB candidates (587; 22.5%); and $RightOpposition_i$ identifies the remaining opposition parties (879; 33.7%). Unequal counts above and below the cutoff follow mechanically from lists having many substitutes but few seats; density, balance, donut, bandwidth, and alternative-margin diagnostics are evaluated as identification checks rather than inferred from the raw side counts alone.

Appendix Tables B1 and B2 provide the variable dictionary and descriptive statistics for this 2,606-candidate population, including observed and missing counts.

4.2.2 Legislative Response Estimating Sample

Construction and unit of observation. The legislative sample links 455 of the 487 elected candidates to both the NCA vote file and the concession data. Its unit of observation is a deputy–issue pair. For deputy i and issue j, $Loyalty_{i,j} \in [0, 1]$ is the share of the issue's component votes cast in the Executive's preferred direction. Agrarian reform, the right to strike, employment stability, working hours, and property rights aggregate 7, 5, 4, 9, and 4 component votes, respectively. The Presidential System and Five-Year Mandate issues each use one vote. The outcome is therefore fractional. We call the two institutional issues Non-Ideological and the remaining five issues Ideological.

The direction-dependent benchmark coding defines 2,006 of the potential $455 \times 7 = 3,185$ deputy–issue scores. The issue-specific counts are 384 for agrarian reform, 154 for the right to strike, 184 for employment stability, 200 for working hours, 174 for property rights, and 455 for each Non-Ideological issue. These are code-defined scores rather than counts of fully observed raw roll calls. A score can remain defined when some component votes are missing.

Missing votes. The current Results tables use the inherited direction-dependent benchmark. In that implementation, a missing component vote propagates to the issue score when the Executive preferred No but is coded as zero alignment when the Executive preferred Yes. This rule produces the 2,006 observations above and is the exact sample described by the main regression tables. Because the same unobserved vote is treated differently according to the Executive's preferred direction, we also implement a symmetric validation in which every missing roll-call entry remains missing.

The source file does not distinguish an OCR omission from absence, leave, nonparticipation, obstruction, or linkage failure. The missing-at-random assumption therefore applies directly only to OCR-induced omissions and cannot be tested for the undifferentiated missing category. The other cases also lack an observed voting direction, so we do not impute alignment to them. A raw missing entry propagates to the deputy–issue score under the fixed-denominator aggregation.

The symmetric missing validation defines 1,714 deputy–issue observations from 445 deputies. The issue-specific counts are 240 for agrarian reform, 124 for the right to strike, 151 for employment stability, 177 for working hours, 141 for property rights, 443 for the Presidential System, and 438 for the Five-Year Mandate. It removes 292 observations from the direction-dependent benchmark. Every retained $Loyalty_{i,j}$ value is unchanged before the treatment of abstentions changes. The loss is larger among Ideological issues (24.0%) than among Non-Ideological issues (3.2%), so Appendix diagnostics report both the coefficient sensitivity and the resulting sample selection.

Abstention is an observed parliamentary choice, but it is not a vote in the Executive's preferred direction. The symmetric validation therefore codes abstention as zero alignment whether the Executive preferred Yes or No. Further sensitivity analyses exclude abstentions or divide by the number of observed component votes. We also report a complete-voter restriction, although only 30 deputies have all 31 raw component votes and

the fully controlled specification is not identified in that sample. These alternatives diagnose the inherited benchmark; they are not silently substituted for the 2,006-observation sample used in the current Results tables.

Treatment, technology, and political groups. We define $Concession_i$ using the broad automated-plus-Motter measure. This definition yields 106 recipients (23.3% of deputies). They contribute 400 treated deputy–issue observations under the direction-dependent benchmark and 334 under the symmetric missing validation. A self-name-only definition is a sensitivity analysis rather than the headline Legislative Response treatment.

Under the broad coding, 32 deputies have $TV_i = 1$ (7.0% of the sample) and 74 have $RadioOnly_i = 1$ (16.3%). These are mutually exclusive treatment indicators, not moderators. $NonIdeological_j$ identifies the Presidential System and Five-Year Mandate issues, while $Ideological_j$ identifies the remaining five. $Government_i$ identifies PMDB and PFL deputies, and $Opposition_i$ identifies all other parties. The predetermined vector $\mathbf{x}_i$ contains $RunVar_i$ and separate annual counts of radio and television concessions for 1982, 1983, 1984, 1985, and 1986. The specification-specific fixed effects and their interpretation belong to the empirical-methods section.

Appendix Tables B3 and B4 report definitions and descriptive statistics separately at the deputy and deputy–issue levels, avoiding the duplication of deputy-level variables across issues.

4.2.3 Electoral Advantage Estimating Sample

Origin cohorts and outcomes. The current Results specification pools four origin-election cohorts: 1982, 1986, 1990, and 1994, and follows each cohort to the federal-deputy election four years later. Before common-support restrictions, the OLS population contains 1,972 origin-election winners: 479, 487, 503, and 503 in the four cohorts. Iteratively

removing singleton year–state and year–state–party cells used by the most saturated specification leaves the common 1,811-observation estimating sample reported in every OLS column: 477, 463, 440, and 431 observations by cohort. The candidate-level RDD panel instead includes every observation with a defined origin-election running variable: 1,355, 2,606, 2,885, and 2,326 observations, respectively, for a total of 9,172 candidate–cohort pairs. In the OLS specifications, $Ran_{i,t+4}$ and $Elected_{i,t+4}$ come from the official subsequent-election candidacy and victory indicators. In the heterogeneous RDD, subsequent victory is operationalized as a nonnegative observed $RunVar_{i,t+4}$. This makes the 1994 running-variable coverage limitation relevant when 1994 serves as an outcome election as well as when it serves as an origin election.

Broadcasting rights are sufficiently durable to make all four cohorts substantively informative. Radio concessions have an initial legal term of ten years and television concessions an initial term of fifteen years, and both can be renewed. Television grants peaked in 1982–86, up to roughly sixteen years before the end of the follow-up, while radio grants peaked during the NCA in 1987–88, roughly ten years before the end. Most grants made in these allocation waves therefore remained relevant over much of the observation window, and renewability could extend their ownership value beyond the initial term. A separate 1986-only design is a diagnostic, not the headline Electoral Advantage sample.

Flow and stock treatments. The Results code distinguishes two media variables. *Concession*$_{i,t+1,t+4}$ is the flow treatment: it equals one when the candidate or a linked relative receives any new radio or television concession during 1983–86, 1987–90, 1991–94, or 1995–98 for the respective origin cohort. In the final 1,811-observation OLS sample, 194 observations receive a term concession. *MediaOwner*$_{i,t}$ is the predetermined stock treatment: it equals one when the candidate or a linked relative holds at least one observed concession from 1982 through the origin election; 217 final OLS observations are owners. In the unrestricted 9,172-observation candidate panel, the cohort-specific owner

counts are 26, 135, 280, and 298, or 739 candidate–cohort observations in total (8.1%). The flow and stock measures use the same broad self-or-relative linkage scope, but represent different timing and must remain distinct in estimation and interpretation.

Appendix Tables B5 and B6 define the variables and report descriptive statistics separately for the 1,811-observation OLS and 9,172-observation RDD samples.

5 Empirical Strategy

We organize the empirical analysis around the three sets of predictions presented in Section 3. First, we test the *media allocation* predictions: electoral victory should increase access to media concessions during the NCA, with stronger effects for deputies closer to the Executive's institutional position. Second, we test the *legislative response* predictions: concession recipients should vote more often with the government during the NCA, again with stronger associations for higher-valence concessions and deputies with lower ideological distance. Finally, we test the main *electoral advantage* prediction: concessions, or media ownership more broadly, should be associated with better future electoral outcomes.

5.1 Media Allocation

We start the empirical analysis by testing whether political power affects media allocation. As discussed in section 3, if media concessions were used as political currency, then incumbents should have been more likely to receive concessions than challengers (Proposition 1). We use the media allocation estimating sample described in section 4 to compare concession receipt between elected and non-elected candidates.

The main empirical challenge in causally testing this proposition is that elected candidates usually differ from non-elected candidates in relevant dimensions, such as political

experience, party connections, past media ownership, and electoral strength. These characteristics may affect both the probability of winning a seat and the probability of receiving a concession, generating omitted-variable bias (OVB) in simple comparisons.

To mitigate the likelihood of OVB, we estimate a regression with fixed effects that compares elected and non-elected candidates within similar groups, such as electoral districts and parties, and includes predetermined control variables to account for differences between elected and non-elected candidates within the same group. More specifically, we estimate the partial correlation between electoral victory and concession receipt using the following OLS model:

$$Concession_i = \alpha_{s(i),p(i)} + \beta Elected_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_i, \tag{8}$$

where $Concession_i$ is an indicator equal to one if candidate i received a media concession during the NCA (1987–88), and $Elected_i$ is an indicator equal to one if candidate i won a seat in the 1986 federal election. The term $\alpha_{s(i),p(i)}$ captures state-party fixed effects, and $\mathbf{x}_i$ includes the predetermined controls described in Section 4.

We cluster standard errors at the state level—the electoral district in Brazilian federal elections. Because the treatment variable $Elected_i$ is assigned at the candidate level, clustering at the state level aggregates many candidates into each unit, making inference conservative relative to finer clustering levels: it permits arbitrary within-state residual correlation across all candidates competing in the same electoral district, regardless of party. The media allocation estimating sample yields 26 state clusters, with an average of 99.3 candidates per cluster.

The coefficient β measures how much more likely elected candidates are to receive a media concession than non-elected candidates, in percentage points, conditional on fixed effects and controls. A causal interpretation would require the conditional exogeneity

assumption

$$Cov\left[Elected_i, \varepsilon_i \mid \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}, \mathbf{x}_i\right] = 0.$$

This assumption implies that all unobserved determinants of both $Concession_i$ and $Elected_i$ are captured by the controls and fixed effects. Given the implausibility of this OLS identification assumption, we interpret β in Equation (8) as a partial correlation between electoral victory and concession receipt.

To strengthen identification, we complement Equation (8) with a close-election regression discontinuity design. More specifically, we estimate:

$$Concession_i = \tau\, \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i, \tag{9}$$

where $f(RunVar_i)$ is a local RD polynomial in the running variable. The running variable, $RunVar_i$, is the within-list vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold, expressed in percentage points of the state-level vote share, as described in detail in Section 4. Candidates with $RunVar_i \geq 0$ narrowly won a seat, while candidates with $RunVar_i < 0$ narrowly lost.

Following Imbens and Lemieux (2008) and Calonico et al. (2014), our main specification estimates Equation (9) nonparametrically by fitting separate local regressions on each side of the cutoff. We use a local-linear polynomial and triangular kernel weights, which give greater weight to observations closer to the cutoff. The local-linear specification is the standard choice in applied RDD because it limits boundary bias without relying on unstable high-order polynomials (Gelman and Imbens, 2019). Our preferred specification selects bandwidths using the MSERD bandwidth selector of Calonico et al. (2019).

Inference follows the robust bias-corrected procedure of Calonico et al. (2014), which adjusts confidence intervals for the bias induced by local-polynomial estimation. We use nearest-neighbor variance estimation and, as in Equation (8), cluster standard errors at

the state level.

The coefficient τ measures the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 election on the likelihood of receiving a media concession during the NCA, in percentage points. The identifying variation in Equation (9) comes from comparing concession outcomes for close winners and close losers in the 1986 election.

The causal interpretation of τ relies on the continuity of potential outcomes around the cutoff. Let $Concession_i(0)$ denote potential concession receipt without winning a seat. The coefficient τ has a causal interpretation under the standard continuity condition in close-election RDDs: $E[Concession_i(0) \mid RunVar_i = r]$ is continuous at the cutoff $r = 0$. This assumption implies that candidates should not precisely manipulate their position around the cutoff, and that candidates just above and just below the cutoff should be comparable in predetermined determinants of concession receipt. Under this assumption, τ identifies a local average treatment effect for candidates around the cutoff.

5.2 Legislative Response

Regression model. The second step of the empirical analysis is testing whether media allocation impacts the legislative behaviour of Congress members. As discussed in section 3, if media concessions were used as political currency, concession recipients should have been more likely to support the Executive during the NCA (Proposition 2). We use the legislative-response estimating sample described in section 4 to compare legislative alignment between concession recipients and non-recipients.

The main empirical challenge in causally testing this proposition is that concession receipt is endogenous within the sample of elected candidates. First, concession receipt may reflect unobserved state-party bargaining arrangements, such as agreements mediated by governors, party leaders, or regional coalition brokers, which could jointly determine access to concessions and roll-call alignment. Second, the Executive may have targeted leg-

islators according to unobserved characteristics such as ideological proximity, bargaining power, personal ties to the government, electoral vulnerability, or expected future influence, causing selection bias.

To mitigate these concerns, we estimate an OLS fixed-effect regression that compares the legislative outcomes of deputies from the same state-party group voting on the same constitutional issue and controls for predetermined covariates. More precisely, we estimate:

$$Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_j + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)} + \beta Concession_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_{i,j}, \tag{10}$$

where $Loyalty_{i,j}$ is the government-aligned support score of deputy i on issue j, and $Concession_i$ is an indicator equal to one if deputy i received a media concession during the NCA. The terms α_j and $\alpha_{s(i),p(i)}$ denote issue fixed effects and state-party fixed effects, respectively. The vector $\mathbf{x}_i$ includes the predetermined political and media-ownership controls described in Section 4.

As in the media allocation analysis, we cluster standard errors at the state level, making inference conservative relative to finer clustering levels. The legislative-response estimating sample yields 26 state clusters, comprising 2,006 observations, with an average of 77.2 observations (issue–deputy pairs) per cluster.

The coefficient β measures how much more likely concession recipients were to support the government than non-recipients, in percentage points. A causal interpretation would require the conditional exogeneity assumption

$$Cov\left[Concession_i, \varepsilon_{i,j} \mid \alpha_j, \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}, \mathbf{x}_i\right] = 0.$$

This assumption is demanding even within state-party groups and conditional on $\mathbf{x}_i$, because it requires $Concession_i$ to be independent of all unobserved deputy characteristics that affect $Loyalty_{i,j}$. Given the restrictiveness of this OLS identification assumption, we in-

terpret β in Equation (10) as a conditional association between $Concession_i$ and $Loyalty_{i,j}$.

Our theoretical model also predicts that, if concessions bought loyalty selectively, recipients should have been especially likely to support the Executive on non-ideological votes, where patronage is less constrained by ideology (Proposition 2). Testing this prediction requires comparing the legislative behaviour of the same deputies across ideological and non-ideological issues, which is difficult to observe. The NCA provides this variation: as explained in Section 4, our sample includes deputy-level votes on two non-ideological issues, the presidential system of government and the five-year presidential mandate, as well as five more ideological issues. Based on this classification, Section 4 defines $NonIdeological_j$, an indicator equal to one for the two non-ideological issues and zero for the remaining five issues.

Then, we use $NonIdeological_j$ to test whether the concession–loyalty association is stronger for non-ideological votes. To do so, we estimate the following two-way fixed-effects specification:

$$Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_i + \alpha_j + \delta Concession_i \cdot NonIdeological_j + \varepsilon_{i,j}, \tag{11}$$

where α_i denotes deputy fixed effects and α_j denotes issue fixed effects. Deputy fixed effects absorb all time-invariant differences across deputies, including the main effect of concession receipt. Issue fixed effects absorb average differences in government support across constitutional topics, including the main effect of $NonIdeological_j$.

The coefficient δ measures how much stronger the association between concession receipt and government support is on non-ideological votes than on ideological votes. It is identified from *within-deputy variation*: it compares the difference between non-ideological and ideological votes for concession recipients with the same difference for non-recipients.

Equation (11) also helps assess the plausibility of endogeneity bias caused by selec-

tion into concession receipt. First, if the association between concession receipt and loyalty were driven by generic omitted variables, we would not expect $\widehat{\delta}$ to vary substantially across ideological and non-ideological votes. Second, if selection based on time-invariant deputy characteristics explained the relationship between concession receipt and loyalty, then $\widehat{\delta}$ should change substantially once estimated using within-deputy variation. Therefore, by documenting a positive, significant, and stable $\widehat{\delta}$ after including deputy fixed effects, we show that endogeneity bias caused by selection into concession receipt is unlikely to account for our results.

Our theoretical model predicts that, if concessions operated as political currency, the concession–loyalty association should be stronger among government-aligned deputies, whose institutional deviation cost places them inside the targetable set of Proposition 1, and for media types with higher valence returns. To test this proposition, we use an augmented specification that interacts the moderator with all fixed effects and controls, avoiding the restriction that nuisance parameters are equal across subsamples, which Feigenberg et al. (2025) show can bias estimated interaction effects. More specifically, we estimate the following regression model:

$$\begin{aligned} Loyalty_{i,j} = Government_i \cdot \left(\alpha_j^1 + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}^1 + \beta^1 Concession_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}^1 \mathbf{x}_i\right) \\ + (1 - Government_i) \cdot \left(\alpha_j^0 + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}^0 + \beta^0 Concession_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}^0 \mathbf{x}_i\right) + \varepsilon_{i,j}. \end{aligned} \tag{12}$$

$Government_i$ is the moderator: a deputy-level indicator for whether deputy i belongs to one of the two government parties (PMDB or PFL). Superscripts 1 and 0 denote parameters estimated for the subsamples with $Government_i = 1$ and $Government_i = 0$, respectively. The coefficient β^1 measures the association between concession receipt and government support among deputies with $Government_i = 1$, while β^0 measures the same association among deputies with $Government_i = 0$. We then test the null hypothesis $H_0 : \beta^1 - \beta^0 = 0$. Rejecting H_0 provides evidence that concessions are more strongly

associated with loyalty in the subgroup with $Government_i = 1$.

Our theoretical model also predicts that, if concessions operated as political currency, the concession–loyalty association should be stronger for media types with higher valence returns; the model carries a single valence parameter, so this is a heterogeneity consistent with the mechanism rather than a prediction it derives. Television concessions reach broader audiences than radio, implying a larger loyalty premium for TV recipients than for radio-only recipients. To test this prediction, we decompose the concession indicator into two mutually exclusive dummies and estimate their alignment premia jointly in a single pooled regression:

$$Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_j + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)} + \beta^1 TV_i + \beta^0 RadioOnly_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_{i,j}, \tag{13}$$

where TV_i equals one if deputy i received at least one TV concession in 1987–88 (whether or not they also received radio concessions), and $RadioOnly_i$ equals one if deputy i received only radio concessions in 1987–88. Deputies with no concession form the omitted category, so β^1 and β^0 measure the alignment premium for each group relative to non-recipients. We then test the null hypothesis $H_0 : \beta^1 - \beta^0 = 0$ using the delta method with $G-1$ cluster degrees of freedom, where G is the number of state clusters. Rejecting H_0 provides evidence that the loyalty premium is larger for TV concessions than for radio-only concessions.

5.3 Electoral Advantage

The final part of the empirical analysis examines whether media allocation affected the future political power of concession recipients. If media concessions were valuable political assets, recipients should have performed better in subsequent federal elections. We use the electoral-advantage estimating sample described in Section 4 to assess whether media

ownership is associated with higher recandidacy rates, higher reelection rates, and larger incumbency effects.

The main empirical challenge is that media ownership is not randomly assigned. Simple comparisons between recipients and non-recipients likely suffer from OVB: concession recipients may have more resources, deeper local networks, higher name recognition, or greater party influence. Moreover, as Section 6 shows, concession allocation is itself a consequence of electoral outcomes, generating reverse causality when the electoral outcome and the concession treatment are contemporaneous.

To mitigate OVB, we compare electoral outcomes of concession recipients and non-recipient incumbents within the same state-party-cohort cell:

$$Elected_{i,t+4} = \alpha_{s(i),p(i),t} + \beta Concession_{i,t+1,t+4} + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}, \tag{14}$$

where $Elected_{i,t+4}$ is an indicator for whether incumbent deputy i, elected in year t, wins again in year $t+4$. The variable $Concession_{i,t+1,t+4}$ is the flow measure of concession receipt: it equals one if deputy i received a media concession while in office between years $t+1$ and $t+4$. The term $\alpha_{s(i),p(i),t}$ captures state-party-year fixed effects, so the comparison is made among politicians from the same party, state, and electoral cohort.

The coefficient β measures the partial correlation between concession receipt during the term and re-election probability, in percentage points. A causal interpretation requires

$$Cov\left[Concession_{i,t+1,t+4}, \varepsilon_{i,t+4} \mid \alpha_{s(i),p(i),t}\right] = 0. \tag{15}$$

This assumption is unlikely to hold. The fixed effects do not address reverse causality, and even within the same state-party-cohort cell, concession recipients may differ systematically from non-recipients in unobserved determinants of electoral success. To mitigate reverse causality, we re-estimate Equation (14) replacing $Concession_{i,t+1,t+4}$ with

$MediaOwner_{i,t}$, the stock treatment variable. Since OVB remains plausible under either treatment measure, we interpret the OLS estimates as descriptive evidence on the electoral advantage associated with media ownership.

To move closer to causal evidence, we estimate heterogeneous incumbency effects using the electoral-advantage candidate sample (Proposition 3) that compares close-election RDD estimates for candidates with $MediaOwner_{i,t} = 1$ and $MediaOwner_{i,t} = 0$. For each group $G \in \{0, 1\}$, where $G = 1$ denotes candidates with $MediaOwner_{i,t} = 1$, we estimate:

$$Elected_{i,t+4} = \tau^G \mathbf{1}(RunVar_{i,t} \geq 0) + f^G(RunVar_{i,t}) + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}, \tag{16}$$

where $Elected_{i,t+4}$ is an indicator for winning a seat in the next federal election and $RunVar_{i,t}$ is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold, as described in Section 4. The coefficient τ^G measures the local incumbency effect within group G: the causal effect of narrowly winning the origin election on winning the next election. The difference $\tau^1 - \tau^0$ tests whether the incumbency premium is larger among media owners than non-media owners.

We estimate the two τ^G separately within each media-ownership subsample. Allowing the RD polynomial to differ across subsamples avoids imposing homogeneous running-variable slopes, reducing the risk of misspecification bias in the estimated HLATE (Carril et al., 2023). Subsample-specific bandwidth selection also improves precision: because candidates with $MediaOwner_{i,t} = 1$ account for only 8.1% of the candidate-level panel, the smaller treated subsample benefits from a larger bandwidth when the data support it.

As in the media allocation and legislative response analyses, we cluster standard errors at the state level—the electoral district in Brazilian federal elections—allowing arbitrary within-state residual correlation among candidates competing in the same broadcasting market. The media-owner subsample yields 26 state clusters with an average of 28.4 candidates per cluster; the non-media-owner subsample yields 27 state clusters with an average

of 312.3 candidates per cluster.

All specifications use a local-linear polynomial, triangular kernel weights, and standard errors clustered at the state level. We report bias-corrected point estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors throughout.

The difference $\tau^1 - \tau^0$ identifies the HLATE associated with media ownership under three assumptions (Becker et al., 2013): continuity of counterfactual outcomes at the cutoff within each moderator-defined subgroup; continuity of the moderator at the cutoff; and zero conditional covariance between the moderator and the outcome error, conditional on the running variable. Under these assumptions, $\tau^1 - \tau^0$ identifies the causal effect of media ownership on the incumbency premium.

First, the HLATE interpretation requires within-group continuity of potential outcomes: $E[Elected_{i,t+4}(0) \mid RunVar_{i,t} = r, G]$ is continuous in r at zero for each $G \in \{0, 1\}$. Intuitively, candidates who barely won and barely lost the origin election would have faced the same re-election prospects had neither group won—separately within the media-owner and non-owner subsamples. This is the standard close-election assumption applied within each subpopulation, and it gives τ^1 and τ^0 their individual causal interpretations. We motivate this assumption with running-variable density tests (McCrary, 2008; Cattaneo et al., 2018) and balance checks on predetermined covariates in $\mathbf{x}_{i,t}$.

Second, the HLATE interpretation requires continuity of the interaction variable at the cutoff. In our setting, this means that $E[MediaOwner_{i,t} \mid RunVar_{i,t} = r]$ is continuous in r at zero. Because $MediaOwner_{i,t}$ is binary, this condition requires the probability of belonging to the media-owner subsample to evolve smoothly through the cutoff. Intuitively, candidates who barely won and barely lost the origin election should have had similar probabilities of being media owners before the election. This condition matters because we estimate separate RDDs for media owners and non-owners: crossing the close-election threshold should not determine assignment to either subsample. We motivate this as-

sumption by testing whether the interaction variable $MediaOwner_{i,t}$ is continuous at the cutoff in the full sample.

Third, the HLATE interpretation requires the interaction variable to be uncorrelated with unobserved determinants of the outcome conditional on the running variable near the cutoff. In our setting, this requires $Cov\left[MediaOwner_{i,t}, \varepsilon_{i,t+4} \mid RunVar_{i,t}\right] = 0$ in a neighborhood of the cutoff. Intuitively, among candidates with similar values of $RunVar_{i,t}$ near zero, media owners and non-owners should not differ in unobserved characteristics that would independently change the incumbency effect. We motivate this assumption with balance-check statistics for the predetermined covariates in $\mathbf{x}_{i,t}$ across media owners and non-owners, conditional on the running variable $RunVar_{i,t}$.

6 Main Results

6.1 Allocation

We begin with who received licenses. Proposition 1 predicts that recipients are drawn from the legislators whose institutional deviation cost falls below the valence a license delivers, and that legislators far from the Executive's institutional position receive nothing. Two implications are testable in the media-allocation sample: holding a seat should raise the probability of receiving a concession, and the increase should be concentrated inside the governing coalition. The population contains 2,606 candidates, of whom 487 won seats; 204 (7.83 percent) are linked to a radio or television grant issued during 1987–88.

Table 2: Electoral Victory Is Associated with Higher Likelihood of Concession Receipt

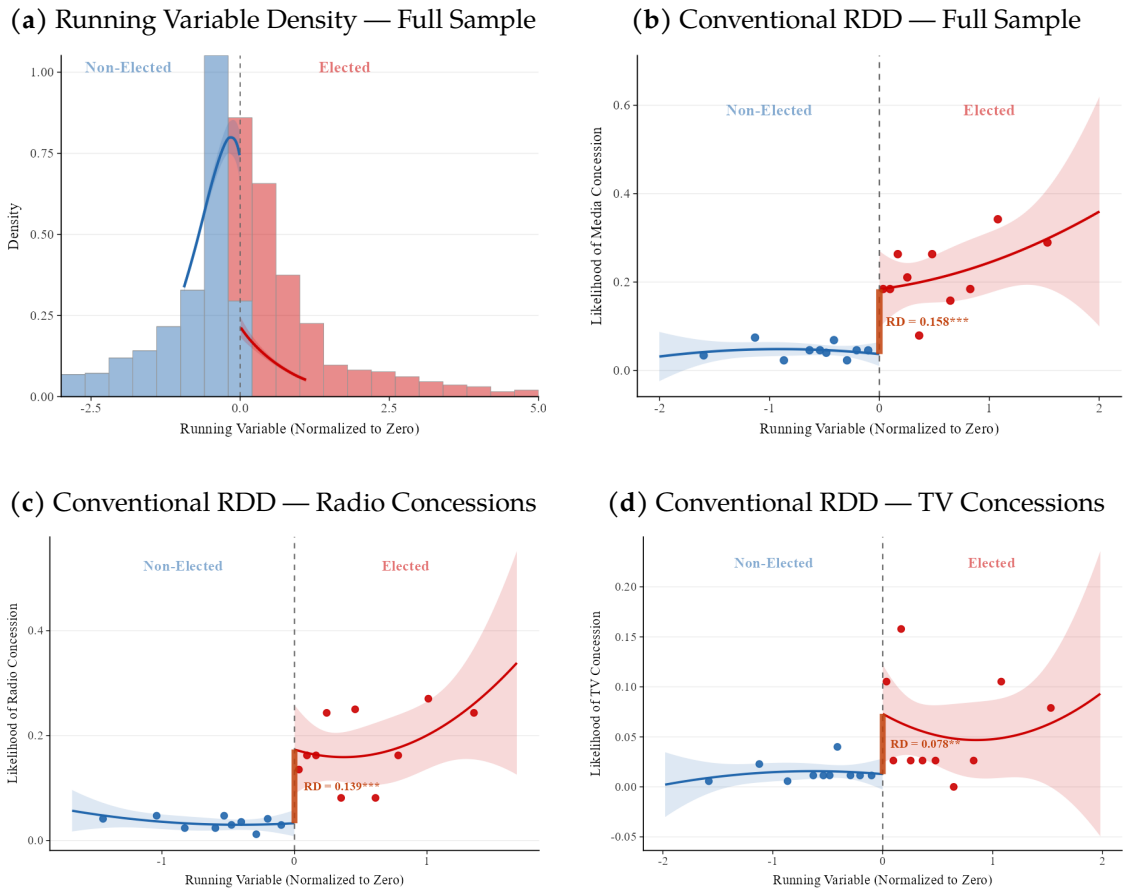
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Elected	0.186***	0.179***	0.183***	0.179***	0.128***
	[0.026]	[0.026]	[0.027]	[0.026]	[0.025]
R-Squared	0.072	0.093	0.104	0.136	0.251
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.079	0.079	0.079	0.079	0.079
N (Observations)	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583
N (Observations, Treatment)	484	484	484	484	484
N (Observations, Control)	2,099	2,099	2,099	2,099	2,099
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26
Party FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party×State FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the association between winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election and receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88) estimated using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The dependent variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if candidate i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88, coded using machine-assisted and archival searches. The treatment variable, $Elected_i$, equals one if candidate i won a seat in the 1986 election. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs) or controls. Column (2) adds state FEs. Column (3) adds state and party FEs separately. Column (4) adds state-party FEs. Column (5) further controls for predetermined covariates. The most complete specification in Column (5) is $Concession_i = \alpha_{s(i),p(i)} + \beta Elected_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_i$. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 2 compares elected and non-elected candidates within state–party cells. Winning a seat is associated with an increase in concession receipt of 0.186 before conditioning and of 0.128 (0.025) in the saturated column, which absorbs state–party cells and the predetermined covariates. The estimating sample contains 2,583 candidates—484 elected and 2,099 not—in 26 state clusters, and the mean of the outcome among non-elected candidates is 0.079.[16] Explanatory power rises from 0.072 to 0.251 across columns, so the fixed effects absorb much of the variation in concession receipt without eliminating the winner–loser gap. These are conditional associations. The exogeneity they would require—that state–party cells and covariates exhaust the common determinants of winning and of receiving a license—fails where political experience, party standing, and prior media holdings predict both.

[16]The gap between the 2,606-candidate population and the 2,583-candidate estimating sample is produced by the iterative removal of singleton state–party cells; the 2,583-candidate estimating sample is used throughout the allocation analysis, including the RDD, so that every column and every table compares the same candidates.

Figure 2: Electoral Victory Increased Media Concession Receipt — Quadratic RDD ($p = 2$)



Notes: This figure displays RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88), using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The outcomes are $Concession_i$, an indicator equal to one if candidate i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88; $Radio_i$, an indicator equal to one if candidate i received a radio concession in 1987–88; and TV_i, an indicator equal to one if candidate i received a TV concession in 1987–88. The running variable $RunVar_i$ is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. Panel (a) plots the density of $RunVar_i$, estimated with a local-polynomial density estimator using an over-smoothed bandwidth ($1.4\times$ MSE-optimal) and 95% confidence bands. Panels (b), (c), and (d) show binned scatter plots for $Concession_i$, $Radio_i$, and TV_i, respectively, with 10 equal-frequency bins on each side of the cutoff, a local-quadratic fit ($p = 2$) with triangular kernel and MSE-optimal bandwidth, and a vertical segment at the cutoff marking the estimated jump. The estimating equation is $Outcome_i = \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$, where $Outcome_i \in \{Concession_i, Radio_i, TV_i\}$. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors, clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The close-election design restricts the comparison to candidates on either side of the seat threshold. Figure 2 plots the discontinuity in four panels. Panel (a) shows the density of the within-list vote margin evolving smoothly through the threshold, with no bunching on either side, so candidates did not sort across the seat cutoff. Panels (b) through (d) plot binned means of concession receipt against the margin—for any concession, for radio, and for television—with quadratic fits estimated separately on each side; each jumps at zero. The estimates reported below use a local-linear fit.

Table 3: Electoral Victory Caused an Increase in Media Concession Receipt

	(1) Any Concession	(2) Radio	(3) TV
Panel A: Conventional RDD			
Elected	0.140***	0.129***	0.054**
	(0.042)	(0.049)	(0.027)
Robust 95% CI	[0.060, 0.224]	[0.038, 0.229]	[0.005, 0.110]
Bandwidth	1.42	1.11	1.68
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.044	0.033	0.012
N (Full Sample)	2,583	2,583	2,583
N (Within Bandwidth)	1,960	1,812	2,062
N (Left of Cutoff)	1,605	1,487	1,694
N (Right of Cutoff)	355	325	368
% of full sample	75.9%	70.2%	79.8%
N (Clusters)	26	26	26
Panel B: Donut RDD			
Elected	0.152***	0.130**	0.076**
	(0.049)	(0.063)	(0.036)
Robust 95% CI	[0.058, 0.249]	[0.008, 0.255]	[0.009, 0.151]
Donut	$[-0.10,\ 0.10]$	$[-0.10,\ 0.10]$	$[-0.10,\ 0.10]$
Bandwidth	1.57	1.37	1.31
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.044	0.033	0.012
N (Full Sample)	2,452	2,452	2,452
N (Within Bandwidth)	1,900	1,800	1,769
N (Left of Cutoff)	1,595	1,507	1,480
N (Right of Cutoff)	305	293	289
% of full sample	73.6%	69.7%	68.5%
N (Clusters)	25	25	25

Notes: This table reports RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88) using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The outcomes are $Concession_i$, an indicator equal to one if candidate i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88; $Radio_i$, an indicator equal to one if candidate i received a radio concession in 1987–88; and TV_i, an indicator equal to one if candidate i received a TV concession in 1987–88. The running variable $RunVar_i$ is the within coalition-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. Columns (1), (2), and (3) report estimates for $Concession_i$, $Radio_i$, and TV_i, respectively. Panel A uses the full media allocation estimating sample. Panel B restricts the sample to candidates with $|RunVar_i| \geq 0.10$. The estimating equation is $Outcome_i = \tau\,\mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$, where $Outcome_i \in \{Concession_i, Radio_i, TV_i\}$, with a local linear polynomial ($p = 1$), triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, and nearest-neighbor variance estimation. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors, clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

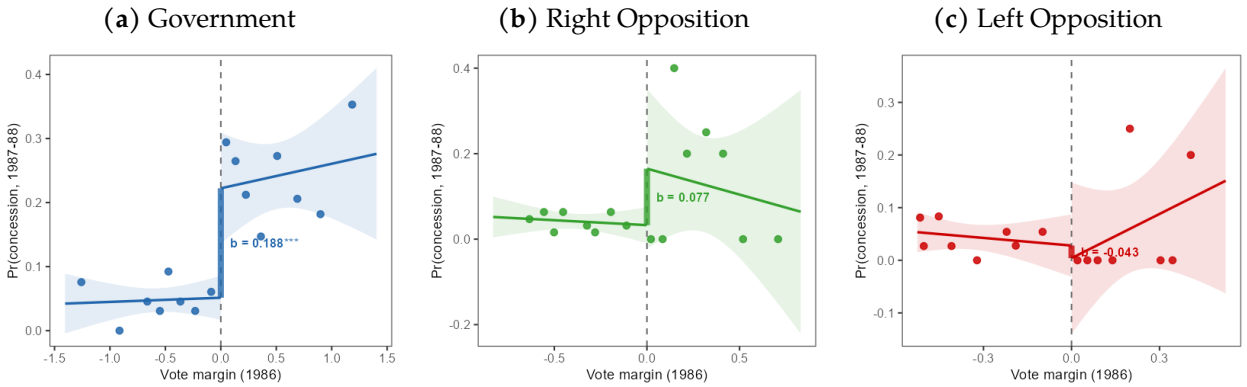
Table 3 estimates that discontinuity. Narrowly winning a seat in 1986 raises the probability of receiving any broadcast concession during the Constituent Assembly by 0.140 (0.042), with a robust confidence interval of $[0.060, 0.224]$ against a control-side mean of 0.044. The MSERD bandwidth of 1.42 percentage points retains 1,960 of the 2,583 candidates, or 75.9 percent, with 1,605 observations left of the cutoff and 355 right. By technology, the effect is 0.129 (0.049) for radio and 0.054 (0.027) for television, against control means of 0.033 and 0.012. Radio carries the larger absolute effect, matching the supply side of the setting: the population contains 165 radio recipients against 60 television recipients. Panel B drops candidates within one-tenth of a percentage point of the threshold, where sorting, if any, would concentrate. The estimates rise rather than fall—0.152 (0.049) for any concession, 0.130 (0.063) for radio, 0.076 (0.036) for television—so the discontinuity is not driven by the observations closest to the cutoff.

Table 4: Electoral Victory Increased Media Concession Receipt Among Government-Aligned Candidates

	(1) Government (PMDB-PFL)	(2) Opposition (Right)	(3) Opposition (Left)
Elected	0.188***	0.075	-0.014
	(0.061)	(0.066)	(0.020)
Difference		-0.113	-0.202***
P-Value		0.207	0.002
Robust 95% CI	[0.073, 0.312]	[-0.057, 0.201]	[-0.056, 0.021]
Bandwidth	1.40	0.82	0.36
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.038	0.051	0.041
N (Full Sample)	1,140	864	579
N (Within Bandwidth)	793	539	163
N (Left of Cutoff)	524	500	136
N (Right of Cutoff)	269	39	27
% of full sample	69.6%	62.4%	28.2%

Notes: This table reports RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88) using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4, estimated separately by political alignment. The dependent variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if candidate i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88. The running variable, $RunVar_i$, is the within coalition-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. The three variables defining the subsamples are: $Government_i = 1$, an indicator for government candidates (PMDB and PFL); $RightOpposition_i = 1$, an indicator for right-opposition candidates; and $LeftOpposition_i = 1$, an indicator for left-opposition candidates (PDT, PT, PSB, PCB, and PCdoB). Column (1) restricts the sample to candidates with $Government_i = 1$; Column (2) restricts the sample to candidates with $RightOpposition_i = 1$; Column (3) restricts the sample to candidates with $LeftOpposition_i = 1$. The estimating equation is $Concession_i = \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$, estimated via `rdrobust` with a local linear polynomial ($p = 1$), triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, and nearest-neighbor variance estimation. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Figure 3: RDD Estimates by Political Alignment: Government, Right Opposition, and Left Opposition



Notes: This figure displays RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88) using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4, estimated separately by political alignment. The dependent variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if candidate i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88. The running variable, $RunVar_i$, is the within coalition-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. The three variables defining the subsamples are: $Government_i = 1$, an indicator for government candidates (PMDB and PFL); $RightOpposition_i = 1$, an indicator for right-opposition candidates; and $LeftOpposition_i = 1$, an indicator for left-opposition candidates (PDT, PT, PSB, PCB, and PCdoB). Panel (a) restricts the sample to candidates with $Government_i = 1$; Panel (b) restricts the sample to candidates with $RightOpposition_i = 1$; Panel (c) restricts the sample to candidates with $LeftOpposition_i = 1$. The estimating equation is $Concession_i = \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$, with a local linear polynomial ($p = 1$), triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, and nearest-neighbor variance estimation. The RDD panels show 10 equal-frequency bins on each side of the cutoff, local-linear fits with 95% confidence ribbons, and a vertical segment at the cutoff marking the conventional RD jump. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 4 and Figure 3 test the targeting margin by estimating the discontinuity separately within political blocs. Among candidates of the two government parties, PMDB and PFL, narrowly winning raises concession receipt by 0.188 (0.061), with an interval of $[0.073, 0.312]$ and a control mean of 0.038; 793 of the bloc's 1,140 candidates fall inside the bandwidth, 524 below the cutoff and 269 above. For the right opposition the estimate is 0.075 (0.066) and the interval $[-0.057, 0.201]$ contains zero; the selected bandwidth of 0.82 leaves 39 observations above the cutoff, which is what the standard error reflects. The gap from the government bloc is -0.113 with a p-value of 0.207, so the two blocs order as predicted but cannot be separated statistically. For the left opposition the estimate is -0.014 (0.020), the interval is $[-0.056, 0.021]$, and the difference from the government bloc is -0.202 with a p-value of 0.002.

The left-opposition estimate rests on a thin window. The selector returns a bandwidth of 0.36 percentage points, retaining 163 of the bloc's 579 candidates—28.2 percent, against 69.6 percent for the government bloc—and leaving 27 observations above the cutoff. The standard error of 0.020 therefore reflects a narrow window rather than an unusually precise zero. Taken together, the three panels order the blocs as Proposition 1 predicts: the effect is largest and precisely estimated inside the governing coalition, positive but imprecise for the right opposition, and indistinguishable from zero for the left. The design separates the government bloc sharply from the left opposition and only loosely from the right.

6.2 Legislative Response

Proposition 2 makes a prediction sharper than a loyalty premium: because a license offsets the electoral cost of an institutional vote against district preference but not that of a redistributive one, recipients should align with the Executive on institutional questions and vote at the district median on ideological ones. The Assembly supplies that variation.

The legislative-response sample links 455 deputies to seven constitutional issues, yielding 2,006 deputy–issue observations, of which 400 belong to the 106 deputies (23.3 percent) linked to a 1987–88 concession. Two issues—the presidential system of government and the five-year presidential term—are the institutional votes the model calls non-ideological; the remaining five concern agrarian reform, the right to strike, employment stability, working hours, and property rights.

Table 5: Media Concession Is Associated with Greater Government Alignment

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Concession	0.128***	0.151***	0.143***	0.109***	0.116***	0.115***
	(0.017)	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.021)	(0.024)	(0.025)
R-Squared	0.018	0.095	0.123	0.151	0.184	0.187
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612
N (Observations)	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006
N (Observations, Treatment)	400	400	400	400	400	400
N (Observations, Control)	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606
N (Deputies)	455	455	455	455	455	455
N (Issues)	7	7	7	7	7	7
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26	26
Issue FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party-State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the association between receiving a media concession in 1987–88 and government alignment, using the legislative response estimating sample described in Section 4. The dependent variable, $Loyalty_{i,j}$, is the government-aligned support score for deputy i on issue j. The treatment variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if deputy i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs) or controls. Column (2) adds issue FEs. Column (3) further adds state FEs. Column (4) further adds party FEs. Column (5) replaces state and party FEs with state-party FEs. Column (6) further controls for the 1986 coalition vote margin and pre-1987 radio and TV concession counts. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_{s(i),p(i)} + \alpha_j + \beta\, Concession_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_{i,j}$. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 5 pools all seven issues. Recipients score 0.128 higher on the government-alignment index before conditioning and 0.115 (0.025) in the saturated column, which absorbs issue, party, state, and state–party fixed effects together with the predetermined covariates. The mean of the index among non-recipients is 0.612, explanatory power rises from 0.018 to 0.187, and the coefficient stays within the band 0.109 to 0.151 across specifications. These estimates are conditional associations: concession receipt is assigned within the elected sample, and the identifying condition—that no unobserved deputy characteristic drives both the license and the vote—is exactly what Table 3 makes implausible: concessions were allocated on the basis of political position, and position is only partly observable.

Table 6: The Association Between Media Concessions and Alignment Is Driven by Non-Ideological Votes

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Concession × Non-Ideological	0.307***	0.307***	0.300***	0.264***	0.273***	0.274***
	(0.042)	(0.042)	(0.041)	(0.043)	(0.046)	(0.047)
Concession × Ideological	-0.038*	-0.015	-0.023	-0.057**	-0.057**	-0.054**
	(0.022)	(0.020)	(0.022)	(0.024)	(0.022)	(0.023)
Difference ($\hat{\beta}^1 - \hat{\beta}^0$)	0.346***	0.322***	0.323***	0.322***	0.330***	0.328***
P-Value (H_0: $\beta^1 = \beta^0$)	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
R-Squared	0.072	0.123	0.151	0.179	0.213	0.216
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612
N (Observations)	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006
N (Observations, Treatment)	400	400	400	400	400	400
N (Observations, Control)	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606
N (Deputies)	455	455	455	455	455	455
N (Issues)	7	7	7	7	7	7
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26	26
N (Observations, Non-Ideological)	910	910	910	910	910	910
N (Obs., Treatment, Non-Ideological)	212	212	212	212	212	212
N (Obs., Control, Non-Ideological)	698	698	698	698	698	698
N (Deputies, Non-Ideological)	455	455	455	455	455	455
N (Issues, Non-Ideological)	2	2	2	2	2	2
N (Clusters, Non-Ideological)	26	26	26	26	26	26
N (Observations, Ideological)	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096
N (Obs., Treatment, Ideological)	188	188	188	188	188	188
N (Obs., Control, Ideological)	908	908	908	908	908	908
N (Deputies, Ideological)	412	412	412	412	412	412
N (Issues, Ideological)	5	5	5	5	5	5
N (Clusters, Ideological)	26	26	26	26	26	26
Issue FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party-State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the association between receiving a media concession in 1987–88 and government alignment, using the legislative response estimating sample described in Section 4, allowing effects to differ across non-ideological and ideological NCA votes. The dependent variable, $Loyalty_{i,j}$, is the government-aligned support score for deputy i on issue j. The treatment variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if deputy i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88. $NonIdeological_j$ equals one for the Presidential System and Five-Year Mandate votes; $Ideological_j$ equals one for the five ideologically divisive topics. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Columns (2)–(6) add issue FEs, state FEs, party FEs, state-party FEs, and pre-determined controls progressively, all interacted with the moderator. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Loyalty_{i,j} = Non\text{-}Ideological_j \cdot (\alpha_j^1 + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}^1 + \boldsymbol{\gamma}^1 \mathbf{x}_i + \beta^1 \, Concession_i) + (1 - Non\text{-}Ideological_j) \cdot (\alpha_j^0 + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}^0 + \boldsymbol{\gamma}^0 \mathbf{x}_i + \beta^0 \, Concession_i) + \varepsilon_{i,j}$. $\hat{\beta}^1 - \hat{\beta}^0$ is tested using the delta method with $G - 1$ cluster degrees of freedom, where G is the number of state clusters. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. $^*p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 6 is the model's signature test. The specification decomposes the concession premium into its non-ideological and its ideological component in a single pooled regression and tests their equality. Recipients score 0.274 (0.047) higher than non-recipients on institutional votes and 0.054 (0.023) *lower* on ideological ones. The difference is 0.328 with a p-value of 0.000 and is stable across every column, moving from 0.346 to 0.328 as fixed effects and controls enter; the non-ideological cell contains 910 deputy–issue observations, 212 of them treated. The ideological coefficient is negative and significant where the model predicts zero. The differential the proposition concerns is unaffected by this, and the negative sign is what one expects if recipients are drawn disproportionately from deputies whose districts pulled against the Executive on redistribution.

Table 7: The Non-Ideological Alignment Differential Holds Within Deputy

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Concession × Non-Ideological	0.346***	0.322***	0.323***	0.322***	0.330***	0.328***	0.360***
	(0.056)	(0.054)	(0.054)	(0.053)	(0.052)	(0.053)	(0.060)
R-Squared	0.072	0.123	0.151	0.179	0.213	0.216	0.414
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612
N (Observations)	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006
N (Observations, Treatment)	400	400	400	400	400	400	400
N (Observations, Control)	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606
N (Observations, Non-Ideological)	910	910	910	910	910	910	910
N (Observations, Ideological)	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096	1,096
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26	26	26
Issue FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party-State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Deputy FEs	No	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the differential alignment premium associated with media concessions on non-ideological relative to ideological NCA votes, using the legislative-response estimating sample described in Section 4. The dependent variable, $Loyalty_{i,j}$, is the government-aligned support score for deputy i on issue j. The treatment variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if deputy i received any federal TV or radio concession in 1987–88. The moderator, $NonIdeological_j$, equals one for the two non-ideological issues (presidential system and five-year mandate) and zero for the five ideologically divisive topics. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds issue FEs. Column (3) adds state FEs. Column (4) adds party FEs. Column (5) adds Party-State FEs. Column (6) adds predetermined controls. Column (7) adds deputy FEs. The reported coefficient is $\hat{\beta}_3$ from $Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_i + \alpha_j + \beta_1 Concession_i + \beta_2 NonIdeological_j + \beta_3 Concession_i \times NonIdeological_j + \mathbf{x}_i'\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \varepsilon_{i,j}$. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 7 re-estimates the same differential with deputy fixed effects, so that each deputy's alignment on institutional votes is compared with the same deputy's alignment on ideological ones. The within-deputy estimate is 0.360 (0.060), larger than the pooled differential, and explanatory power rises to 0.414. Any characteristic that makes a deputy uniformly more pro-government—ideology, party standing, personal disposition toward the Sarney government—is differenced out of that comparison, because it shifts both of a deputy's index values equally and cancels in their difference. Of the 455 deputies in the sample, 412 are observed on both blocks of votes; the remaining 43 appear only on institutional issues and contribute nothing to the within-deputy contrast. A confounder able to generate this pattern would have to raise a recipient's support for the Executive on the system of government and the presidential term while lowering it on agrarian reform and labor rights—the issue-differentiated deviation-cost technology of the model, not a generic selection story. One channel meets that description and is not differenced out, because it varies at the deputy–issue level: coverage of the ideological votes is lower for recipients than for non-recipients, and the benchmark coding turns absence into disalignment. section 7 quantifies the asymmetry and names the exercise that separates the two accounts.

Table 8: Concessions Have a Stronger Association with Political Support Among Government Deputies

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Concession × Government	0.134***	0.161***	0.158***	0.124***	0.136***	0.135***
	(0.021)	(0.023)	(0.022)	(0.023)	(0.027)	(0.029)
Concession × Opposition	0.068	0.082*	0.024	0.005	-0.004	-0.002
	(0.046)	(0.047)	(0.056)	(0.070)	(0.071)	(0.071)
Difference ($\hat{\beta}^1 - \hat{\beta}^0$)	0.066	0.078	0.134**	0.120	0.139*	0.138*
P-Value (H_0: $\beta^1 = \beta^0$)	0.227	0.170	0.041	0.130	0.088	0.094
R-Squared	0.022	0.117	0.159	0.179	0.202	0.205
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612
N (Observations)	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006
N (Observations, Treatment)	400	400	400	400	400	400
N (Observations, Control)	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606
N (Deputies)	455	455	455	455	455	455
N (Issues)	7	7	7	7	7	7
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26	26
N (Observations, Government)	1,467	1,467	1,467	1,467	1,467	1,467
N (Obs., Treatment, Government)	333	333	333	333	333	333
N (Obs., Control, Government)	1,134	1,134	1,134	1,134	1,134	1,134
N (Deputies, Government)	349	349	349	349	349	349
N (Issues, Government)	7	7	7	7	7	7
N (Clusters, Government)	26	26	26	26	26	26
N (Observations, Opposition)	539	539	539	539	539	539
N (Obs., Treatment, Opposition)	67	67	67	67	67	67
N (Obs., Control, Opposition)	472	472	472	472	472	472
N (Deputies, Opposition)	106	106	106	106	106	106
N (Issues, Opposition)	7	7	7	7	7	7
N (Clusters, Opposition)	23	23	23	23	23	23
Issue FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party-State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the alignment premium from media concessions, using the legislative response estimating sample described in Section 4, estimated separately for government and opposition deputies in a fully interacted pooled panel. The dependent variable, $Loyalty_{i,j}$, is the government-aligned support score for deputy i on issue j. The treatment variable, $Concession_i$, equals one if deputy i received any TV or radio concession in 1987–88. $Government_i$ equals one for PMDB and PFL deputies; $Opposition_i$ equals one for all other parties. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Columns (2)–(6) add issue FEs, state FEs, party FEs, state-party FEs, and predetermined controls progressively, all interacted with the moderator. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Loyalty_{i,j} = Government_i \cdot (\alpha_j^1 + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}^1 + \boldsymbol{\gamma}^1 \mathbf{x}_i + \beta^1 \, Concession_i) + (1 - Government_i) \cdot (\alpha_j^0 + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)}^0 + \boldsymbol{\gamma}^0 \mathbf{x}_i + \beta^0 \, Concession_i) + \varepsilon_{i,j}$. $\hat{\beta}^1 - \hat{\beta}^0$ is tested using the delta method with $G - 1$ cluster degrees of freedom, where G is the number of state clusters. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. $^*p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 8 locates the premium in the coalition structure, estimating separate parameters for government and opposition deputies and letting all fixed effects and controls differ across the two. Among PMDB and PFL deputies the association is 0.134 before conditioning and 0.135 (0.029) in the saturated column. Among opposition deputies it runs from 0.068 down to -0.002, reaching the ten percent level in the second column alone. The difference is 0.138 with a p-value of 0.094 in the saturated column and attains conventional significance only in the third, where it is 0.134 with a p-value of 0.041. The ordering tracks the allocation results, though the government–opposition gap is estimated far less precisely than the institutional–ideological gap.

Table 9: Alignment Premia by Concession Technology: Television and Radio-Only

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
TV	0.178***	0.206***	0.190***	0.156***	0.156***	0.163***
	(0.026)	(0.028)	(0.024)	(0.033)	(0.037)	(0.032)
Radio Only	0.106***	0.128***	0.123***	0.088***	0.098***	0.093***
	(0.022)	(0.023)	(0.024)	(0.026)	(0.029)	(0.031)
Difference ($\hat{\beta}^1 - \hat{\beta}^0$)	0.072**	0.078**	0.068*	0.068	0.058	0.070
P-Value (H_0: $\beta^1 = \beta^0$)	0.048	0.050	0.056	0.124	0.213	0.119
R-Squared	0.019	0.097	0.125	0.152	0.185	0.188
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612	0.612
N (Observations)	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006	2,006
N (Observations, TV)	118	118	118	118	118	118
N (Observations, Radio Only)	282	282	282	282	282	282
N (Observations, Control)	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606	1,606
Issue FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FE	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
State×Party FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the alignment premium from media concessions, using the legislative response estimating sample described in Section 4, splitting recipients by type of concession received in a deputy-by-issue panel. The dependent variable, $Loyalty_{i,j}$, is the government-aligned support score for deputy i on issue j. Two mutually exclusive treatment indicators partition concession recipients: TV_i equals one if deputy i received any federal TV concession in 1987–88 (TV-only or TV and radio combined); $RadioOnly_i$ equals one if deputy i received a radio concession but no TV concession in 1987–88. The omitted category is deputies with no 1987–88 media concession. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs) or controls. Column (2) adds issue FEs. Column (3) further adds state FEs. Column (4) further adds party FEs. Column (5) replaces state and party FEs with state-party FEs. Column (6) further controls for the 1986 coalition vote margin and pre-1987 radio and TV concession counts. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_j + \alpha_{s(i),p(i)} + \beta^1 TV_i + \beta^0 RadioOnly_i + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_{i,j}$, where α_j denotes issue fixed effects, $\alpha_{s(i),p(i)}$ denotes state-party fixed effects, and $\boldsymbol{x}_i$ includes the predetermined political and media-ownership controls described in Section 4. The Difference row reports $\hat{\beta}^1 - \hat{\beta}^0$, tested using the delta method with $G - 1$ cluster degrees of freedom, where G is the number of state clusters. Standard errors clustered at the state level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

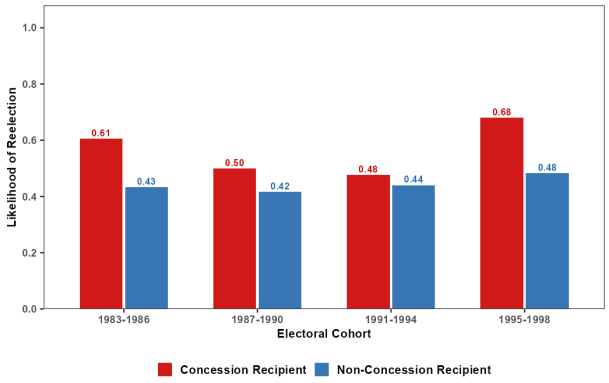
Table 9 decomposes the treatment by technology, on the reasoning that television reaches a larger audience and should deliver more valence per license. Deputies with at least one television concession score 0.163 (0.032) above non-recipients in the saturated column; radio-only recipients score 0.093 (0.031). The point estimates preserve the predicted ordering in every column, but the gap does not survive saturation: it is 0.072 with a p-value of 0.048 in the first column and 0.078 with a p-value of 0.050 in the second, and once state–party fixed effects and controls enter it is 0.070 with a p-value of 0.119. The television cell contains 118 deputy–issue observations and the radio-only cell 282, so the two premia cannot be separated within state–party cells. The legislative-response result is the institutional–ideological differential of Table 6 and Table 7, which is what Proposition 2 predicts and which no uniform pro-government disposition reproduces.

6.3 Electoral Advantage

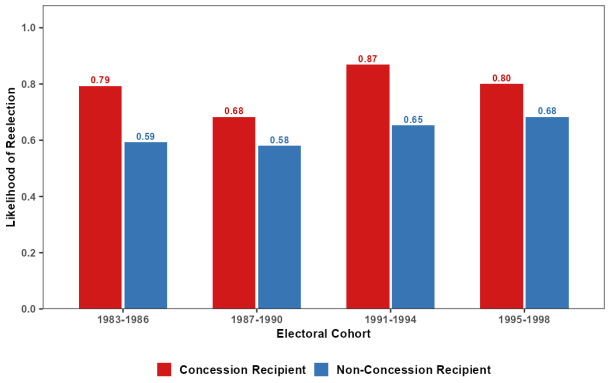
The third prediction concerns what a license is worth once held. Proposition 3 states that a concession delivers valence only to a candidate who holds office, since a defeated candidate has no legislative platform for the station to amplify. The prediction is about an interaction rather than a level: winning a seat should be worth more to a media owner than to a non-owner, and the difference between the two incumbency effects is increasing in the model's valence parameter.

Figure 4: Concession Recipient (Flow Treatment) Is Associated with Higher Reelection Rates among Incumbents, Unconditional and Conditional on Running

(**a**) Unconditional Reelection Rates



(**b**) Conditional Reelection Rates



Notes: This figure presents unconditional and conditional reelection rates by electoral cohort, using the electoral-advantage incumbency estimating sample defined in Section 4. We plot four electoral cohorts, $c \in \{1983\text{–}1986, 1987\text{–}1990, 1991\text{–}1994, 1995\text{–}1998\}$, generated by election years $t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$. Both panels split incumbents according to the flow treatment $Concession_{i,t+1,t+4}$, the indicator for receiving a radio or television concession during the term: red bars plot statistics for treated deputies, those with the indicator equal to one, and blue bars plot statistics for control deputies. Panel (a) plots unconditional reelection rates, $\Pr[Elected_{i,t+4} = 1 \mid Elected_{i,t} = 1]$, separately for treated and control deputies. Panel (b) plots reelection rates conditional on running, $\Pr[Elected_{i,t+4} = 1 \mid Elected_{i,t} = 1,\ Run_{i,t+4} = 1]$, separately for treated and control deputies. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Figure 4 shows the raw difference in reelection rates between incumbents who received a concession during their term and those who did not, unconditionally in panel (a) and conditional on standing again in panel (b). Recipients reelect at higher rates on both margins.

Table 10: Media Concessions Are Associated with Higher Probability of Re-election to Congress

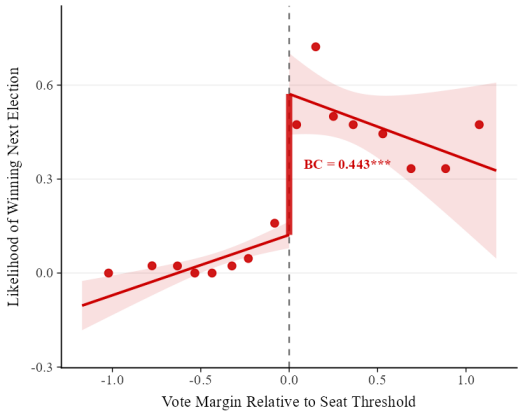
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A: Concession (Flow)						
Concession (term)	0.113***	0.122***	0.130***	0.129***	0.136***	0.141***
	(0.036)	(0.035)	(0.037)	(0.036)	(0.037)	(0.037)
R-Squared	0.005	0.009	0.033	0.056	0.091	0.187
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.448	0.448	0.448	0.448	0.448	0.448
N (Observations)	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811
N (Observations, Treatment)	194	194	194	194	194	194
N (Observations, Control)	1,617	1,617	1,617	1,617	1,617	1,617
N (Clusters)	105	105	105	105	105	105
Panel B: Media Owner (Stock)						
Media Owner	0.095***	0.084***	0.084**	0.075**	0.083**	0.078**
	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.032)	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.034)
R-Squared	0.004	0.006	0.030	0.052	0.087	0.183
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.449	0.449	0.449	0.449	0.449	0.449
N (Observations)	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811
N (Observations, Treatment)	217	217	217	217	217	217
N (Observations, Control)	1,594	1,594	1,594	1,594	1,594	1,594
N (Clusters)	105	105	105	105	105	105
Year FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year × State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year × State × Party FEs	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the association between concession receipt and the probability of being elected to the next federal Congress using the electoral-advantage incumbent estimating sample defined in Section 4. The outcome variable, $Elected_{i,t+4}$, equals one if deputy i won a federal seat in election $t+4$, coded unconditionally (non-runners are assigned zero). Panel A uses the flow treatment variable, $Concession_i$, which equals one if the deputy or any related party received at least one new federal radio or television concession during the term (years $t+1$ through $t+4$; `flow_ct`). Panel B uses the stock treatment variable, $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, which equals one if the deputy held at least one media concession at any point before election year t (cumulative stock; `stock_ct`). Both panels pool four cohorts with origin election years 1982, 1986, 1990, and 1994; the unit of observation is a deputy-cohort pair. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds year FEs. Column (3) further adds state FEs. Column (4) further adds party FEs. Column (5) adds year-by-state FEs. Column (6) adds year-by-state-by-party FEs. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Elected_{i,t+4} = \alpha_{s(i),p(i),t} + \beta Treatment_i + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}$, where $\alpha_{s(i),p(i),t}$ denotes year-by-state-by-party fixed effects and $Treatment_i \in \{Concession_i, MediaOwner_{i,t}\}$ varies by panel. These estimates report partial correlations and should not be interpreted causally. Standard errors clustered at the state-party level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

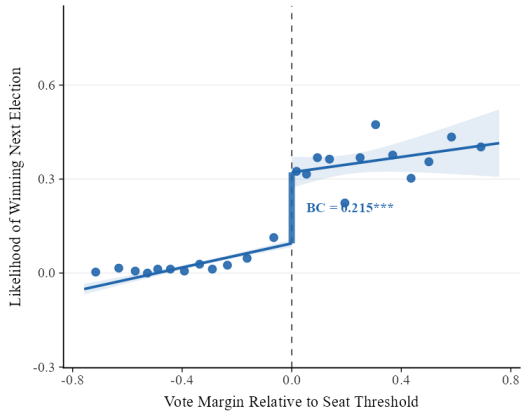
Table 10 places the comparison inside state–party–cohort cells. Incumbents who received a concession while in office are 0.113 more likely to win the following federal election before conditioning and 0.141 more likely in the saturated column, against a mean of 0.448 among incumbents who received nothing. The sample pools four origin cohorts and contains 1,811 observations, 194 of them treated. Two problems keep these estimates descriptive. Unobserved determinants of electoral success—local networks, name recognition, party standing—plausibly predict concession receipt as well. And the treatment is contemporaneous with the outcome window: Table 3 shows that electoral success itself causes concession receipt, so the direction of the relationship is not identified here.

Figure 5: Incumbency Effects by Predetermined Media Ownership: Close-Election Estimates

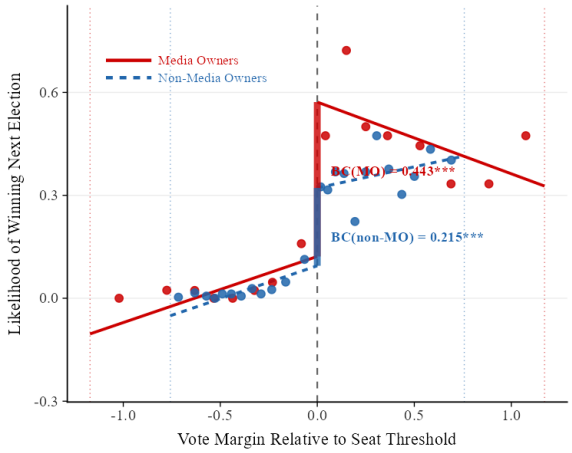
(**a**) Media Owners



(**b**) Non-Media Owners



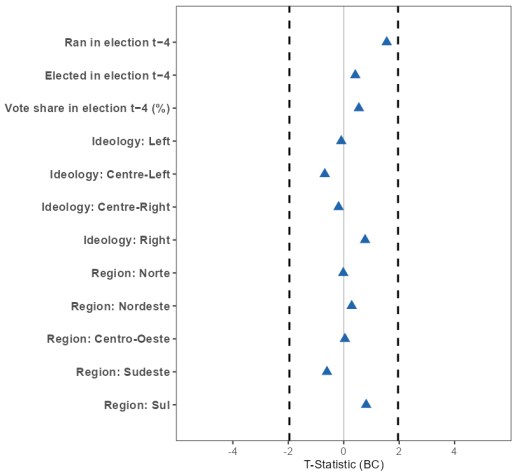
(**c**) Media Owners and Non-Media Owners (Overlay)



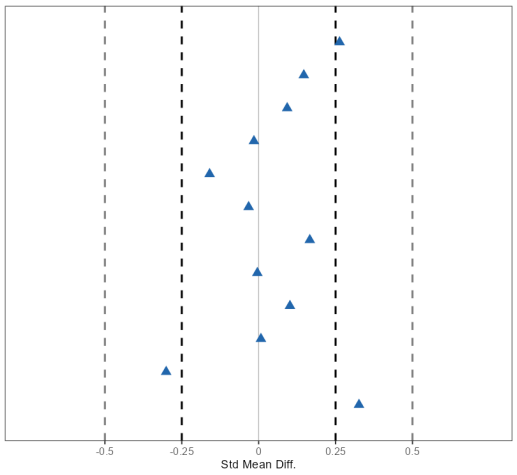
Notes: This figure displays local-linear RDD estimates of the incumbency effect—the causal effect of narrowly winning a Congressional seat in t on winning a Congressional seat in $t+4$—using the electoral-advantage candidates estimating sample defined in Section 4. The sample pools four electoral cohorts with election year $t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$; the unit of observation is a candidate-year pair. Panel A displays $\hat{\tau}^1 = 0.443^{***}$, the incumbency effect in the subsample of media owners. Panel B displays $\hat{\tau}^0 = 0.215^{***}$, the incumbency effect in the subsample of non-media owners. The heterogeneous LATE is $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0 = 0.229^{***}$. Estimates correspond to Column (1) of Table 11 (no fixed effects). All point estimates are bias-corrected and standard errors are robust bias-corrected, as proposed by Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014). The estimating equation is $Elected_{i,t+4} = \tau^G \mathbf{1}(RunVar_{i,t} \geq 0) + f^G(RunVar_{i,t}) + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}$, where $RunVar_{i,t}$ is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin in the origin election t (not normalized across cohorts). $MediaOwner_{i,t}$ equals one if the candidate holds at least one media concession at any point before election year t (cumulative stock, predetermined before the treatment election). The bandwidth is selected by MSERD separately for each group under the no-FEs specification using state-level clustering: $h^1 = 1.171$ for media owners (Panel A) and $h^0 = 0.758$ for non-media owners (Panel B). Dots are equal-frequency bin means within the display window (8 bins per side in Panel A, 12 in Panel B); lines are local-linear fits with triangular kernel weights; shaded bands are 95% confidence intervals. Both panels share the same y-axis scale. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. $^*p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Figure 6: Pre-Treatment Covariates Are Balanced Around the Electoral Cutoff

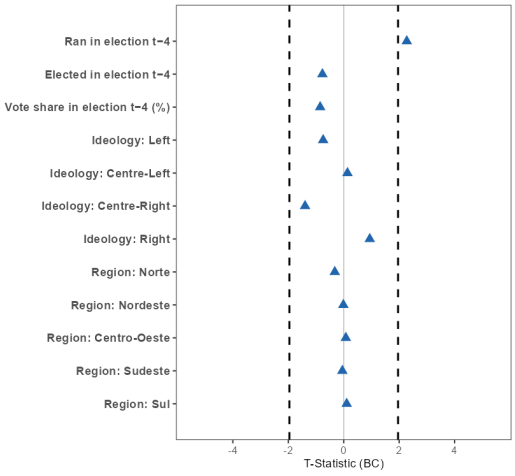
(**a**) Media Owners: T-Statistic



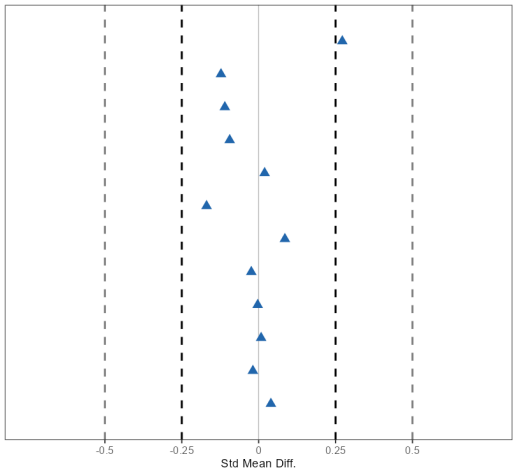
(**b**) Media Owners: Standardized Mean Diff.



(**c**) Non-Media Owners: T-Statistic



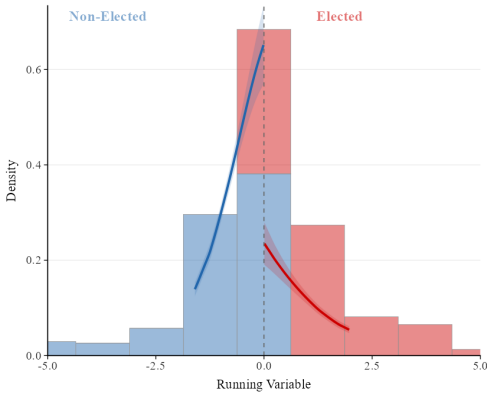
(**d**) Non-Media Owners: Standardized Mean Diff.



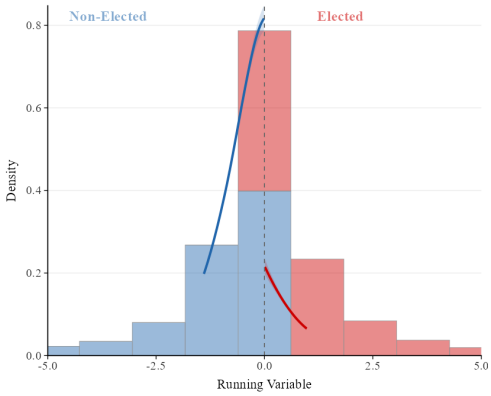
Notes: This figure reports RDD balance checks for the electoral-advantage candidates estimating sample defined in Section 4, estimated separately for Media Owners ($MediaOwner_{i,t} = 1$, panels (a)–(b)) and Non-Media Owners ($MediaOwner_{i,t} = 0$, panels (c)–(d)). $MediaOwner_{i,t}$ equals one if the deputy held any media concession at any point before origin election year t (cumulative stock, predetermined). The sample is stacked across four origin-election cohorts ($t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$). The running variable $RunVar_{i,t}$ is the raw within-coalition, within-state vote margin in origin election t (no cohort normalization). For each pre-treatment covariate $x_{i,k} \in \mathbf{x}_i$, we estimate the RDD using a linear polynomial ($p = 1$), triangular kernel, and a bandwidth selected separately for that covariate: bandwidths range from $h = 0.7369$ to $h = 1.4117$ among Media Owners and from $h = 0.4087$ to $h = 0.9491$ among Non-Media Owners. Each covariate-specific bandwidth is selected by `rdrobust` with `bwselect=''mserd''` applied to that covariate as the outcome, clustered at the state level; imposing a single bandwidth on every covariate would under-power the test for rows whose MSE-optimal window differs from it, so each row is estimated at its own bandwidth. We report bias-corrected (BC) estimates and robust BC standard errors (CCT, 2014). Panels (a) and (c) plot the bias-corrected t-statistic; dashed lines mark ± 1.96. Panels (b) and (d) plot the standardized mean difference $\hat{\tau}_k^{bc}/\hat{\sigma}_k$; dashed lines mark ± 0.25 and ± 0.50. Under local randomization at the cutoff, all estimates should be statistically indistinguishable from zero. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Figure 7: The Incumbency Premium Differential Between Media Owners and Non-Media Owners Is Consistent with a Causal Interpretation

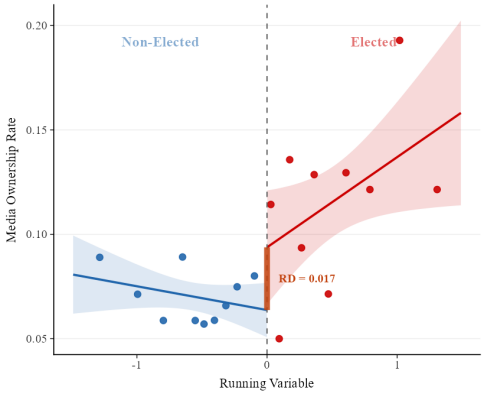
(**a**) Density of Running Variable, Media Owners



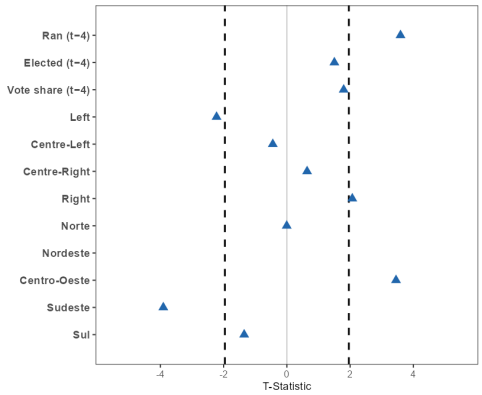
(**b**) Density of Running Variable, Non-Media Owners



(**c**) Continuity of the Moderator



(**d**) Balance Check between Media Owners and Non-Media Owners



Notes: This figure presents four diagnostic checks for the causal interpretation of the heterogeneous local average treatment effect (HLATE) of incumbency for media owners versus non-media owners, reported in Table 11 and estimated using the electoral-advantage candidates estimating sample described in Section 4. The moderator, $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, equals one if deputy i held any media concession at any point before origin election year t (cumulative stock, predetermined). The sample is stacked across four origin-election cohorts ($t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$). The running variable $RunVar_{i,t}$ is the raw within-coalition, within-state vote margin in origin election t (no cohort normalization). Panels (a) and (b) display the distribution of $RunVar_{i,t}$ for media owners ($N = 739$) and non-media owners ($N = 8,433$), respectively; the smooth density is estimated via `lpdensity` with a jackknife bandwidth, scaled separately on each side of the cutoff. Panel (c) tests the continuity of the moderator at the electoral cutoff (Assumption 2 of Becker, Egger, and von Ehrlich 2013): the outcome is $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, the estimator is `rdrobust` with a linear polynomial ($p = 1$), triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, and standard errors clustered at the state level via nearest-neighbor variance estimation; a flat slope at the cutoff indicates the moderator does not jump discontinuously with electoral victory. Panel (d) tests the conditional independence of the moderator (Assumption 3): for each of the 12 pre-treatment covariates $x_{i,k}$ (three lagged outcomes, four ideological indicators, five regional indicators), it plots the t-statistic from the OLS regression $x_{i,k} = \alpha + \beta\, MediaOwner_{i,t} + \gamma\, RunVar_{i,t} + \varepsilon_i$, estimated within the combined RDD window $|RunVar_{i,t}| \leq h_{\text{max}}$, where $h_{\text{max}} = \max(h^{MO}, h^{NMO}) = 1.1713$ ($N = 6,400$); dashed lines mark ± 1.96. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The heterogeneous close-election design removes the second problem by construction and makes the first testable. It uses the predetermined stock measure of media ownership—holdings observed up to and including the origin election—so the moderator cannot be a consequence of the outcome, and it estimates the incumbency effect separately within owners and non-owners. Figure 5 plots the two discontinuities side by side, Figure 6 shows predetermined covariates continuous through the threshold, and Figure 7 reports the tests specific to the heterogeneous design: the running-variable density within each ownership group, the continuity of the ownership indicator at the cutoff, and covariate balance between owners and non-owners near the threshold.

Table 11: Media Ownership (Before Treatment) is Associated with Larger Incumbency Effect

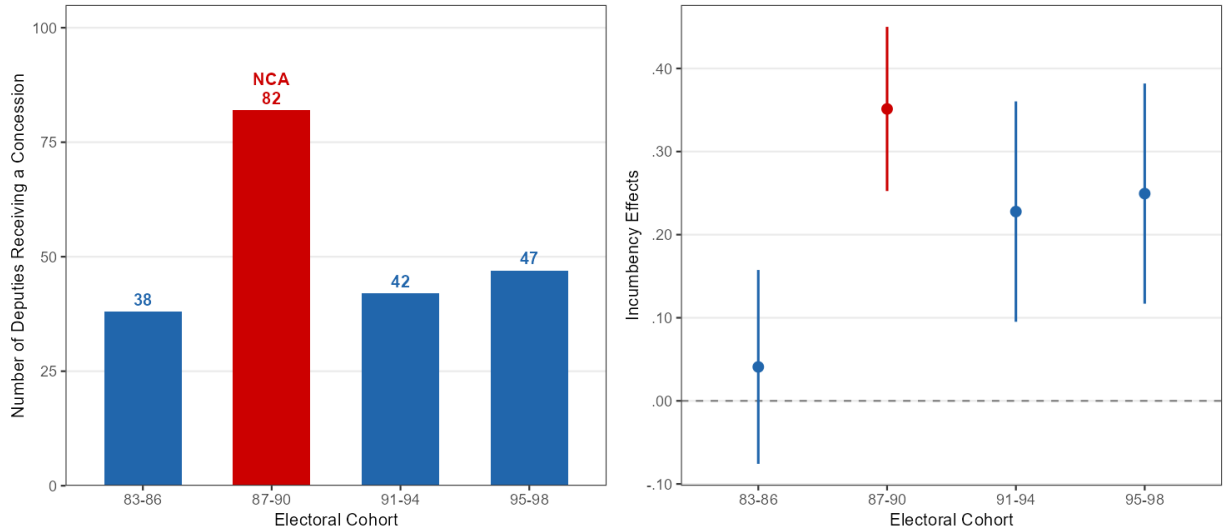
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A: Media Owners ($\hat{\tau}^1$)						
Elected	0.443***	0.445***	0.440***	0.440***	0.451***	0.427***
	(0.073)	(0.073)	(0.071)	(0.057)	(0.053)	(0.050)
95% CI	[0.30, 0.59]	[0.30, 0.59]	[0.30, 0.58]	[0.33, 0.55]	[0.35, 0.55]	[0.33, 0.52]
Bandwidth	1.171	1.171	1.171	1.171	1.171	1.171
N (Full Sample)	739	739	739	739	739	739
N (Within Bandwidth)	495	495	495	495	495	495
N (Left of Cutoff)	348	348	348	348	348	348
N (Right of Cutoff)	147	147	147	147	147	147
% of full sample	67.0%	67.0%	67.0%	67.0%	67.0%	67.0%
Panel B: Non-Media Owners ($\hat{\tau}^0$)						
Elected	0.215***	0.214***	0.204***	0.204***	0.200***	0.164***
	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.030)	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.026)
95% CI	[0.15, 0.28]	[0.15, 0.28]	[0.15, 0.26]	[0.15, 0.26]	[0.14, 0.26]	[0.11, 0.22]
Bandwidth	0.758	0.758	0.758	0.758	0.758	0.758
N (Full Sample)	8,433	8,433	8,433	8,433	8,433	8,433
N (Within Bandwidth)	4,731	4,731	4,731	4,731	4,731	4,731
N (Left of Cutoff)	3,815	3,815	3,815	3,815	3,815	3,815
N (Right of Cutoff)	916	916	916	916	916	916
% of full sample	56.1%	56.1%	56.1%	56.1%	56.1%	56.1%
Panel C: HLATE ($\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$)						
$\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$	0.229***	0.231***	0.235***	0.236***	0.251***	0.262***
	(0.080)	(0.080)	(0.078)	(0.064)	(0.061)	(0.056)
P-value	0.004	0.004	0.002	0.000	0.000	0.000
Year FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year × Party FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year × Party × State FEs	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports local-linear RDD estimates of the incumbency effect—i.e., the causal effect of narrowly winning a Congressional seat in t on winning a Congressional seat in $t+4$—using the electoral-advantage candidates estimating sample defined in Section 4. The sample pools four electoral cohorts with election year $t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$. The unit of observation is a candidate-year pair. Panel A reports $\hat{\tau}^1$, the incumbency effect in the subsample of media owners. Panel B reports $\hat{\tau}^0$, the incumbency effect in the subsample of non-media owners. Panel C reports $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$, the difference between the incumbency effects of media owners and non-media owners, and the p-value of the null hypothesis $H_0 : \tau^1 = \tau^0$. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds year FEs. Column (3) further adds party FEs. Column (4) further adds state FEs. Column (5) adds year-by-party FEs. Column (6) adds year-by-party-by-state FEs. For each media-ownership group $G \in \{0, 1\}$, where $G = 1$ denotes candidates with $MediaOwner_{i,t} = 1$ and $G = 0$ denotes candidates without media ownership, the estimating equation is $Elected_{i,t+4} = \alpha^G_{s(i),p(i),t} + \tau^G \mathbf{1}(RunVar_{i,t} \geq 0) + f^G(RunVar_{i,t}) + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}$, where $Elected_{i,t+4}$ is an indicator for winning a seat in election $t+4$ and $RunVar_{i,t}$ is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin in the origin election t. $MediaOwner_{i,t}$ equals one if the candidate holds at least one media concession at any point before election year t (cumulative stock, predetermined before the treatment election). All specifications use `rdrobust` ($p = 1$, triangular kernel, nearest-neighbor variance) with fixed effects entered as covariate adjustments via the `covs` argument, following the Frisch–Waugh–Lovell partialling approach. We report bias-corrected (BC) coefficient estimates together with robust BC standard errors, as proposed by Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014). The bandwidth is selected separately for each group by MSERD under the no-fixed-effects specification of Column (1), using state-level clustering: $h = 1.171$ for media owners and $h = 0.758$ for non-media owners. The bandwidth is held fixed across all columns within each panel. The standard error of $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ equals $\sqrt{\text{SE}^2_{\text{rbc},m} + \text{SE}^2_{\text{rbc},nm}}$, where the subscript rbc denotes the robust bias-corrected standard error. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. $^*p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 11 reports the two incumbency effects and their difference. Among candidates already holding a concession at the origin election, narrowly winning raises the probability of winning the next federal election by 0.427 (0.050) in the saturated column, with an interval of $[0.33, 0.52]$; the bandwidth of 1.171 retains 495 of 739 owner observations, 348 below the cutoff and 147 above. Among non-owners the same event raises reelection by 0.164 (0.026), with an interval of $[0.11, 0.22]$ and a bandwidth of 0.758 retaining 4,731 of 8,433 observations. Panel C reports the difference: 0.262 (0.056), with a p-value of 0.000. The difference is significant at the one percent level in every column and rises from 0.229 to 0.262 across the table; the rise comes almost entirely from the non-owner effect, which falls from 0.215 to 0.164 as fixed effects enter, while the owner effect moves from 0.443 to 0.427.

Under the conditions of section 5, this difference is the causal return to office that accrues to candidates who already held a broadcast asset and not to those who did not. Its mapping to the model is proportional rather than exact. The valence parameter Γ of (2) is an increment to expected vote share, while τ^G is a difference in the probability of holding a seat, so the two are linked by the density of counterfactual vote share at the winning threshold; and Proposition 3 sets to zero the share of Γ that a defeated owner captures. Relaxing that restriction to a share λ scales the difference by $(1 - \lambda)$. The estimate is therefore a lower bound on the complementarity the proposition describes, and it is signed as the proposition requires.

Figure 8: Incumbency Effects and Media Concessions Peak During the National Constitutional Assembly (1987-1990 Electoral Cohort)



Notes: This figure displays concession volume and incumbency effects across electoral cohorts, using the electoral-advantage incumbency estimating sample described in Section 4. We denote each electoral cohort by $c \in \{1983\text{–}1986, 1987\text{–}1990, 1991\text{–}1994, 1995\text{–}1998\}$, generated by election years $t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$. The concession-recipients panel displays $\#ConcessionRecipients_c = \sum_{i=1}^{N_c} \mathbf{1}\left[\sum_{k \in c} Concession_{i,k} > 0\right]$, the number of incumbent deputies in cohort c who received at least one new federal radio or television concession during their term. The red bar marks the National Constitutional Assembly (NCA) cohort (1987–90). The incumbency-effect panel shows $\Pr[Elected_{i,t+4} = 1 \mid Run_{i,t} = 1, Elected_{i,t} = 1] - \Pr[Elected_{i,t+4} = 1 \mid Run_{i,t} = 1, Elected_{i,t} = 0]$, the causal effect of narrowly winning on reelection. Incumbency effects are estimated separately for each cohort using local-linear regressions with a triangular kernel and MSE-optimal bandwidth. We display 95% robust bias-corrected confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Figure 8 estimates the pooled incumbency effect separately by origin cohort. The premium is largest for the cohort elected in 1986 and serving through the Constituent Assembly, the period in which executive discretion over licensing was widest and the concessions of Table 3 were granted. Four cohorts support a description, not a test: the same years carry a new constitution, hyperinflation and the 1989–90 electoral cycle, and the figure plots the pooled effect by cohort rather than the ownership differential.

6.4 Mechanisms

The electoral advantage can operate on either of two margins: a license may raise the probability that an incumbent stands again, or the probability of winning among those who stand. The model speaks to the second—valence enters the incumbent's vote-share condition, and nothing attaches a license to the decision to run. The two tables below separate the margins using the specification progression of Table 10.

Table 12: Media Concessions Are Not Associated with Recandidacy

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A: Concession (Flow)						
Concession (term)	0.021	0.019	0.033	0.031	0.031	0.053
	(0.038)	(0.038)	(0.037)	(0.038)	(0.038)	(0.041)
R-Squared	0.000	0.003	0.042	0.055	0.105	0.210
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.706	0.706	0.706	0.706	0.706	0.706
N (Observations)	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811
N (Observations, Treatment)	194	194	194	194	194	194
N (Observations, Control)	1,617	1,617	1,617	1,617	1,617	1,617
N (Clusters)	105	105	105	105	105	105
Panel B: Media Owner (Stock)						
Media Owner	-0.009	0.001	0.009	0.006	0.010	0.023
	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.032)	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.035)
R-Squared	0.000	0.003	0.041	0.055	0.105	0.209
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.710	0.710	0.710	0.710	0.710	0.710
N (Observations)	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811	1,811
N (Observations, Treatment)	217	217	217	217	217	217
N (Observations, Control)	1,594	1,594	1,594	1,594	1,594	1,594
N (Clusters)	105	105	105	105	105	105
Year FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year × State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year × State × Party FEs	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the association between concession receipt and the probability of running for the next federal Congress using the electoral-advantage incumbent estimating sample defined in Section 4. The outcome variable, $Run_{i,t+4}$, equals one if deputy i ran in election $t+4$, coded unconditionally (non-runners are assigned zero). Panel A uses the flow treatment variable, $Concession_i$, which equals one if the deputy or any related party received at least one new federal radio or television concession during the term (years $t+1$ through $t+4$; `flow_ct`). Panel B uses the stock treatment variable, $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, which equals one if the deputy held at least one media concession at any point before election year t (cumulative stock; `stock_ct`). Both panels pool four cohorts with origin election years 1982, 1986, 1990, and 1994; the unit of observation is a deputy-cohort pair. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds year FEs. Column (3) further adds state FEs. Column (4) further adds party FEs. Column (5) adds year-by-state FEs. Column (6) adds year-by-state-by-party FEs. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Run_{i,t+4} = \alpha_{s(i),p(i),t} + \beta\, Treatment_i + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}$, where $\alpha_{s(i),p(i),t}$ denotes year-by-state-by-party fixed effects and $Treatment_i \in \{Concession_i, MediaOwner_{i,t}\}$ varies by panel. These estimates report partial correlations and should not be interpreted causally. Standard errors clustered at the state-party level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 12 replaces the outcome with an indicator for standing in the following federal election. The estimates are small and cannot be distinguished from zero in any column, running from 0.021 without fixed effects to 0.053 (0.041) in the saturated one, against a mean of 0.706 among incumbents who received no concession. The sample is the same 1,811 observations with 194 treated used in Table 10. The interval around the saturated estimate still admits an increase of roughly thirteen points in the probability of standing again, so the evidence bounds the recandidacy margin rather than closing it.

Table 13: Media Concessions Are Associated with Higher Re-election Rates Conditional on Running

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A: Concession (Flow)						
Concession (term)	0.138***	0.154***	0.155***	0.151***	0.158***	0.127***
	(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.035)	(0.036)	(0.038)	(0.041)
R-Squared	0.008	0.021	0.039	0.074	0.129	0.231
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.627	0.627	0.627	0.627	0.627	0.627
N (Observations)	1,218	1,218	1,218	1,218	1,218	1,218
N (Observations, Treatment)	132	132	132	132	132	132
N (Observations, Control)	1,086	1,086	1,086	1,086	1,086	1,086
N (Clusters)	99	99	99	99	99	99
Panel B: Media Owner (Stock)						
Media Owner	0.144***	0.120***	0.118***	0.099***	0.105***	0.094**
	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.033)	(0.036)	(0.037)	(0.037)
R-Squared	0.009	0.017	0.035	0.069	0.124	0.228
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.625	0.625	0.625	0.625	0.625	0.625
N (Observations)	1,218	1,218	1,218	1,218	1,218	1,218
N (Observations, Treatment)	143	143	143	143	143	143
N (Observations, Control)	1,075	1,075	1,075	1,075	1,075	1,075
N (Clusters)	99	99	99	99	99	99
Year FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year × State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Year × State × Party FEs	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports OLS estimates of the association between concession receipt and the probability of being elected conditional on running in the next federal election, using the electoral-advantage incumbent estimating sample defined in Section 4. The estimation sample is restricted to deputies who ran in election $t+4$ ($Run_{i,t+4} = 1$). The outcome variable, $Elected_{i,t+4} \mid Run_{i,t+4} = 1$, equals one if deputy i won a seat given that they chose to run. Panel A uses the flow treatment variable, $Concession_i$, which equals one if the deputy or any related party received at least one new federal radio or television concession during the term (years $t+1$ through $t+4$; `flow_ct`). Panel B uses the stock treatment variable, $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, which equals one if the deputy held at least one media concession at any point before election year t (cumulative stock; `stock_ct`). Both panels pool four cohorts with origin election years 1982, 1986, 1990, and 1994; the unit of observation is a deputy-cohort pair among runners. Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds year FEs. Column (3) further adds state FEs. Column (4) further adds party FEs. Column (5) adds year-by-state FEs. Column (6) adds year-by-state-by-party FEs. The most complete specification in Column (6) is $Elected_{i,t+4} = \alpha_{s(i),p(i),t} + \beta\, Treatment_i + \varepsilon_{i,t+4}$, where $\alpha_{s(i),p(i),t}$ denotes year-by-state-by-party fixed effects, estimated on the subsample of runners, and $Treatment_i \in \{Concession_i,\ MediaOwner_{i,t}\}$ varies by panel. These estimates report partial correlations and should not be interpreted causally. Standard errors clustered at the state-party level are reported in parentheses. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 13 restricts the sample to incumbents who did stand and asks whether they won. Among the 1,218 observations meeting the restriction, 132 of them treated, recipients are 0.138 more likely to win before conditioning and 0.127 more likely in the saturated column, against a mean of 0.627 among non-recipients. The estimates are significant at the one percent level throughout and close in magnitude to those of Table 10, as the recandidacy result implies: with no detectable difference in who ran, restricting the sample to runners removes little of the difference in who won. Decomposed at the saturated estimates, the winning margin accounts for $0.706 \times 0.127 = 0.090$ of the unconditional difference and the running margin for $0.053 \times 0.627 = 0.033$, so the advantage operates mainly, though not exclusively, on winning; the two components reconstruct 0.123 of the 0.141 unconditional difference, the remainder reflecting the different estimation samples of the two tables. The two tables locate the association on the margin the model specifies: concession receipt is unrelated to whether a deputy sought reelection and is related to whether the attempt succeeded. These estimates share the identification limits of Table 10, and the causal weight of the electoral-advantage evidence rests on Table 11. With the two preceding subsections they complete the chain the propositions describe: the Executive targeted the legislators it could move, recipients aligned with the Executive precisely on the votes it valued, and holding a broadcast asset multiplied what office was worth in the elections that followed.

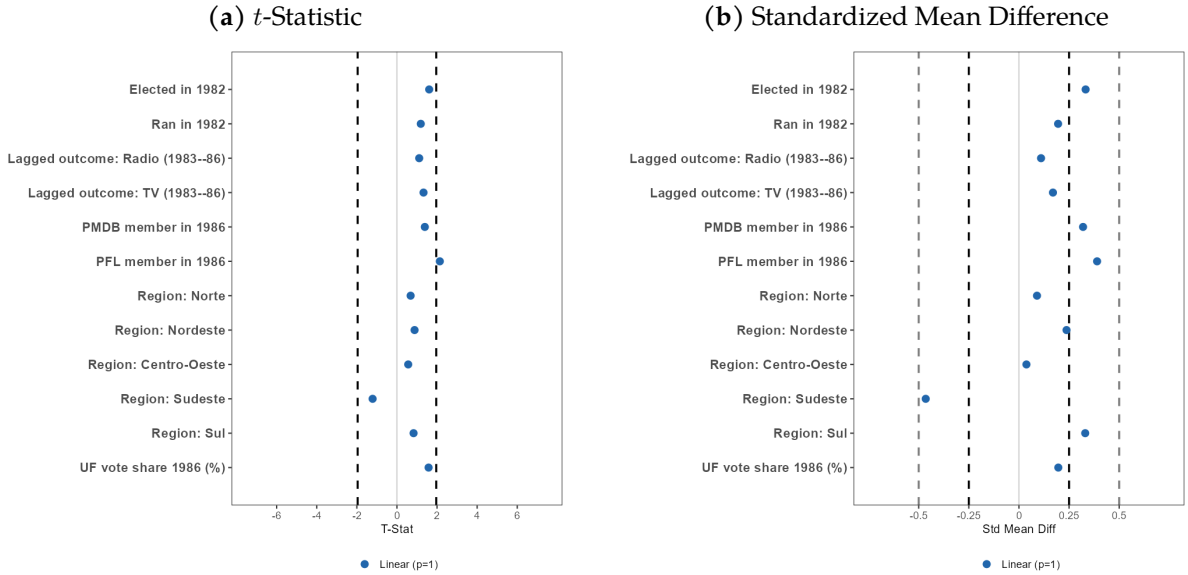
7 Complementary Results

7.1 Allocation

The close-election estimate of Table 3 carries the causal weight of the allocation result, and this subsection puts it through the checks a sharp RD design invites: covariate balance, specification and bandwidth choice, false cutoffs, polynomial order, and comparison groups narrower than the state. Figure 9 takes the first. Each predetermined covariate in $\mathbf{x}_i$

is used in turn as the outcome of the baseline specification, and the resulting discontinuity is plotted as a t-statistic in panel (a) and as a standardized mean difference in panel (b). The threat is that narrow winners and narrow losers differ in ways that predict licensing independently of the seat. No covariate's estimated jump crosses the thresholds the panels mark: narrow winners and narrow losers do not differ detectably on any characteristic recorded before the 1986 election.

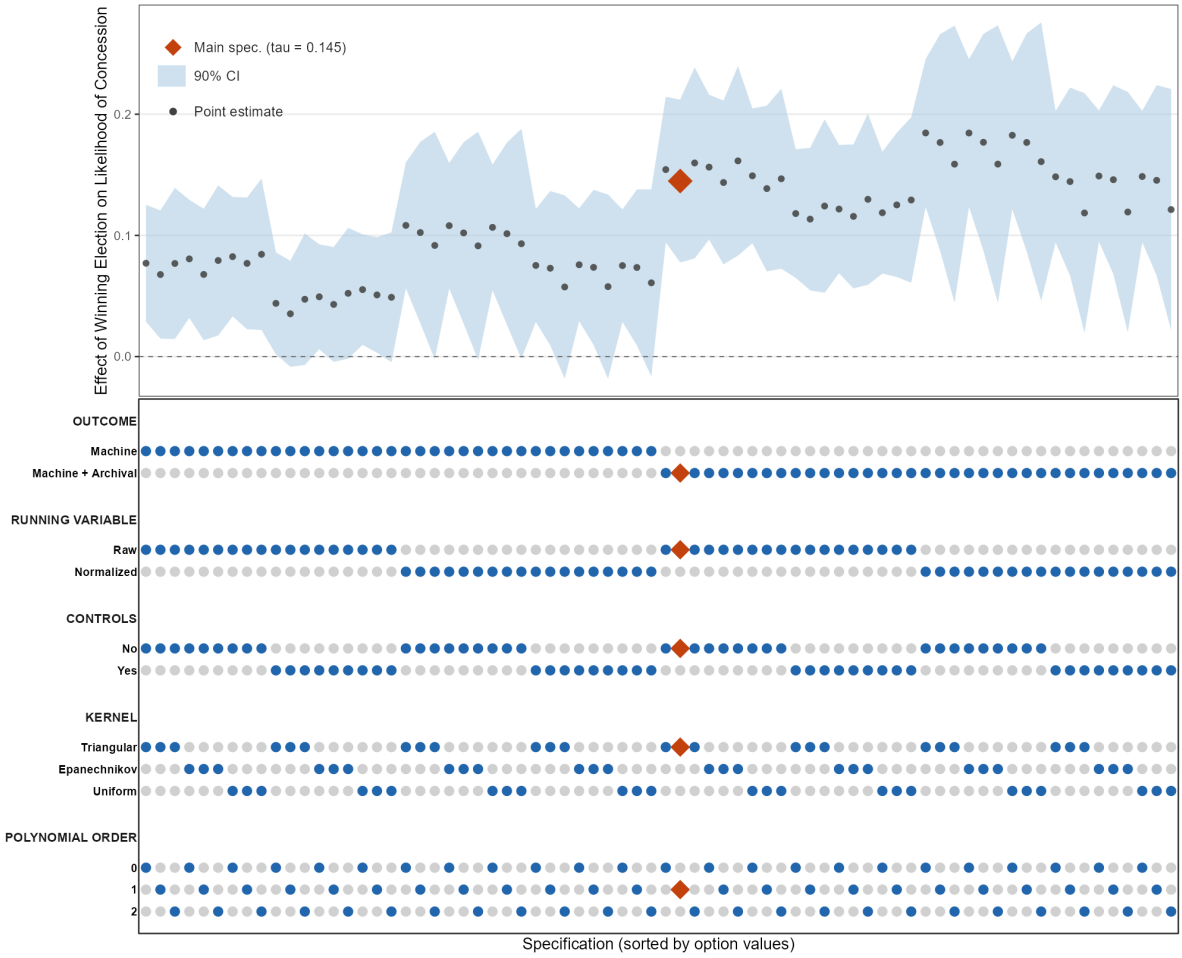
Figure 9: Pre-Treatment Covariates Are Balanced Around the Electoral Cutoff



Notes: This figure reports RDD balance check statistics using the media allocation estimating sample. For each pre-treatment covariate $x_{i,k} \in \mathbf{x}_i$, we estimate $x_{i,k} = \tau_k \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$, where $RunVar_i$ is the within-coalition-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold and $f(\cdot)$ is a local-linear polynomial. We estimate each covariate RDD using a triangular kernel, an MSE-optimal bandwidth, and standard errors clustered at the state level. Panel (a) plots the conventional t-statistic associated with the hypothesis $H_0 : \tau_k = 0$, defined as $t_k = \hat{\tau}_k / \widehat{SE}(\hat{\tau}_k)$, where $\widehat{SE}(\hat{\tau}_k)$ is the conventional RD standard error; dashed lines mark ± 1.96. Panel (b) plots the standardized mean difference, defined as $\Delta_k = \hat{\tau}_k / \hat{\sigma}_k$, where $\hat{\sigma}_k = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N-1} \sum_{i=1}^{N} (x_{i,k} - \bar{x}_k)^2}$ is the full-sample standard deviation of covariate $x_{i,k}$; dashed lines mark the thresholds for small effects (± 0.25) and large effects (± 0.50).

Balance disciplines the comparison but not the estimator. A second objection is that the baseline is a choice among the many estimates the same data admit, and Figure 10 answers it by reporting all of them. The grid crosses two codings of the outcome, machine-readable administrative records alone against those records combined with archival sources, with two codings of the running variable, three kernels, polynomial orders $p \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ and the inclusion or exclusion of $\mathbf{x}_i$, producing 72 estimates plotted with their 90 percent robust bias-corrected intervals. The baseline sits inside that distribution rather than at its edge.

Figure 10: RDD Robustness Analysis Shows that the Effect of Winning on the Likelihood of Concession Is Robust to Specification Choices

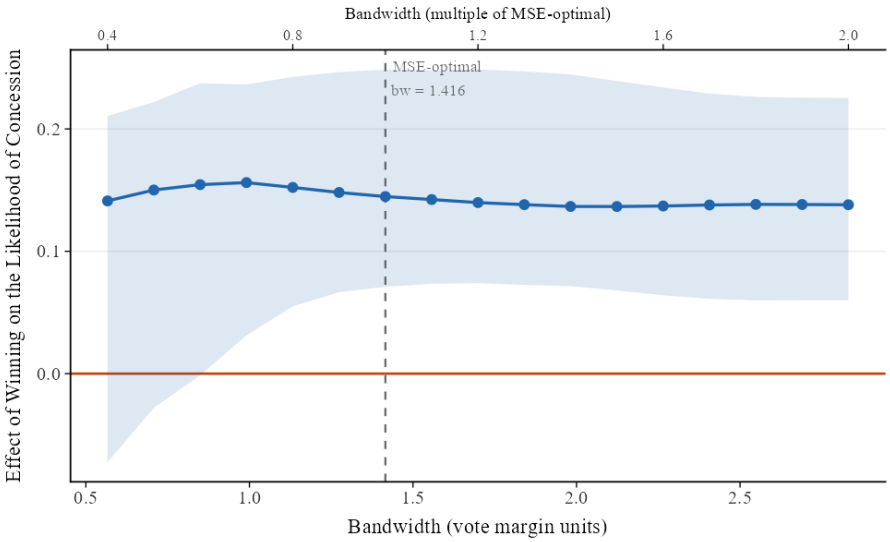


Notes: This figure presents a specification-check graph probing the robustness of the media allocation RDD estimate across several specification choices. The specification grid varies in five dimensions: outcome coding, running-variable coding, controls, RD polynomial, and RD kernel, generating 72 different RDD estimates. There are two possible codings of the outcome: $Concession_i$, which combines machine-readable administrative records and archival sources; and $ConcessionMachine_i$, which uses only machine-readable administrative records. There are two possible codings of the running variable: *Raw*, $RunVar_i$, the within-coalition-state vote margin; and $RunVarNorm_i$, the running variable expressed in percentage points of state vote share. There are two possible control choices: unconditional, which does not include any control variables; and conditional, which includes the control vector $\mathbf{x}_i$. There are three possible kernel functions: triangular, Epanechnikov, and uniform. There are three possible polynomial orders: $p \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. Each specification uses a local-polynomial RDD estimator with MSE-optimal bandwidth and robust bias-corrected inference, with standard errors clustered at the state level. The shaded band shows the 90% robust bias-corrected confidence interval. Specifications are sorted lexicographically by option values across the five dimensions, in the order they appear in the lower panel. The orange diamond in the upper panel identifies the baseline estimate from Table 3 ($\hat{\tau} = 0.145$). A blue dot in the lower panel indicates that the specification uses the corresponding option value, while a light-gray dot indicates that it does not. The orange diamond in the lower panel marks the option values used in the main specification. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

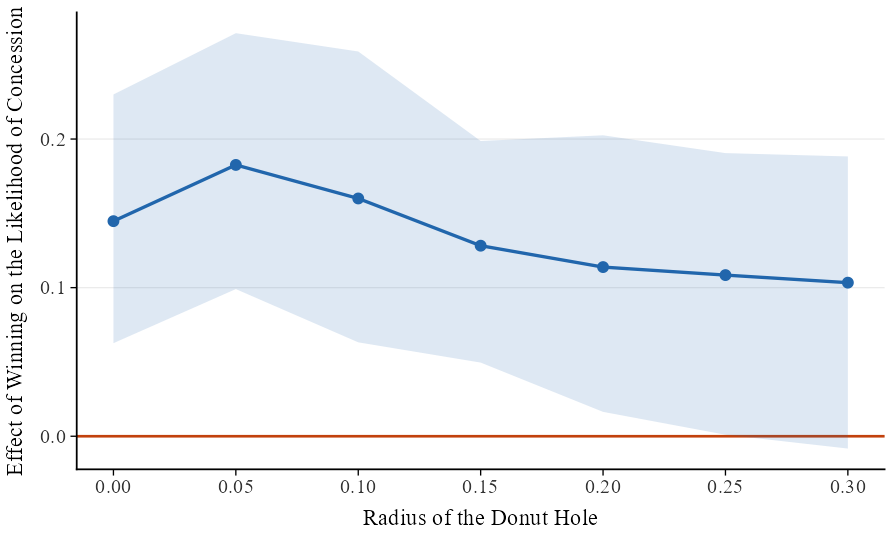
Two choices change the sample the estimator sees, and Figure 11 isolates them. Panel (a) traces the local-linear estimate across bandwidths from 0.4 to 2.0 times the MSE-optimal value, testing whether the discontinuity belongs to the data near the threshold or to the window the selector returned; the path is flat and widens where the window shrinks. Panel (b) removes candidates within a distance d of the threshold, for d up to 0.30, and reselects the bandwidth at each radius. This is the sorting check in severe form: if manipulated margins produced the jump, deleting them would erase it. The donut estimates do not fall, matching Panel B of Table 3, where the 0.10 donut raises the estimate from 0.140 to 0.152.

Figure 11: Concession Effects Are Robust to Bandwidth and Donut Hole Choices

(**a**) Robustness to Bandwidth Choices



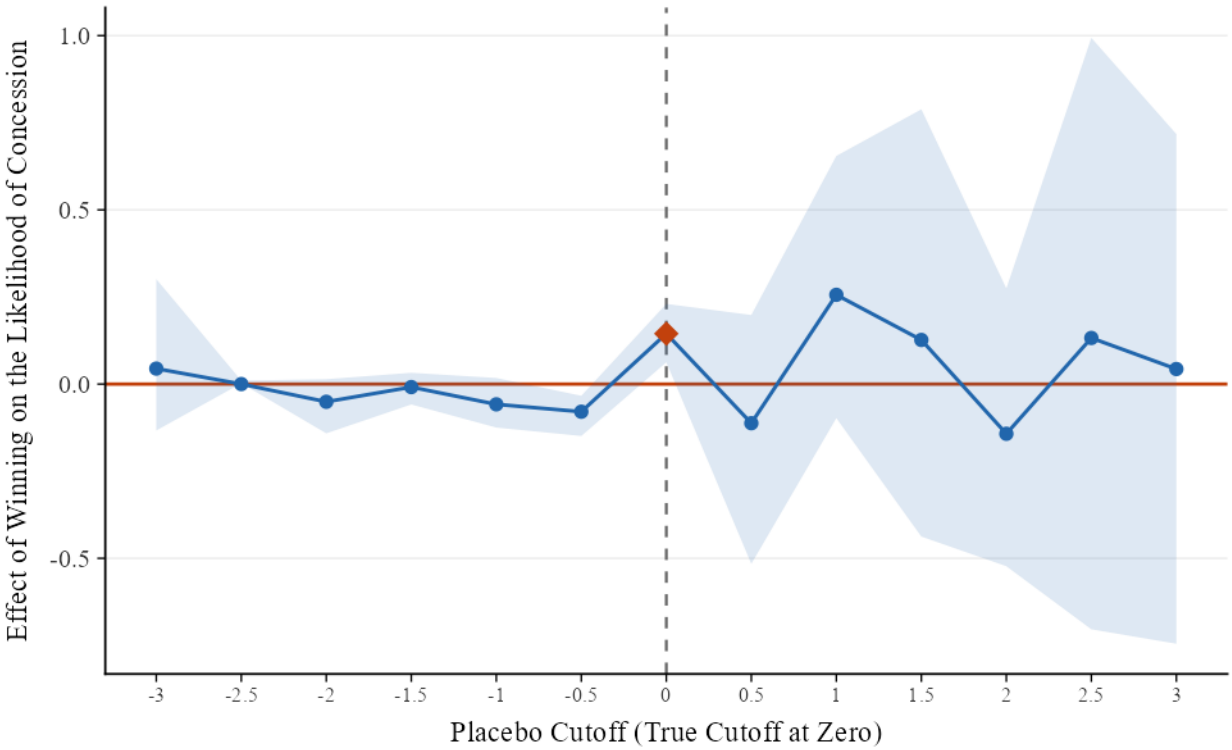
(**b**) Robustness to Donut Hole Size



Notes: This figure displays two robustness exercises for the baseline RDD estimate of the effect of $Elected_i$ on $Concession_i$ reported in Column (1) of Table 4: $\hat{\tau} = 0.145$, with a 95% robust bias-corrected confidence interval of $[0.071,\ 0.248]$. Graph (a) shows the bandwidth-sensitivity path: each point is the local-linear RD estimate at a fixed bandwidth ranging from 0.4 to 2.0 times the MSE-optimal bandwidth, $h^* = 1.416$, marked by a vertical dashed line. The top x-axis shows each bandwidth as a multiple of h^*, and the bottom x-axis shows the actual value of h. Graph (b) shows robustness to a two-sided donut RDD: each point drops all candidates with $|RunVar_i| < d$, for $d \in \{0, 0.05, \ldots, 0.30\}$, and re-estimates the RDD using an MSE-optimal bandwidth for each value of d. Both graphs use a triangular kernel and nearest-neighbor variance estimation, with standard errors clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

A third objection is that the fitting procedure would find a jump anywhere. Figure 12 tests it by moving the cutoff within the 1986 election. The exercise re-estimates the baseline specification at twelve false thresholds displaced from the seat cutoff, from -3.0 to -0.5 and from 0.5 to 3.0 in steps of 0.5, holding the estimator fixed and using only the side of the true cutoff on which each false cutoff lies, so that no placebo borrows the true discontinuity. The estimated jumps are centered on zero and the true cutoff is the outlier. The design does not manufacture discontinuities in a smooth running variable; it locates one where the institution places the seat.

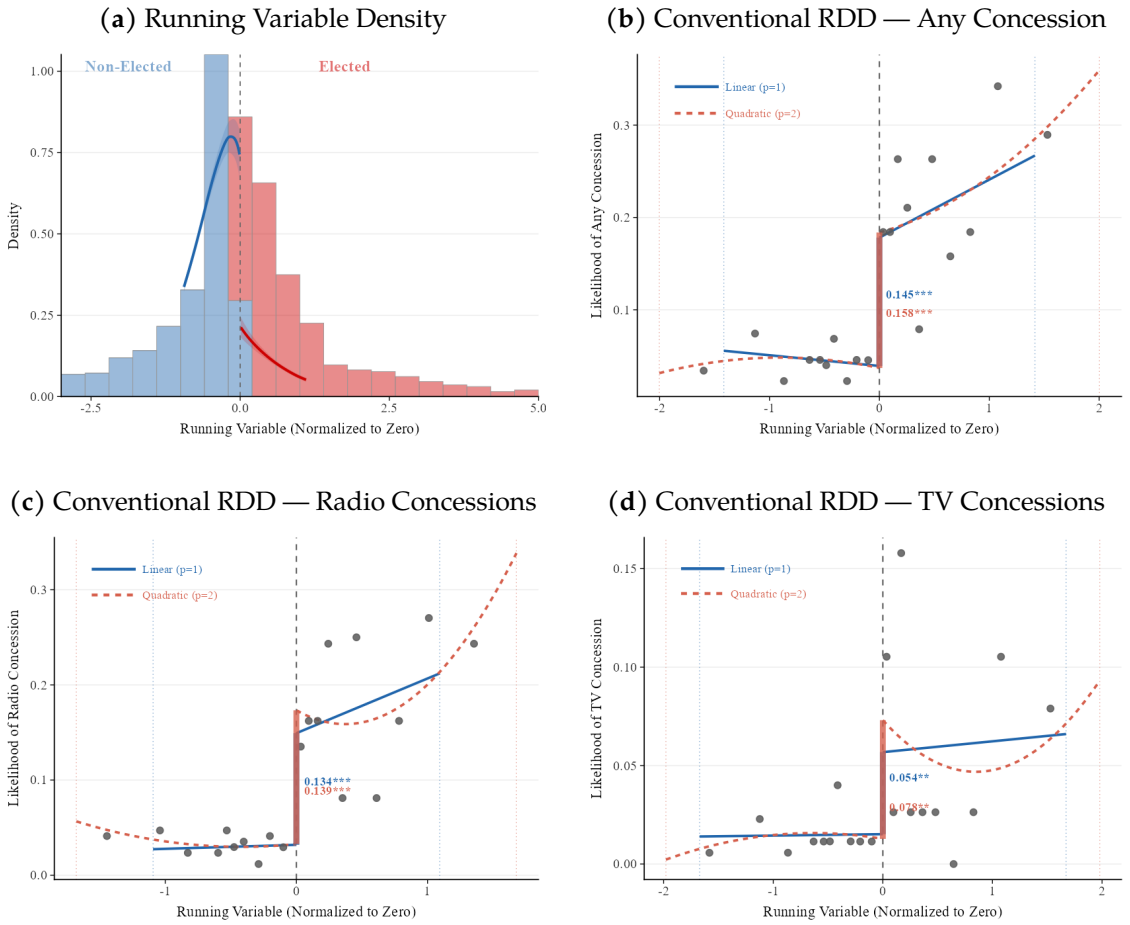
Figure 12: Placebo Cutoff Test: No Discontinuity at Alternative Thresholds



Notes: This figure reports a placebo test of the conventional sharp RDD specification in Table 3. We re-estimate the RDD at twelve false cutoffs of the running variable $RunVar_i$, ranging from -3.0 to -0.5 and from 0.5 to 3.0 in steps of 0.5, while keeping the rest of the specification unchanged: local-linear polynomial, triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, and robust bias-corrected inference with standard errors clustered at the state level. To ensure a clear null of no effect, placebo estimates at $c < 0$ use only candidates with $RunVar_i < 0$ (left side of the true cutoff), and placebo estimates at $c > 0$ use only candidates with $RunVar_i > 0$ (right side of the true cutoff). The full sample is used at the true cutoff, $c = 0$. The horizontal axis reports the placebo cutoff value in the running variable $RunVar_i$. Each point is the conventional local-linear RDD estimate of the effect of narrowly winning a 1986 NCA seat on $Concessions_i$, with 95% robust bias-corrected confidence intervals shown as a shaded band. The orange horizontal line marks $y = 0$. Blue circles show the placebo-cutoff estimates, and the orange diamond identifies the estimate at the true cutoff. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Figure 13 repeats the four panels of the main RD plot with the local-linear and local-quadratic fits drawn together, each on its own MSE-optimal bandwidth. The two polynomials trace different curvature away from the cutoff and agree on the jump at it, in any concession as in radio and television, so the discretion a referee is most entitled to distrust in an RD plot does not carry the allocation result.

Figure 13: Linear and Quadratic RDD Estimates of the Effect of Electoral Victory on Media Concession Receipt Are Consistent



Notes: This figure displays RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88), using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The outcomes are $Concession_i$, $Radio_i$, and TV_i, indicators equal to one if candidate i received any, a radio, or a TV concession in 1987–88, respectively. The running variable $RunVar_i$ is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. Panel (a) plots the density of $RunVar_i$, estimated with a local-polynomial density estimator using an oversmoothed bandwidth ($1.4\times$ MSE-optimal) and 95% confidence bands. Panels (b), (c), and (d) show binned scatter plots (10 equal-frequency bins per side within the wider of the two bandwidths) for $Concession_i$, $Radio_i$, and TV_i, respectively. Each panel overlays the local-linear fit ($p = 1$, solid blue line) and the local-quadratic fit ($p = 2$, dashed red line); each polynomial uses its own MSE-optimal bandwidth selected by `rdrobust` (dotted vertical lines mark each bandwidth boundary). Vertical segments at the cutoff indicate the estimated jump for each polynomial. The estimating equation is $Outcome_i = \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \varepsilon_i$, with triangular kernel and nearest-neighbor variance estimation. We report conventional RDD estimates; robust bias-corrected standard errors are clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The last objection is about the comparison group. Table 3 compares narrow winners with narrow losers anywhere in the country, where a referee may want the comparison made within coalitions, within parties, and within parties in the same state. Table 14 adds those fixed effects in sequence and reselects the bandwidth in each column. Under the local-linear fit the estimate is 0.140 with no fixed effects, 0.154 with coalition, 0.147 with party, 0.143 with coalition–state, and 0.056 (0.018) with party–state; all five are significant at the one percent level against a control-side mean of 0.044. The fifth estimate differs significantly not only from zero but from the baseline: its robust interval, $[0.030, 0.101]$, excludes 0.140. The fifth column has the narrowest window, and the selector produced it: the bandwidth falls from 1.42 to 0.24 across the columns and the retained sample from 1,960 candidates in 26 state clusters to 446 in 15, because the party–state covariates entered the bandwidth calculation. The estimate is 0.140 to 0.154 at every window from 1.42 down to the 0.40 of column (4), and departs from that range only in the last cell. Column (5) changes the comparison group and the estimation sample at once, and within that table the two cannot be separated.

Table 14: Electoral Victory Caused an Increase in Media Concession Receipt Even Under More Restrictive Comparison Groups (rdrobust)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Panel A: Linear RD Polynomial					
Elected	0.140***	0.154***	0.147***	0.143***	0.056***
	(0.042)	(0.039)	(0.040)	(0.025)	(0.018)
Robust 95% CI	[0.060, 0.224]	[0.078, 0.233]	[0.075, 0.231]	[0.093, 0.190]	[0.030, 0.101]
Bandwidth	1.42	1.10	0.75	0.40	0.24
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044
N (RD Population)	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583
N (Within Bandwidth)	1,960	1,795	1,473	772	446
N (Left of Cutoff)	1,605	1,470	1,204	586	319
N (Right of Cutoff)	355	325	269	186	127
N (Clusters)	26	26	25	18	15
Panel B: Quadratic RD Polynomial					
Elected	0.153***	0.163***	0.157***	0.121***	0.178***
	(0.045)	(0.042)	(0.041)	(0.040)	(0.023)
Robust 95% CI	[0.068, 0.244]	[0.083, 0.248]	[0.082, 0.244]	[0.045, 0.201]	[0.134, 0.222]
Bandwidth	2.03	1.50	1.41	0.72	0.20
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044
N (RD Population)	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583
N (Within Bandwidth)	2,127	1,978	1,953	1,461	358
N (Left of Cutoff)	1,746	1,619	1,599	1,195	248
N (Right of Cutoff)	381	359	354	266	110
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	24	14
Coalition FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Coalition×State FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Party×State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88), using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The outcome, $Concession_i$, equals one if candidate i received any federal TV or radio concession in 1987–88. The running variable, $RunVar_i$, is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. Panel A uses a local-linear polynomial ($p = 1$); Panel B uses a local-quadratic polynomial ($p = 2$). Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds coalition FEs. Column (3) adds party FEs. Column (4) adds coalition-state FEs. Column (5) adds party-state FEs. The estimating equation for the most stringent model in Column (5) is $Concession_i = \alpha_{p(i),s(i)} + \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_i$, where $\alpha_{p(i),s(i)}$ denotes party-state fixed effects and $\mathbf{x}_i$ denotes the vector of predetermined controls described in Section 4. Each column uses a triangular kernel, MSE-optimal bandwidth, and nearest-neighbor variance estimation. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors, clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Holding the window fixed separates them, which is what Table 15 does. It runs the same ladder of fixed effects with the bandwidth held fixed at $h = 1.439$ in the linear panel, close to but not identical to the 1.42 that column (1) of Table 14 selects, so every column is estimated on the same 1,967 observations and the same 26 clusters. The two tables are otherwise the same regression: sample construction, covariate matrix, kernel, variance estimator and clustering are common to both, and the bandwidth rule is the only design choice that differs. The estimates are 0.140, 0.146, 0.131, 0.144 and 0.144, with the saturated interval at $[0.103, 0.199]$. With the window fixed, the full progression from no fixed effects to party–state fixed effects moves the estimate within 0.131 to 0.146, a band containing the baseline. Holding the window fixed, therefore, the comparison group does not move the estimate. The quadratic panels say something sharper about the last cell. At $p = 2$ the reselected-bandwidth column (5) returns 0.178 (0.023) on a window of 0.20—narrower still, and above rather than below the baseline—while the fixed-bandwidth quadratic estimates lie between 0.150 and 0.173. A narrow window does not attenuate the estimate mechanically, which Figure 11 shows again over the range it covers. What column (5) of the reselected table displays is instability in one cell where the most saturated covariate matrix meets the narrowest window: at that saturation the linear fit gives 0.056 (0.018) and the quadratic gives 0.178 (0.023), two tight intervals that cannot both describe the same parameter. Reselecting the bandwidth under covariate adjustment is the standard choice and a referee will run it; fixing the window is what isolates the contribution of the comparison group, which is the question this pair of tables asks.

Table 15: Electoral Victory Caused an Increase in Media Concession Receipt Even Under More Restrictive Comparison Groups (rdrobust, Fixed Bandwidth)

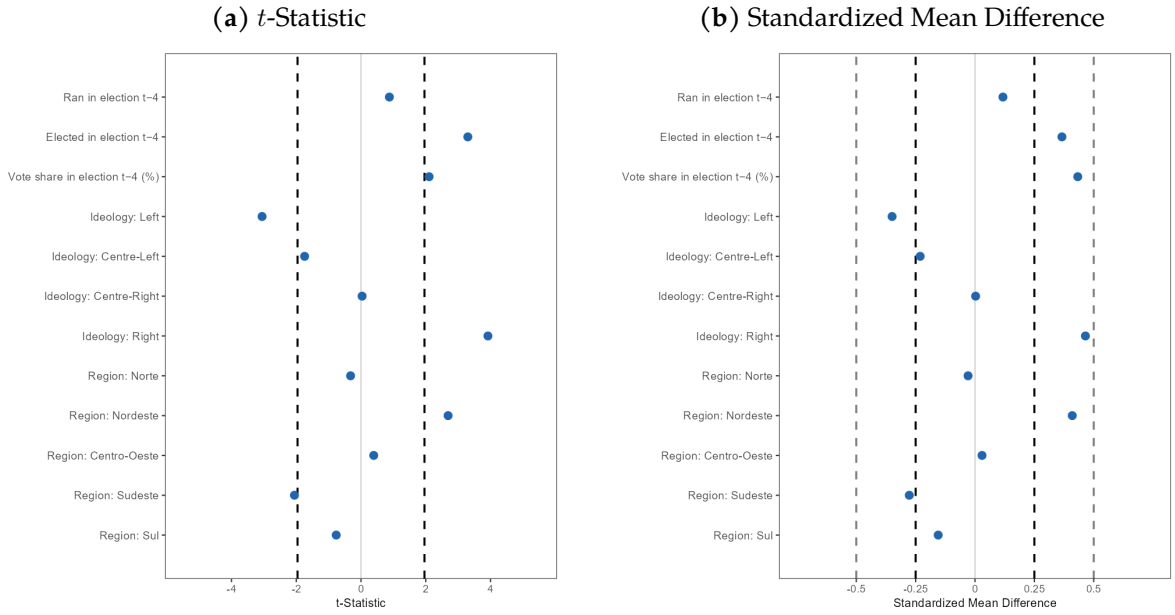
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Panel A: Linear RD Polynomial					
Elected	0.140***	0.146***	0.131***	0.144***	0.144***
	(0.045)	(0.041)	(0.040)	(0.026)	(0.025)
Robust 95% CI	[0.068, 0.244]	[0.081, 0.243]	[0.077, 0.232]	[0.104, 0.207]	[0.103, 0.199]
Bandwidth	1.439	1.439	1.439	1.439	1.439
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044
N (RD Population)	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583
N (Within Bandwidth)	1,967	1,967	1,967	1,967	1,967
N (Left of Cutoff)	1,609	1,609	1,609	1,609	1,609
N (Right of Cutoff)	358	358	358	358	358
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26
Panel B: Quadratic RD Polynomial					
Elected	0.156***	0.163***	0.150***	0.172***	0.173***
	(0.049)	(0.045)	(0.043)	(0.031)	(0.030)
Robust 95% CI	[0.051, 0.242]	[0.066, 0.242]	[0.067, 0.234]	[0.115, 0.237]	[0.107, 0.227]
Bandwidth	1.839	1.839	1.839	1.839	1.839
Outcome Mean (Control)	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044	0.044
N (RD Population)	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583	2,583
N (Within Bandwidth)	2,101	2,101	2,101	2,101	2,101
N (Left of Cutoff)	1,725	1,725	1,725	1,725	1,725
N (Right of Cutoff)	376	376	376	376	376
N (Clusters)	26	26	26	26	26
Coalition FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Coalition×State FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Party×State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes

Notes: This table reports RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning a seat in the 1986 Brazilian federal election on receiving a media concession during the National Constitutional Assembly (1987–88), using the media allocation estimating sample described in Section 4. The outcome, $Concession_i$, equals one if candidate i received any federal TV or radio concession in 1987–88. The running variable, $RunVar_i$, is the within-coalition, within-state vote margin relative to the effective seat threshold. Panel A uses a local-linear polynomial ($p = 1$); Panel B uses a local-quadratic polynomial ($p = 2$). Column (1) includes no fixed effects (FEs). Column (2) adds coalition FEs. Column (3) adds party FEs. Column (4) adds coalition-state FEs. Column (5) adds Party-State FEs. The estimating equation for the most stringent model in Column (5) is $Concession_i = \alpha_{p(i),s(i)} + \tau \mathbf{1}(RunVar_i \geq 0) + f(RunVar_i) + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{x}_i + \varepsilon_i$, where $\mathbf{x}_i$ denotes the vector of predetermined controls described in Section 4. Unlike Table 14, all columns within each panel use a common bandwidth fixed at the MSE-optimal value from the unconditional specification in Column (1): $h = 1.439$ in Panel A and $h = 1.839$ in Panel B, ensuring the estimation sample is identical across columns within each panel. Each column uses a triangular kernel and nearest-neighbor variance estimation. We report conventional RDD estimates and robust bias-corrected standard errors, clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

7.2 Legislative Response

The legislative-response estimates are associations within the elected sample, and their weakness is selection: the deputies who received licenses may have been the ones already disposed to vote with the Executive. Figure 14 reports what selection is visible. It regresses each of twelve predetermined covariates—1982 candidacy and office, the 1982 vote share, four ideology indicators from Zucco and Power (2023), and five region dummies—on concession receipt among the 455 deputies, with no fixed effects. Balance on these covariates does not rule out selection on unobservables; it establishes that recipients are not set apart on the deputy characteristics recorded before 1987.

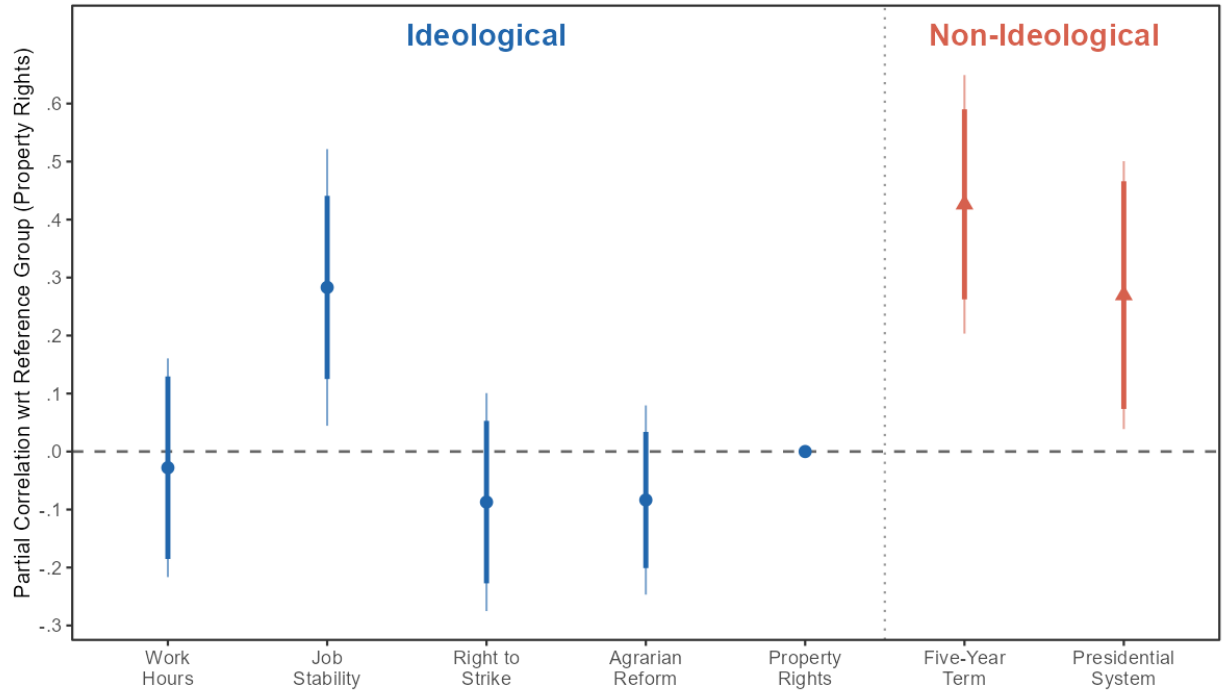
Figure 14: Pre-Treatment Covariates Are Balanced Across Concession Recipients and Non-Recipients in the Legislative Response Sample



Notes: This figure assesses unconditional covariate balance between concession recipients ($Concession_i = 1$) and non-recipients ($Concession_i = 0$) in the legislative response estimating sample described in Section 4. The sample comprises the $N = 455$ elected deputies who participated in the 1987–88 National Constitutional Assembly (NCA), identified by matching elected candidates from the 1986 federal election to the NCA roll-call voting records. The treatment indicator $Concession_i$ (`won_media_all_87_88PM`) equals one if deputy i received any federal TV or radio concession during the NCA. Each covariate is regressed on $Concession_i$ with no fixed effects. Panel (a) reports the t-statistic and panel (b) the standardized mean difference $\hat{\beta}/\hat{\sigma}_y$ for each of twelve pre-treatment covariates: an indicator for having run in the 1982 federal election (election $t-4$), an indicator for having been elected in 1982, the vote share in 1982 (%), four ideology indicators derived from Zucco and Power (2023) BLS estimates using the 1990 congressional wave (the first wave available in that paper), and five region dummies. Dashed vertical lines at ± 1.96 in panel (a) and at ± 0.25 and ± 0.50 in panel (b) mark conventional imbalance thresholds. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 6 imposes the model's partition of the seven issues into two blocks. Figure 15 removes it, estimating an interaction of concession receipt with each issue separately, relative to property rights, under issue and deputy fixed effects. The figure shows whether the pattern the pooled differential of 0.328 summarizes is visible issue by issue or driven by a single vote, and it reports Romano–Wolf stepdown intervals alongside the naive ones, computed within each family by wild cluster bootstrap, which prices the number of hypotheses the decomposition tests.

Figure 15: Issue-Level Alignment Premium for Media Concession Recipients: Ideological vs. Non-Ideological Issues

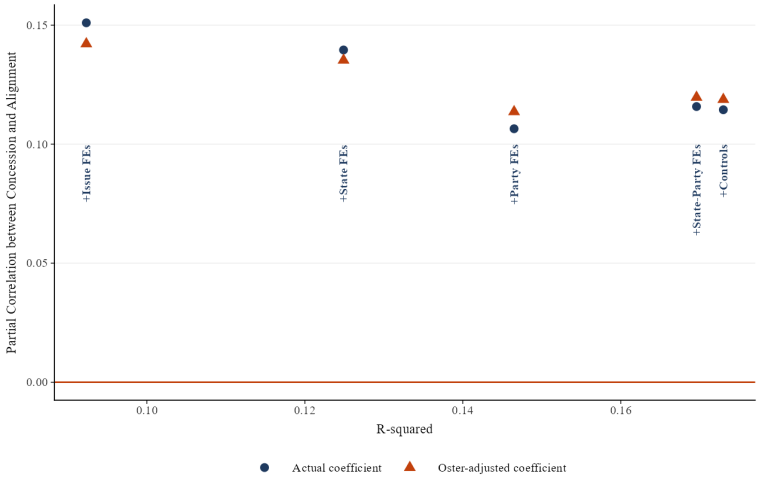


Notes: This figure presents issue-specific partial correlations between media concession receipt and government alignment, relative to the Property Rights reference group, using the legislative-response estimating sample defined in Section 4. We estimate the regression model $Loyalty_{i,j} = \alpha_i + \alpha_j + \sum_{\ell \neq \text{Property Rights}} \beta_\ell \, Concession_i \times Issue_{\ell,j} + \varepsilon_{i,j}$. The seven issues are Agrarian Reform, Right to Strike, Job Stability, Work Hours, Property Rights, Five-Year Presidential Term, and Presidential System. Each point is the interaction coefficient $\hat{\beta}_\ell$ on $Concession_i \times Issue_{\ell,j}$ from a two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) model with issue FEs and deputy FEs, estimated via OLS with standard errors clustered at the state level. Issues are grouped into non-ideological issues (Five-Year Presidential Term and Presidential System; in orange) and ideological issues (the remaining five; in blue). The thick inner intervals are naive 95% confidence intervals; the thin outer intervals are Romano-Wolf stepdown 95% confidence intervals, computed using a Rademacher wild cluster bootstrap with $B = 999$ replications and separately within each family. Property Rights serves as the reference category. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

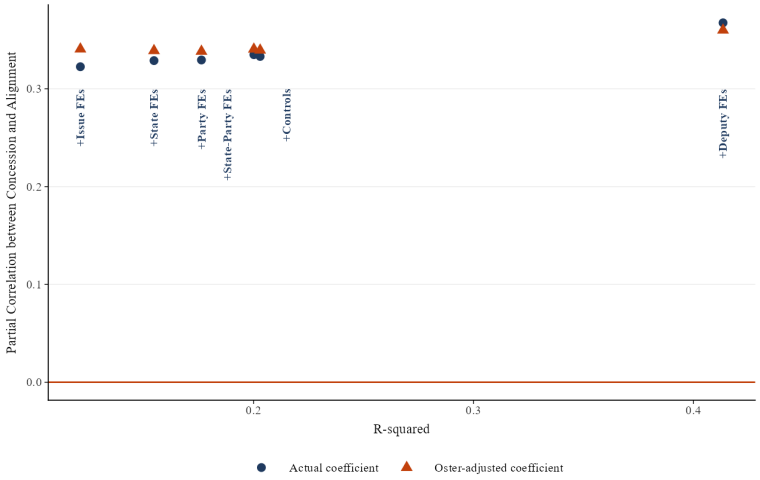
Figure 16 asks how much unobserved selection the association could absorb. Panel (a) applies the coefficient-stability calculation of Oster (2019) to Table 5, with $\delta = 1$ and $R^2_{\max} = 1.3\,\tilde{R}^2$ against the uncontrolled benchmark: the adjusted coefficient β^* tracks the estimated one across the progression, the diagnostic the method delivers for a between-deputy comparison whose added controls proxy for the omitted variable. Panel (b) runs the same calculation on the within-deputy contrast of Table 7, where it carries no information about selection. The Oster adjustment is proportional to the distance the coefficient travels between the uncontrolled and the controlled specification, and here that distance is 0.014: the differential is 0.346 with no fixed effects and 0.360 with deputy fixed effects. The adjustment is therefore near zero for any assumed $R^2_{\max}$, and the closeness of β^* to $\hat{\beta}$ restates the design's logic—deputy fixed effects difference out deputy-level selection—rather than testing it. Deputy fixed effects are also not proxies for a confounder of the institutional–ideological differential, which is what the method requires of the added regressors. The confounder this design does not rule out varies at the deputy–issue level, and the robustness value of Cinelli and Hazlett (2020) is the measure that targets it. The case for reading the 0.360 within-deputy differential as more than composition is the one made in section 6; panel (b) does not add to it.

Figure 16: Coefficient Stability Suggests Limited Selection on Observables

(**a**) OLS, Table 5



(**b**) TWFE, Table 7



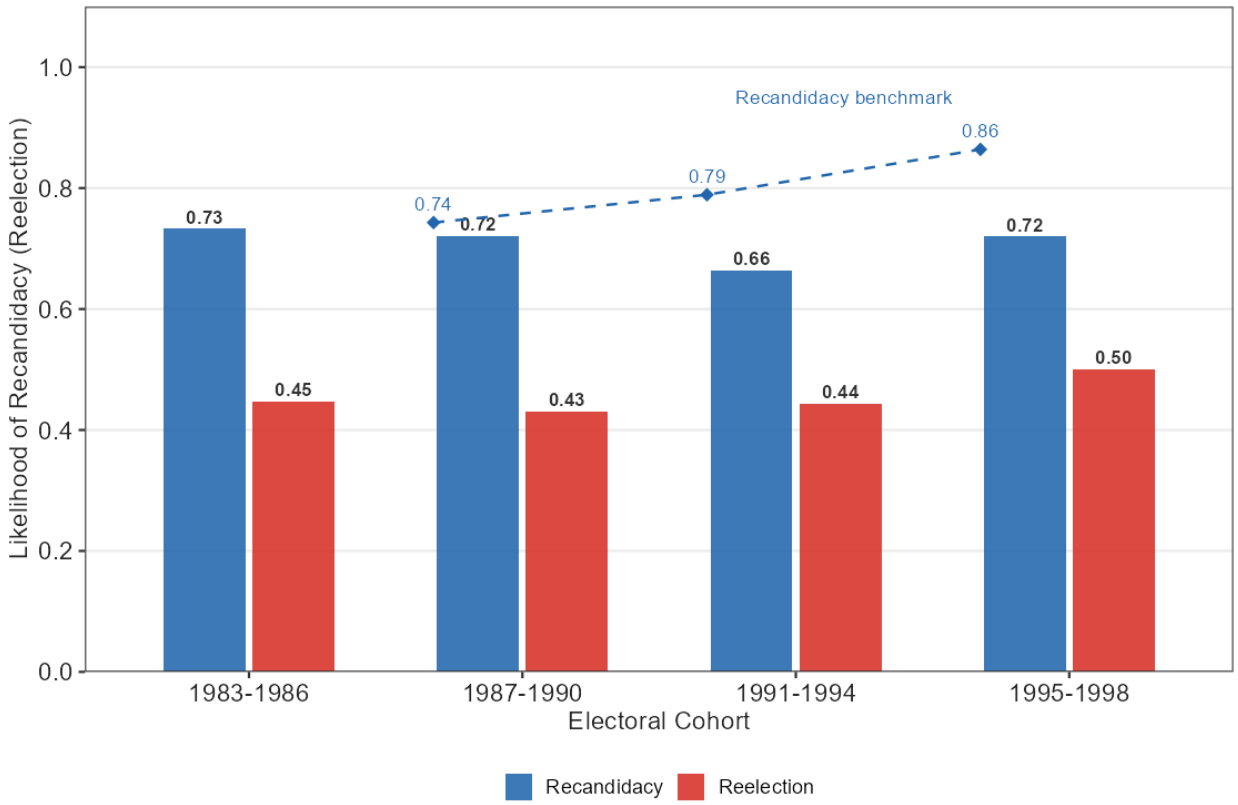
Notes: This figure presents Oster (2019) coefficient-stability tests for two specifications of the legislative-response regression models, using the legislative-response estimating sample defined in Section 4. Graph (a) reports coefficient-stability tests for the results in Table 5, where the outcome is $Loyalty_{i,j}$, the treatment variable is $Concession_i$, and the coefficient of interest is β. Graph (b) reports coefficient-stability tests for the results in Table 7, where the outcome is $Loyalty_{i,j}$, the treatment variable is $Concession_i \times NonIdeological_j$, and the coefficient of interest is β_3. In each graph, blue circles show the actual OLS coefficients and orange triangles show the Oster-adjusted coefficients, β^*, computed as $\beta^* = \tilde{\beta} - \delta \frac{R^2_{\text{max}} - \tilde{R}^2}{\tilde{R}^2 - R^2_0}(\tilde{\beta} - \hat{\beta}_0)$, where $\hat{\beta}_0$ and R^2_0 are from the uncontrolled benchmark specification in Column (1), $\tilde{\beta}$ and $\tilde{R}^2$ are from each controlled specification, $\delta = 1$, and $R^2_{\text{max}} = 1.3 \times \tilde{R}^2$. Specifications are labeled by the fixed effects progressively added relative to the baseline. If the actual and Oster-adjusted series track closely, selection on unobservables is unlikely to explain the estimated association. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The threat this subsection does not close is the one section 4 names. Coverage of the two blocks of votes is not symmetric, and the asymmetry runs in the direction that would manufacture the result: every institutional cell is defined, while the ideological cells survive for 35.5 percent of the recipients' possible observations against 52.0 percent of the non-recipients'. Under the direction-dependent benchmark a missing component counts as zero alignment wherever the Executive preferred a yes vote, so a deputy absent from a roll call is recorded as having voted against the Executive on it. The symmetric-missing coding described in section 4, which leaves every missing entry missing, defines 1,714 deputy–issue observations from 445 deputies with 334 treated, removing 292 observations from the benchmark and removing them unevenly—24.0 percent of the ideological cells against 3.2 percent of the institutional ones. Re-estimating the differential of Table 6 and Table 7 under that coding is the exercise that separates an issue-differentiated deviation cost from differential participation, and it is not reported here.

7.3 Electoral Advantage

The electoral-advantage sample is built by linking candidates across four elections, and a linkage of that kind can lose exactly the people whose careers ended. Figure 17 checks the construction against an outside source, plotting by origin cohort the share of incumbents who stood again and the share who won again, with the recandidacy benchmarks reported by DIAP overlaid. The rates in the estimating sample track the external series, so the panel is not a selected set of survivors.

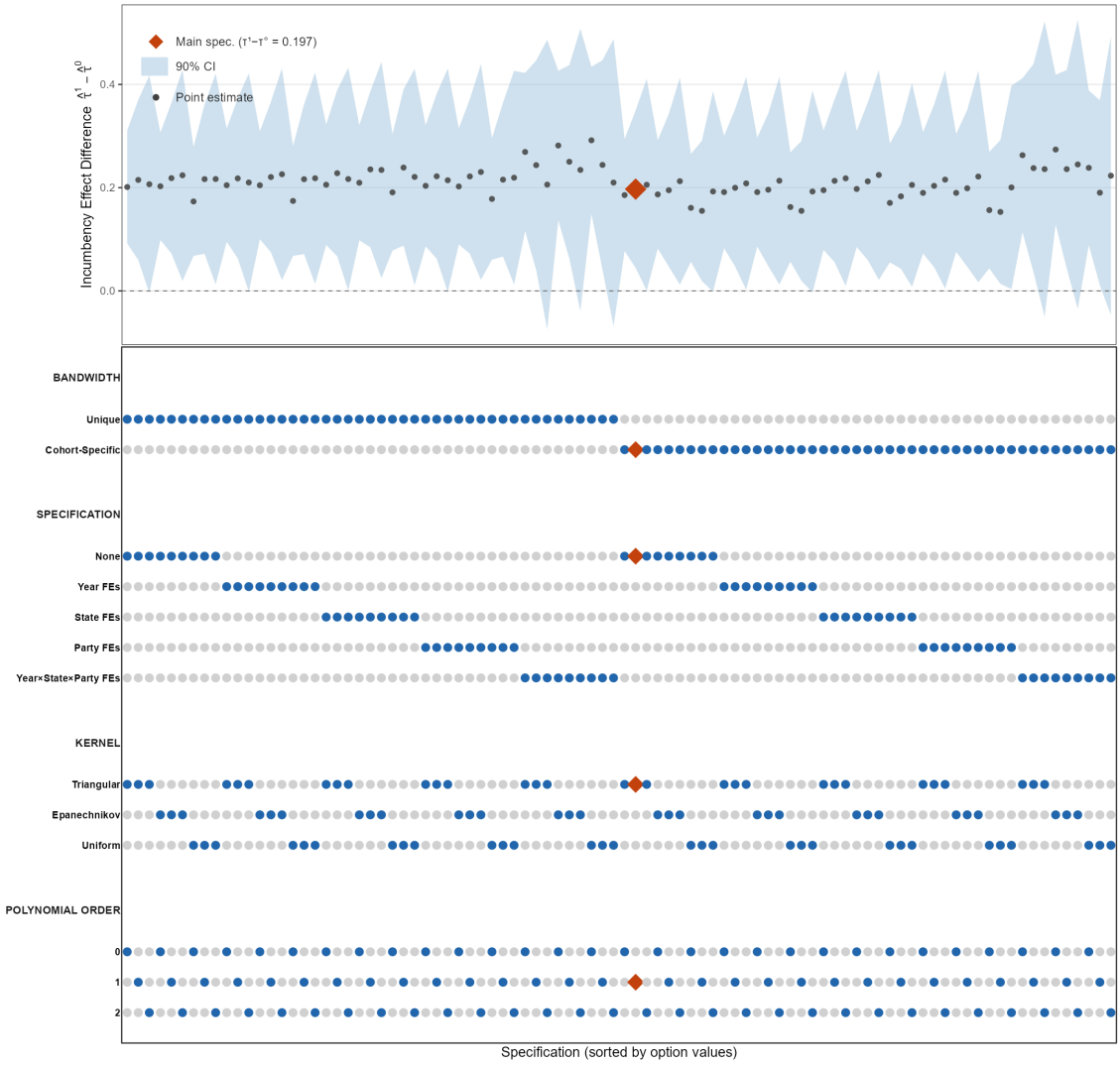
Figure 17: Recandidacy and Reelection Rates by Electoral Cohort in the Electoral Advantage Incumbency Estimating Sample Are Consistent with Official Sources



Notes: This figure presents recandidacy and reelection rates by electoral cohort, using the electoral-advantage incumbency estimating sample defined in Section 4. We plot four electoral cohorts, $c \in \{1983\text{–}1986, 1987\text{–}1990, 1991\text{–}1994, 1995\text{–}1998\}$, generated by election years $t \in \{1982, 1986, 1990, 1994\}$. Blue bars report the recandidacy rate, $\Pr[Run_{i,t+4} = 1 \mid Elected_{i,t} = 1]$: the share of incumbents who ran in the subsequent election. Red bars report the unconditional reelection rate, $\Pr[Elected_{i,t+4} = 1 \mid Elected_{i,t} = 1]$: the share of incumbents who won a seat in the subsequent election. The dashed line and diamond markers overlay benchmark recandidacy rates from Departamento Intersindical de Assessoria Parlamentar, 2018 for the same periods as an external-validity reference. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The heterogeneous design carries more discretion than the allocation design, because bandwidths are selected separately within owners and non-owners and the difference of two local estimates inherits both choices. Figure 18 maps that discretion, reporting $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ across 90 specifications crossing two bandwidth rules, pooled and cohort-specific, with five fixed-effect specifications, three kernels and polynomial orders $p \in \{0, 1, 2\}$, splitting throughout on the predetermined ownership stock $MediaOwner_{i,t}$. The difference stays positive across the grid, and what moves it is the fixed-effect structure—the movement already visible along the columns of Table 11, where the differential rises from 0.229 to 0.262.

Figure 18: Higher Incumbency Effects for Media Owners (Before Treatment) Are Robust to Specification Choices

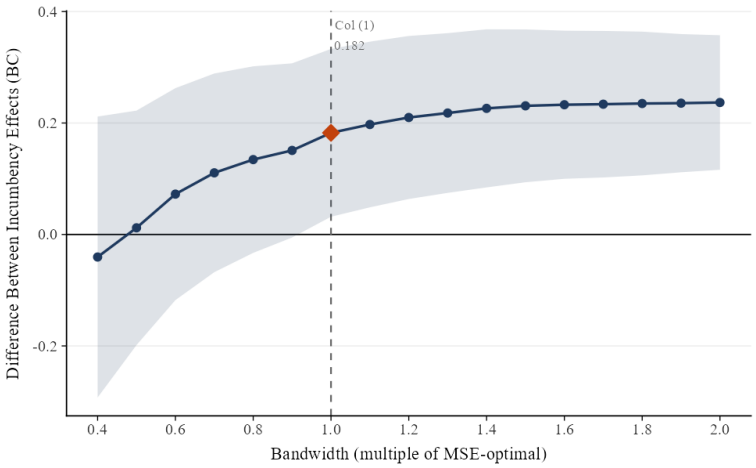


Notes: This figure presents a specification-check graph probing the robustness of $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$—the difference in incumbency effects between media owners and non-media owners—across 90 specification choices, using the electoral-advantage candidates estimating sample defined in Section 4. The specification grid varies in four dimensions: running-variable coding, fixed-effect specification, RD kernel, and polynomial order. There are two possible bandwidth specifications: *Unique*, which applies a single MSERD-optimal bandwidth h estimated from the pooled sample, common to all cohorts; and *Cohort-Specific*, which applies the cohort-specific MSERD-optimal bandwidth h_t—differing across the four electoral cohorts—as in Column (1) of Table 11. There are five possible fixed-effect (FE) specifications: no FEs; year FEs; state FEs; party FEs; and Year×State×Party FEs. There are three possible kernel functions: Triangular, Epanechnikov, and Uniform. There are three possible polynomial orders: $p \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. The split variable is $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, which equals one if the deputy held any media concession before the origin election year t (cumulative stock, predetermined). For each specification of running-variable coding, kernel function, and polynomial order, the MSE-optimal bandwidth is selected separately per group using a regression without fixed effects, as in Table 11. Then, using this bandwidth, the incumbency effect is estimated via WLS with triangular kernel weights, and $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ is computed across groups with standard errors clustered at the state-year level. The shaded band shows the 90% confidence interval. Specifications are sorted lexicographically by option values across the four dimensions, in the order they appear in the lower panel. The orange diamond identifies the baseline estimate from Column (1) of Table 11 ($\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0 = 0.197$). A blue dot in the lower panel indicates that the specification uses the corresponding option value, while a light-grey dot indicates that it does not. The orange diamond in the lower panel marks the option values of the main specification. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

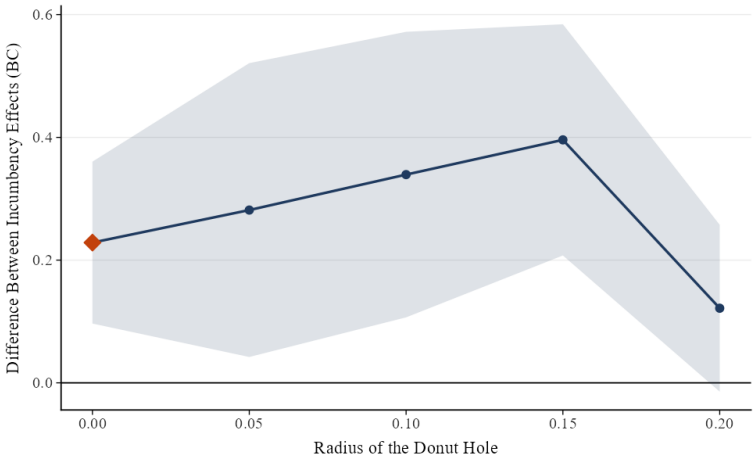
Figure 19 repeats for the difference the two exercises Figure 11 runs for the allocation estimate. Panel (a) traces $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ across bandwidths from 0.4 to 2.0 times the group-specific MSE-optimal values; panel (b) drops candidates within d of the threshold, for d up to 0.20, and reselects both bandwidths at each radius. Neither path drives the difference toward zero. Both paths are estimated on the no-fixed-effects specification of column (1) of Table 11, where the differential is 0.229. That differential is the one the exercise puts at risk, and the columns of Table 11 show it rising to 0.262 as fixed effects enter.

Figure 19: Higher Incumbency Effects for Media Owners (Before Treatment) Are Robust to Bandwidth and Donut Hole Choice

(**a**) Robustness to Bandwidth Choices



(**b**) Robustness to Donut Hole Size



Notes: This figure displays two robustness exercises for the baseline bias-corrected estimate $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0 = 0.182$ from Column (1) of Table 11, where $\hat{\tau}^1$ and $\hat{\tau}^0$ are the incumbency effects for media owners and non-media owners, respectively, estimated using the electoral-advantage candidates estimating sample defined in Section 4. The split variable is $MediaOwner_{i,t}$, which equals one if the deputy held any media concession before the origin election year t (cumulative stock, predetermined). All estimates use `rdrobust` ($p = 1$, triangular kernel, state-level clustering) and report bias-corrected coefficients with 90% robust BC confidence intervals. Graph (a) shows bandwidth sensitivity: each point is $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ estimated at a bandwidth ranging from 0.4 to 2.0 times the MSE-optimal bandwidth, selected separately per group (h^1, h^0) under the no-fixed-effects specification of Column (1); the orange diamond marks the baseline estimate. Graph (b) shows robustness to a two-sided donut RDD: each point drops all candidates with $|RunVar_{i,t}| < d$, for $d \in \{0, 0.05, 0.10, 0.15, 0.20\}$ (in raw vote-margin units), and re-estimates $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ using a fresh MSE-optimal bandwidth per group at each d. The standard error of $\hat{\tau}^1 - \hat{\tau}^0$ equals $\sqrt{\text{SE}^2_{\text{rbc},m} + \text{SE}^2_{\text{rbc},nm}}$. $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

8 Conclusion

This paper studies how control over broadcast media is allocated, retained, and translated into legislative behavior during a foundational moment of institutional redesign. Using a new dataset linking nearly universal information on radio and television concessions to individual politicians, combined with close-election RDD designs and a simple conceptual framework, we present three pieces of evidence that together characterize broadcast concessions as productive political capital—an asset that is discrete, identity-embodied, and ownership-dependent.

On *allocation*, barely elected NCA members were 14.0 percentage points more likely to receive a concession in 1987–88, with an effect of 18.8 points among candidates of the governing coalition and null effects at twelve placebo cutoffs. On *legislative response*, concession recipients show large within-deputy shifts in government alignment concentrated on institutional but not ideological votes—a contrast identified from each deputy's own voting record, which differences out deputy-level selection by construction. On *office–media complementarity*, the return to narrowly winning a seat is 26.2 percentage points larger for candidates who already held a broadcast concession than for those who did not. This ownership conditionality is the sharpest mechanism test the paper delivers. Measurement and linkage limits are detailed in Appendix A; the identification threats are discussed in section 5 and section 7.

These findings contribute to several strands of research. First, they expand the media–politics literature by documenting not only how media influences voters, but how control over media is allocated in the first place, and how that allocation shapes subsequent political competition. Existing work emphasizes biased coverage or media entry; we document how a politically allocated broadcast license operates as a discrete, identity-embodied asset whose electoral value is realized in combination with the office its holder occupies. Second, the ownership gradient in the post-NCA incumbency premium is the finding that

most sharply separates the productive-capital story from pure patronage. A consumptive transfer—fiscal pork, cash payments, or generic patronage—is appropriated at delivery and keeps its value to the recipient whether or not office is retained, so it predicts no interaction between ownership and the return to office. A productive informational asset has no platform to amplify without office, so it predicts exactly that interaction. That the incumbency premium is markedly larger among candidates who already held broadcast assets connects our allocation margin to the literature on politician-owned media (Durante et al., 2019; Barone et al., 2015; Cavgias et al., 2024), and identifies the office–ownership interaction, rather than the level of the premium, as the object that separates informational assets from cash.

Scope conditions and external validity. The mechanism we document is not universal. Broadcast concessions function as political currency when three conditions hold jointly, and Brazil's 1987–88 NCA is an extreme point on each: executive discretion over license allocation is high, as it was for the president over AM and television concessions; local information markets are thin enough that a single new station can dominate political information for a non-trivial share of the electorate, as they were in the interior, where radio penetration was near-universal and competitors per municipality few; and the political window is one of institutional flux, in which executive–legislative bargaining is dense and the stakes of individual votes are unusually high, as they were while the Constituent Assembly drew up the new rules of the political game. We therefore expect the mechanism to be most visible in contexts that approximate this constellation—for example, Peru in the early 1990s, where McMillan and Zoido (2004) document the authoritarian-exchange analogue; Italy under Berlusconi, where Durante et al. (2019) document the private-empire version; and, more speculatively, other episodes in which a regulator with discretion met a legislature in flux. In consolidated democracies with independent regulators and dense information markets—the OECD "Liberal" and "Democratic Corporatist" configurations

of Hallin and Mancini (2004)—we expect the mechanism to be attenuated but not absent: politically valuable media assets can still be allocated through regulatory discretion at the margin, even when formal auction mechanisms are in place. Mapping the boundaries of this mechanism empirically in these settings is an obvious next step for the literature.

A further consideration strengthens rather than weakens extrapolation. The allocation mechanism is uniquely Brazilian, as executive discretion over AM and television licenses at this scale is rare in the OECD, but the *outcome* is not: politicians who own broadcast outlets operate in most democracies, from Italy and Spain to Mexico and the Philippines. What distinguishes the Brazilian NCA is that the allocation episode was broad enough (approximately ninety legislators received concessions) to populate the treated group with a cross-section of governing-coalition politicians rather than a handful of particularly powerful ones. This breadth implies that concession recipients in our sample are less positively selected on political strength than media-owning politicians in countries where ownership is concentrated among the most prominent figures. If anything, our estimates of the allocation and legislative effects are attenuated relative to what a more selected sample would produce. Moreover, Brazil after 1989 operates as a standard multiparty electoral democracy with open-list proportional representation, competitive elections, and a free press; the institutional environment in which the concession's electoral value is realized is not historically specific but common to a wide range of contemporary settings.

The results open several natural avenues for further research. A first is methodological: a clean causal estimate of the long-run electoral return on concession receipt would require an identification design with parallel pre-trends across treated and never-treated cohorts that the single-cohort 1986 setting does not support. Settings with rolling allocation across cohorts—for example, license renewals over multiple legislative terms, or country-level allocations with staggered timing—would allow direct identification of the long-run electoral effect that our one-cycle-ahead design can only signal indirectly. A second direction is to investigate the mechanisms through which concession recipients convert media own-

ership into political advantage: whether they face weaker electoral accountability, engage differently in distributive politics, or shape local information environments in ways that reinforce their political position. Direct measurement of legislative effort and constituent service among media-owning deputies is a natural next step. A third direction is comparative. The Brazilian NCA offers an unusually transparent setting for studying the political allocation of broadcasting rights, but discretionary media control has played an important role in many other democratizing episodes—in Latin America, Southern Europe, and Eastern Europe in particular. Documenting whether similar mechanisms operated in those settings would help identify the conditions under which broadcast concessions emerge as a preferred instrument of executive-legislative bargaining during institutional transitions.

Our results argue for regulatory frameworks that limit executive discretion over broadcast concessions and enforce conflict-of-interest rules for media-owning legislators. More broadly, the mechanism we document—the use of discretionary broadcast licensing as political currency during high-stakes institutional bargaining—is likely to operate in any context where executive discretion over spectrum allocation meets dense executive-legislative negotiation, a pattern whose scope conditions and boundaries future work can map empirically.

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A Matching Concessions and Candidates

This appendix separates the evidence used to construct candidate–concession links from the evidence available to validate them. The construction combines four layers: Ministry of Communications grant records indexed by CNPJ, CNE partner records, TSE candidate records, and the archival concession histories reconstructed by Motter et al. (2019). The first three layers generate automated links. The fourth supplements those links with documented spouses, relatives, associates, and proxy shareholders.

A.1 Automated linkage

Names are converted to lowercase ASCII, punctuation and non-letter characters are removed, repeated spaces are collapsed, and estate markers such as *espólio* are stripped. The linkage preserves suffix information but removes suffixes when it constructs surname tokens for the relative channel. State provides the geographic block.

The self channel compares the normalized candidate and partner names using full-name string distance, token overlap, and first-name similarity. The relative channel requires different first names and either one uncommon shared surname or two common shared surnames. This rule prevents a single common surname from generating a family link. Accepted links inherit the CNPJ's grant year and radio or television classification. The automated files retain separate self, relative, and all-links indicators.

A.2 Archival augmentation and validation scope

Motter's histories add relationships that formal registry fields can miss. They are most useful for documenting recipients whose stations appear under family members or associates. Their coverage is not symmetric across the RDD population, however. Motter searched

for NCA deputies who received or politically controlled concessions; he did not apply an equivalent archival search to every losing candidate. Agreement with Motter therefore measures automated recovery among treated-side archival cases, not matching precision in the full candidate population.

The archived Motter validation file contains 83 archival cases, and the automated linkage recovers 66 of them. This 79.5% recovery rate reveals false negatives on the archival side. It does not identify false positives among candidates outside Motter's search or false negatives among losing candidates. Consequently, Motter provides a recall diagnostic for known recipients, not a gold standard for the entire RDD population.

A.3 Features of unrecovered Motter cases

The 17 Motter cases not recovered automatically span 13 states and all five Brazilian macroregions. Thirteen cases are already linked to the person panel but have no qualifying CNE recovery; four are absent from that panel. Four contain a documented relative link and none contains a documented third-party link. Television appears in six of the 17 cases, AM/OM radio in eight, and FM radio in seven; technologies can overlap. Thus, the observed misses are not predominantly proxy-ownership cases. The evidence points more directly to incomplete CNE or ownership-period coverage and, for four cases, incomplete person-panel coverage. Table A1 reports these diagnostics.

Table A1: Features of Motter Cases Not Recovered Automatically

Feature	Count	Share
Unrecovered Motter cases	17	100.0%
Present in person panel, no CNE recovery	13	76.5%
Absent from person panel	4	23.5%
Documented relative link	4	23.5%
Documented third-party link	0	0.0%
FM concession	7	41.2%
AM/OM concession	8	47.1%
Television concession	6	35.3%

Notes: The denominator is the 17 Motter cases without an automated CNE match. Technology indicators overlap. "Present in person panel" means that the politician was resolved to the person identifier; it does not imply a firm-partner match.

Table A2 presents sanitized snapshots of six recognizable input records. Albérico de França Ferreira Filho and Luís Eduardo Magalhães illustrate cases recovered by the automatic pipeline. Arolde de Oliveira, Osvaldo Coelho, Domingos Juvenil, and Mozarildo Cavalcante illustrate different unrecovered combinations of technology, self or relative evidence, and exact or fuzzy person-panel linkage. These examples are selected to make the pipeline concrete, not to represent the prevalence of each mechanism. The snapshot excludes tax identifiers, internal row identifiers, and unrestricted source fields.

Table A2: Sanitized Snapshots of Motter and Automated Matching Inputs

Motter politician	UF–party	Archival evidence	Link; person-panel result	CNE recovery
Alberico de Franca Ferreira Filho	MA–PMDB	FM: 1; AM/OM: 2	self; exact name–UF	Yes (3)
Luis Eduardo Maron Magalhães	BA–PFL	TV: 3	third party; fuzzy name–UF	Yes (1)
Arolde de Oliveira	RJ–PFL	TV: 1	self; exact name–UF	No
Domingos Juvenil Nunes de Sousa	PA–PMDB	AM/OM: 2; TV: 1	relative; exact name–UF	No
Francisco Mozarildo de Melo Cavalcante	RR–PFL	TV: 1	relative; exact name–UF	No
Osvaldo de Sousa Coelho	PE–PFL	AM/OM: 1; TV: 1	self; fuzzy name–UF	No

Notes: Archival evidence reports the counts recorded in the archived Motter validation input. AM/OM follows that input's medium-wave label. "Person-panel result" is the candidate-to-person linkage stage; "Automated CNE result" is the subsequent firm-partner recovery. These are pipeline snapshots, not independent adjudications of legal ownership.

A.4 Aggregate audit and remaining limitation

The broad automated-plus-Motter outcome identifies 204 recipients in the 2,606-candidate RDD population. These include 112 of 487 elected candidates and 92 of 2,119 non-elected candidates. The latter group contains eight self-only links, 82 relative-only links, one link in both automated channels, and one Motter-only link. A losing candidate could legally receive a grant, so treatment among non-elected candidates is not itself evidence of a false match.

The current local files do not preserve enough upstream lineage to adjudicate the 82 relative-only positives individually. This gap prevents a defensible precision estimate for the broad relative channel. The empirical analysis therefore keeps self-only, all-links automated, and automated-plus-Motter measures distinct. A robustness comparison in the main text can show how the estimates move across those measures, but it cannot replace the missing source-level audit. In particular, the broad all-links measure is not described as a lower bound: false negatives may coexist with unvalidated relative-link false positives.

The matching problem is substantively relevant rather than purely mechanical. Historical reporting documents family-held concessions and an explicit dispute over a license and the five-year presidential term during the Sarney period (Lobato, 1995). Later evidence describes control through foundations, spouses, aides, and electoral associates across several states (Lobato, 2006), while an official Senate report records regulatory concern with fictitious partners and irregular transfers (Agência Senado, 2011). This evidence motivates searching beyond exact self-name links while also requiring that family and archival links remain visible to readers. It is descriptive validation of the mechanism, not an estimate of measurement error in the analysis sample.

Table A3: Aggregate Coverage of the Candidate–Concession Linkage

Diagnostic	Count	Share
1986 RDD population	2606	100.0%
Elected candidates	487	18.7%
Non-elected candidates	2119	81.3%
Broad automated-plus-Motter positives	204	7.8%
Positives among elected candidates	112	23.0%
Positives among non-elected candidates	92	4.3%
Non-winner self only	8	8.7%
Non-winner relative only	82	89.1%
Non-winner self and relative	1	1.1%
Non-winner Motter only	1	1.1%
Automated non-winner positives with archived 1987–88 linkage records	11	12.1%
Motter cases recovered by the automated linkage	66	79.5%

Notes: Shares use the denominator shown by each diagnostic. The archived 1987–88 linkage records recover 11 of 91 automated positives among non-elected candidates. The Motter recovery statistic uses 83 archival cases. These are coverage diagnostics, not estimates of full-sample precision.

B Variable Definitions and Descriptive Statistics

This appendix reports the two requested objects for each estimating sample: a variable dictionary and descriptive statistics. Binary-variable means are sample shares. "Missing" is measured relative to the unit and population named in each panel. The tables are generated directly from the same inputs and sample-building rules as the results reported in section 6.

B.1 Media Allocation

Table B1: Media Allocation Variable Definitions

Variable	Unit	Definition
$RunVar_i$	Candidate	Within-list, within-state vote-share margin to the marginal candidate on the opposite side of the official electoral cutoff.
$Elected_i$	Candidate	One when $RunVar_i \geq 0$; reproduces all 487 official 1986 winners in the analysis population.
$Concession_i$	Candidate	One for any radio or television grant in 1987–88 under the broad automated-plus-Motter linkage.
$Radio_i$	Candidate	One for at least one radio grant in 1987–88 under the broad automated-plus-Motter linkage.
TV_i	Candidate	One for at least one television grant in 1987–88 under the broad automated-plus-Motter linkage.
$Government_i$	Candidate	One for PMDB or PFL candidates in 1986.
$LeftOpposition_i$	Candidate	One for PDT, PT, PSB, PCB, or PCdoB candidates in 1986.
$RightOpposition_i$	Candidate	One for candidates in all remaining 1986 opposition parties.
Prior candidacy outcomes	Candidate	Indicators for running and winning in the 1982 federal-deputy election; missing histories are coded zero, as in the OLS specifications.
Prior media holdings	Candidate	Any, radio, and television grant indicators for 1983–86, entered as predetermined covariates.
1986 vote share	Candidate	Candidate nominal votes as a percentage of statewide nominal federal-deputy votes.

Table B2: Media Allocation Descriptive Statistics

Variable	N	Missing	Mean	SD	Min.	Max.
Running variable (p.p.)	2,606	0	-0.611	2.154	-10.410	42.679
Elected	2,606	0	0.187	0.390	0.000	1.000
Any concession, 1987–88	2,606	0	0.078	0.269	0.000	1.000
Radio concession, 1987–88	2,606	0	0.063	0.244	0.000	1.000
Television concession, 1987–88	2,606	0	0.023	0.150	0.000	1.000
Government party	2,606	0	0.437	0.496	0.000	1.000
Left opposition	2,606	0	0.225	0.418	0.000	1.000
Right opposition	2,606	0	0.337	0.473	0.000	1.000
Elected in 1982	2,606	0	0.183	0.387	0.000	1.000
Ran in 1982	2,606	0	0.314	0.464	0.000	1.000
Any prior media, 1983–86	2,606	0	0.043	0.204	0.000	1.000
Prior radio, 1983–86	2,606	0	0.035	0.183	0.000	1.000
Prior television, 1983–86	2,606	0	0.013	0.115	0.000	1.000
1986 statewide vote share	2,606	0	0.929	2.141	0.000	44.726

Notes: The population contains all 2,606 candidates with a defined 1986 running variable. Binary-variable means are shares. The main local RDD subsequently uses outcome-specific bandwidths.

B.2 Legislative Response

Table B3: Legislative Response Variable Definitions

Variable	Unit	Definition
$Loyalty_{i,j}$	Deputy–issue	Share of issue j's component votes cast by deputy i in the Executive's preferred direction under the current Results coding.
$Concession_i$	Deputy	One for any 1987–88 radio or television grant under the broad automated-plus-Motter linkage.
TV_i	Deputy	One for at least one television grant in 1987–88.
$RadioOnly_i$	Deputy	One for at least one radio grant and no television grant in 1987–88.
$NonIdeological_j$	Issue	One for the Presidential System or Five-Year Mandate issue.
$Ideological_j$	Issue	One for agrarian reform, strike rights, employment stability, working hours, or property rights.
$Government_i$	Deputy	One for PMDB or PFL deputies; $Opposition_i$ identifies all other parties.
$RunVar_i$	Deputy	Deputy's 1986 within-list, within-state vote-share margin to the electoral cutoff.
Prior radio and TV grants	Deputy	Separate annual concession counts for 1982–86. The descriptive table reports five-year sums; regressions enter each annual count separately.

Table B4: Legislative Response Descriptive Statistics

Variable	N	Missing	Mean	SD	Min.	Max.
Panel A: Deputy–issue observations						
Loyalty	2,006	0	0.637	0.381	0.000	1.000
Non-ideological issue	2,006	0	0.454	0.498	0.000	1.000
Ideological issue	2,006	0	0.546	0.498	0.000	1.000
Panel B: Deputies						
Any concession, 1987–88	455	0	0.233	0.423	0.000	1.000
Television concession	455	0	0.070	0.256	0.000	1.000
Radio-only concession	455	0	0.163	0.369	0.000	1.000
Government party	455	0	0.767	0.423	0.000	1.000
Opposition party	455	0	0.233	0.423	0.000	1.000
Running variable (p.p.)	455	0	1.704	3.276	0.001	42.679
Prior radio grants, 1982–86	455	0	0.053	0.321	0.000	3.000
Prior television grants, 1982–86	455	0	0.042	0.567	0.000	9.000

Notes: Panel A uses the 2,006 deputy–issue observations in the current direction-dependent Results benchmark. Panel B uses the 455 distinct deputies represented in that panel. Deputy-level variables are not repeated to inflate their descriptive weight.

B.3 Electoral Advantage

Table B5: Electoral Advantage Variable Definitions

Variable	Unit	Definition
$Concession_{i,t+1,t+4}$	Winner–cohort	One for any new self- or relative-linked radio or television concession during the electoral term after origin election t.
$MediaOwner_{i,t}$	Candidate–cohort	One for any self- or relative-linked concession observed from 1982 through origin election t.
$Ran_{i,t+4}$	Winner–cohort	One when the official electoral record reports a federal-deputy candidacy four years after origin election t; missing records are coded zero.
$Elected_{i,t+4}$ (OLS)	Winner–cohort	One when the official electoral record reports election to the Chamber four years after origin election t; missing records are coded zero.
$RunVar_{i,t}$	Candidate–cohort	Origin-election within-list, within-state vote-share margin used by the pooled RDD.
$Elected_{i,t+4}$ (RDD)	Candidate–cohort	One when the next-election running variable is observed and nonnegative; otherwise zero, as in the heterogeneous RDD.
Origin cohort	Candidate–cohort	Origin election 1982, 1986, 1990, or 1994; the corresponding outcome elections are 1986, 1990, 1994, and 1998.

Table B6: Electoral Advantage Descriptive Statistics

Variable	N	Missing	Mean	SD	Min.	Max.
Panel A: Origin-election winners (OLS)						
Term concession (flow)	1,811	0	0.107	0.309	0.000	1.000
Media owner (stock)	1,811	0	0.120	0.325	0.000	1.000
Ran in next election	1,811	0	0.708	0.455	0.000	1.000
Elected in next election	1,811	0	0.461	0.499	0.000	1.000
Panel B: Candidates with an origin running variable (RDD)						
Origin running variable (p.p.)	9,172	0	-0.555	2.088	-19.001	42.679
Elected at origin cutoff	9,172	0	0.215	0.411	0.000	1.000
Media owner (stock)	9,172	0	0.081	0.272	0.000	1.000
Elected at next observed cutoff	9,172	0	0.096	0.294	0.000	1.000

Notes: Panel A is the 1,811-observation common OLS sample after removing singleton year–state and year–state–party cells. Panel B is the 9,172-observation candidate panel used by the heterogeneous RDD. The two panels operationalize the next-election outcome exactly as the corresponding tables in section 6 do.

Online Appendix I

Historical Evidence

Not for Publication

C Contemporary Newspaper Evidence

Table C1: Representative Politician-Broadcasters, 1979–2000

Politician	UF	Main office(s)	Party (NCA)	Broadcasting outlet(s)
Antônio Carlos Magalhães	BA	Minister of Communications (1985–90); Governor; Senator	PFL	TV Bahia (Globo affiliate) and Rede Bahia
José Sarney	MA	President of Brazil (1985–90); Senator	PMDB	Sistema Mirante (TV, AM, FM, held through children)
Arnon de Mello / Fernando Collor	AL	Senator; Governor; President of Brazil (1990–92)	PMDB	Organizações Arnon de Mello (TV Gazeta, Rádio Gazeta FM)
Edison Lobão	MA	Senator; Minister of Mines & Energy	PFL	Sistema Difusora (Rádio and TV Difusora, Rádio Guajará, Rádio Imperatriz)
Jáder Barbalho	PA	Governor; Senator; Minister of Agrarian Reform	PMDB	Grupo RBA de Comunicação (RBA TV, Rádio Clube do Pará, Rádio Cabano)
Inocêncio Oliveira	PE	President of Chamber of Deputies (1993–95)	PFL	Rádio A Voz do Sertão (Serra Talhada)
Orestes Quércia	SP	Governor (1987–91); Senator	PMDB	Grupo Sol Panamby (Luzes da Ribalta AM, Nova Brasil FM network)
Marcondes Gadelha	PB	Minister of Communications (1989–90); Senator	PFL	Sistema Regional de Comunicação (FM Souza, AM Esperança)
João Alves Filho	SE	Governor; Minister of Interior	PFL	Rádio FM Jornal (Propriá, Aracaju, Estância)
Odacir Soares	RO	Senator	PFL	Rádio Clube de Rolim de Moura; Rádio Planalto; Rádio Sociedade Rondônia
Tasso Jereissati	CE	Governor; Senator	PMDB	Sistema Verdes Mares (TV Verdes Mares Globo affiliate, Rádio Verdes Mares AM/FM)
Rita Furtado	RO	Federal Deputy	PFL	Rádio Amarela, Rádio Nequem FM, Rádio Verde, Rádio Colina, Rádio Tucumi

Notes: Twelve politicians holding federal elected office during the 1986–1990 National Constituent Assembly period for whom broadcasting ownership is documented in one or more of the following: the concession registry reconstructed by Motter et al. (2019) from Ministry of Communications archives; the ownership audit of Lopes (2018); and the official biographies of the Federal Senate, the Chamber of Deputies, and FGV–CPDOC. "Party (NCA)" is the party affiliation at the 1986 election. "Broadcasting outlet(s)" lists the principal station or media group associated with the politician and/or their immediate family; many of these are registered formally under spouses, children, or business associates rather than under the politician's own name. The table is illustrative rather than exhaustive; the empirical analysis treats the full population of candidates as described in Section 4.

This appendix presents contemporary newspaper material illustrating two central features of the institutional environment surrounding the National Constituent Assembly (NCA): (i) the political salience and discretionary nature of broadcast concessions, and (ii) the sharp decline in President José Sarney's popularity following the post-election collapse of the *Plano Cruzado*.

Figure C1 reproduces a front-page story from *Folha de S. Paulo*, published on November 15, 1988, describing the political allocation of radio concessions in the state of Bahia. The report describes how the Minister of Communications, Antonio Carlos Magalhães, distributed radio broadcasting licenses to political allies.



ACM dá concessões de rádio a seus "amigos" na Bahia

BOB FERNANDES

Janio de Freitas

Zero mais zero

Casal recebe 6 rádios

Senadores fizeram CPI

AS CONCESSÕES DE RÁDIO EFETUADAS POR ACM PARA A BAHIA*

Figure C1: Contemporary newspaper story documenting the distribution of radio concessions to political allies in Bahia.

Notes: Front-page story from *Folha de S. Paulo*, November 15, 1988. The article describes how Minister of Communications Antonio Carlos Magalhães distributed radio broadcasting licenses to political allies in the state of Bahia during the NCA period.

Figure C2 presents a compilation of newspaper headlines from *Tribuna da Imprensa*, *Jornal do Brasil*, and *Folha de S. Paulo* documenting the rapid deterioration of President José Sarney's popularity following the November 1986 elections. These stories highlight the abrupt resurgence of inflation, increased political pressure on the executive, and internal divisions within the governing coalition. This environment is consistent with the main-

text discussion that the government entered the NCA with limited political capital and relied heavily on individualized legislative bargaining.



Figure C2: Newspaper headlines illustrating the post-election collapse of the *Cruzado* plan and the resulting decline in presidential popularity.

Notes: Compilation of headlines from *Tribuna da Imprensa*, *Jornal do Brasil*, and *Folha de S. Paulo* documenting the rapid deterioration of President Sarney's approval ratings following the November 1986 elections. The stories document the resurgence of inflation and internal divisions within the governing coalition that increased the Executive's reliance on individualized legislative bargaining during the NCA.

D Contentious Votes in the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly

This appendix documents the procedure used to assemble and classify the voting records of the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (NCA), and provides background on the key legislative issues used in the empirical analysis. We relied on the official historical archive maintained by the Brazilian Chamber of Deputies, including the "25 anos da Constituição" digital collection.[17] All vote tallies, roll-call sheets, and government statements in this appendix come directly from these primary sources.

Data construction and coding procedure

The NCA voting records are preserved in heterogeneous formats, including scanned PDF documents, typed lists, and transcribed minutes. To convert these materials into a structured dataset, we implemented a multi-step workflow:

1. **Digitization via OCR.** Original roll-call sheets were processed using Optical Character Recognition (OCR) tools. Manual inspection ensured accuracy in names, vote options, and abstention codes.

2. **Name standardization.** Deputy names were standardized using a Stata/R cleaning routine that harmonized spelling variations, abbreviations, married names, and typographical inconsistencies. These standardized names were merged with the 1986 electoral registry to uniquely identify each deputy.

3. **Vote classification.** Each voting session was examined to extract the possible voting options (e.g., *Sim*, *Não*, *Abstenção*, *Obstrução*). When different abstention types

[17] Available at: https://www2.camara.leg.br/atividade-legislativa/plenario/discursos/escrevendohistoria/25-anos-da-constituicao-de-1988/momentos-marcantes-da-constituinte.

appeared, they were harmonized to a single "abstain" category.

4. **Government position coding.** Using official transcripts of the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (NCA), we identified the Executive's stated position for each roll-call vote. Government floor leaders—particularly Deputy Mário Covas—publicly announced whether the Executive supported or opposed each amendment or motion. Based on these declarations in the plenary records, each roll-call was coded as "government *FOR*" or "government *AGAINST*."

5. **Deputy-level loyalty index.** For each deputy i, topic t, and roll-call v, we coded:

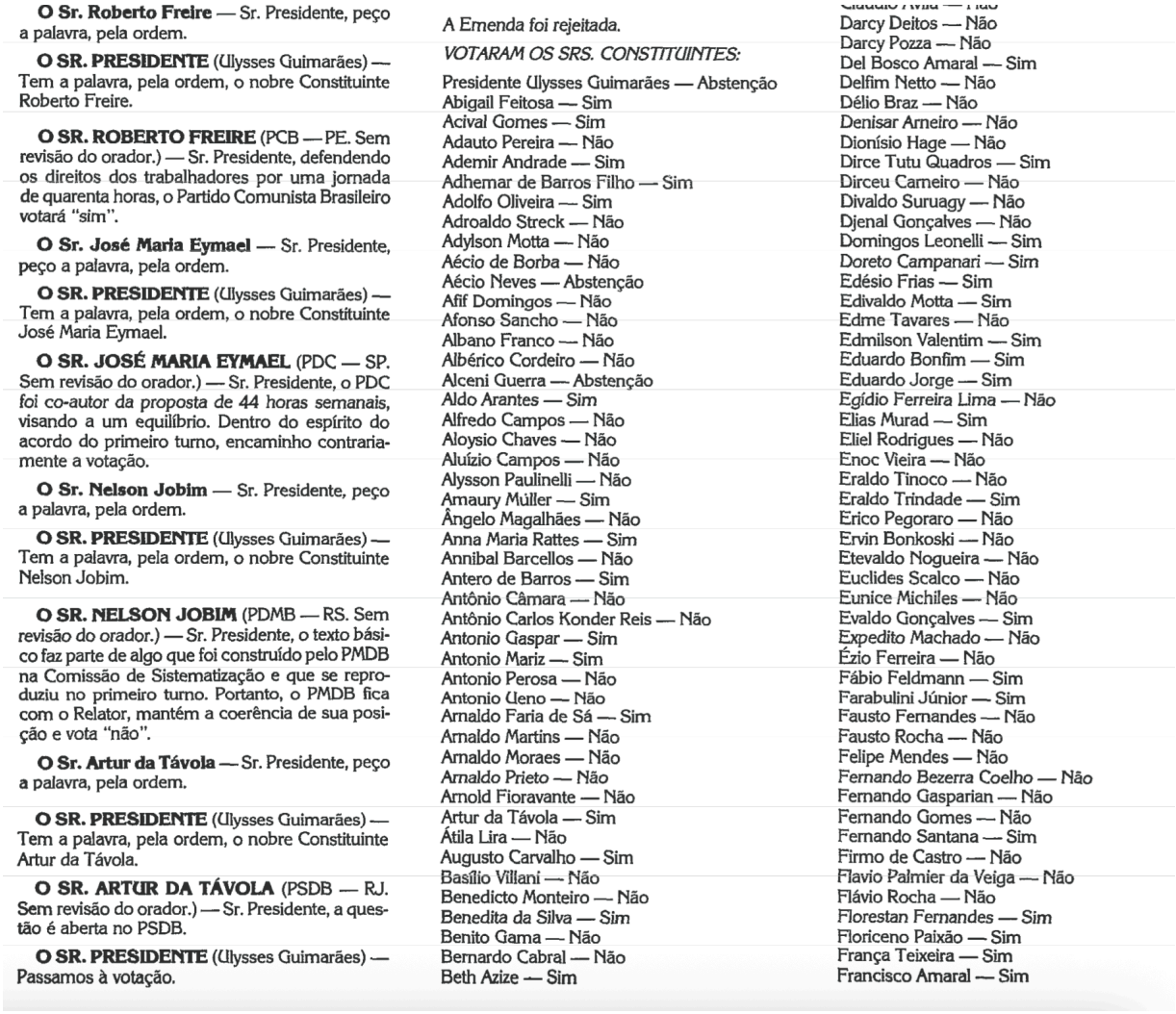
$$Loyalty_{ivt} = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if pro-government vote,} \\ 0, & \text{if anti-government vote.} \end{cases}$$

Abstentions were coded according to the "expected action" implied by the government's stated preference (e.g., an abstention counted as opposition when the government needed an affirmative vote). For each deputy–topic pair, we then averaged $Loyalty_{ivt}$ across all votes v belonging to topic t:

$$Loyalty_{it} = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{v=1}^{N_t} Loyalty_{ivt},$$

yielding a measure of alignment between 0 and 1 for each deputy and each substantive issue debated in the Assembly.

The resulting dataset contains a harmonized panel of deputies $\times$ key topics, enabling the empirical analysis reported in Section 5.



O Sr. Roberto Freire — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.

O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte Roberto Freire.

O SR. ROBERTO FREIRE (PCB — PE. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, defendendo os direitos dos trabalhadores por uma jornada de quarenta horas, o Partido Comunista Brasileiro votará "sim".

O Sr. José Maria Eymael — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.

O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte José Maria Eymael.

O SR. JOSÉ MARIA EYMAEL (PDC — SP. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, o PDC foi co-autor da proposta de 44 horas semanais, visando a um equilíbrio. Dentro do espírito do acordo do primeiro turno, encaminho contrariamente a votação.

O Sr. Nelson Jobim — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.

O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte Nelson Jobim.

O SR. NELSON JOBIM (PDMB — RS. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, o texto básico faz parte de algo que foi construído pelo PMDB na Comissão de Sistematização e que se reproduziu no primeiro turno. Portanto, o PMDB fica com o Relator, mantém a coerência de sua posição e vota "não".

O Sr. Artur da Távola — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.

O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte Artur da Távola.

O SR. ARTUR DA TÁVOLA (PSDB — RJ. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, a questão é aberta no PSDB.

O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Passamos à votação.

A Emenda foi rejeitada.

VOTARAM OS SRS. CONSTITUINTES:

Presidente Ulysses Guimarães — Abstenção
Abigail Feitosa — Sim
Acival Gomes — Sim
Adauto Pereira — Não
Ademir Andrade — Sim
Adhemar de Barros Filho — Sim
Adolfo Oliveira — Sim
Adroaldo Streck — Não
Adylson Motta — Não
Aécio de Borba — Não
Aécio Neves — Abstenção
Afif Domingos — Não
Afonso Sancho — Não
Albano Franco — Não
Albérico Cordeiro — Não
Alceni Guerra — Abstenção
Aldo Arantes — Sim
Alfredo Campos — Não
Aloysio Chaves — Não
Aluízio Campos — Não
Alysson Paulinelli — Não
Amaury Müller — Sim
Ângelo Magalhães — Não
Anna Maria Rattes — Sim
Annibal Barcellos — Não
Antero de Barros — Sim
Antônio Câmara — Não
Antônio Carlos Konder Reis — Não
Antonio Gaspar — Sim
Antonio Mariz — Sim
Antonio Perosa — Não
Antonio Ueno — Não
Arnaldo Faria de Sá — Sim
Arnaldo Martins — Não
Arnaldo Moraes — Não
Arnaldo Prieto — Não
Arnold Fioravante — Não
Artur da Távola — Sim
Átila Lira — Não
Augusto Carvalho — Sim
Basílio Villani — Não
Benedicto Monteiro — Não
Benedita da Silva — Sim
Benito Gama — Não
Bernardo Cabral — Não
Beth Azize — Sim

Darcy Deitos — Não
Darcy Pozza — Não
Del Bosco Amaral — Sim
Delfim Netto — Não
Délio Braz — Não
Denisar Arneiro — Não
Dionísio Hage — Não
Dirce Tutu Quadros — Sim
Dirceu Carneiro — Não
Divaldo Suruagy — Não
Djenal Gonçalves — Não
Domingos Leonelli — Sim
Doreto Campanari — Sim
Edésio Frias — Sim
Edivaldo Motta — Sim
Edme Tavares — Não
Edmilson Valentim — Sim
Eduardo Bonfim — Sim
Eduardo Jorge — Sim
Egídio Ferreira Lima — Não
Elias Murad — Sim
Eliel Rodrigues — Não
Enoc Vieira — Não
Eraldo Tinoco — Não
Eraldo Trindade — Sim
Erico Pegoraro — Não
Ervin Bonkoski — Não
Etevaldo Nogueira — Não
Euclides Scalco — Não
Eunice Michiles — Não
Evaldo Gonçalves — Sim
Expedito Machado — Não
Ézio Ferreira — Não
Fábio Feldmann — Sim
Farabulini Júnior — Sim
Fausto Fernandes — Não
Fausto Rocha — Não
Felipe Mendes — Não
Fernando Bezerra Coelho — Não
Fernando Gasparian — Não
Fernando Gomes — Não
Fernando Santana — Sim
Firmo de Castro — Não
Flavio Palmier da Veiga — Não
Flávio Rocha — Não
Florestan Fernandes — Sim
Floriceno Paixão — Sim
França Teixeira — Sim
Francisco Amaral — Sim

Figure D1: Example of original roll-call voting sheets used to construct the NCA legislative dataset.

Notes: These documents were obtained from the official archive of the Chamber of Deputies. All sheets were digitized using OCR, manually reviewed, and linked to the 1986 electoral registry after name standardization.

Contentious topics

Below we summarize the substantive content, ideological cleavages, and government positions on the seven major issues analyzed in the paper. All descriptions draw on the Chamber of Deputies' official historical records.

Agrarian Reform. Agrarian reform was among the most ideologically polarized issues of the NCA. Central to the debate was the principle that rural property must fulfill a "social function," determined by rational land use, environmental compliance, labor protections, and worker welfare. Highly contentious motions concerned whether non-compliant properties could be expropriated, how compensation would be structured (e.g., debt bonds), and whether productive properties should be shielded from redistribution. The government generally supported measures enabling expropriation and institutionalizing the social function requirement, but it faced defeats on amendments seeking to remove protections for productive properties.

Right to Strike. The right to strike generated intense debate, especially regarding civil servants and essential services. Proposals ranged from broad constitutional guarantees to more restrictive formulations limiting the scope of lawful strikes. The government consistently backed measures that upheld the general right to strike and worker participation in strike-related regulation while opposing amendments that would impose significantly narrower interpretations or constraints, particularly for public-sector workers.

Job Stability. Discussions on job stability centered on balancing worker protection with employer flexibility. Deputies debated the constitutionalization of dismissal rules, safeguards against arbitrary layoffs, and the conditions under which stability could be overridden. The government supported moderate protections but opposed amendments introducing rigid dismissal constraints. Government-supported provisions were approved,

whereas more restrictive motions failed.

Working Hours. Working-hour regulation generated conflict between groups advocating stronger labor protections and those pushing for greater flexibility. Key proposals included establishing an eight-hour workday and reducing the weekly limit from 48 to 44 hours, while permitting compensatory arrangements. Conservatives opposed more rigid proposals, such as the six-hour daily limit; these failed. Government-backed amendments allowing compensatory flexibility passed, while stricter proposals were rejected.

Property Rights. Property rights debates addressed the tension between constitutional guarantees of private property and the possibility of regulation for public interest. Proposals included unconditional property guarantees, limitations for legal non-compliance, and protections against arbitrary expropriation. The government's position varied: it opposed unconditional guarantees but supported conditional regulatory mechanisms, though these often failed to pass due to insufficient support.

Presidential System of Government. The vote on Collective Amendment 1830—the proposal affirming presidentialism as Brazil's system of government—concerned the fundamental architecture of executive power. President Sarney and the government leadership articulated a clear preference for presidentialism over a parliamentary alternative, making this an institutional item on which the Executive held a unified public position. We code a deputy as government-aligned when they voted for the proposal affirming presidentialism and include this vote in the Non-Divisive (institutional) index alongside the five-year presidential term.

Length of Presidential Term. The length of the presidential term was one of the most politically charged issues. President José Sarney and conservative allies pushed for a five-

year term, citing institutional stability. Progressive factions advocated for a four-year term to force earlier elections. These groups viewed a shorter term as a chance to break with the unpopular Sarney administration and open space for political renewal. Amendments proposing shorter terms were rejected, and the five-year mandate prevailed.

Empirical specification. The deputy–issue alignment scores constructed here are the outcome of the legislative-response regressions; the estimating equation is (10) in section 5, and the estimates are reported in section 6.